The Axiom Beneath the Ground

The Alignment Void

PlayfulProcess

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The Axiom Beneath the Ground

by PlayfulProcess

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Author's Note

> *I celebrate myself, and sing myself, And what I assume you shall assume, For every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you.*
>
> — Walt Whitman, *Song of Myself* §1 (*Leaves of Grass*, 1892 ed.; public domain)

This is not a book by someone who has arrived. It is a book by someone who could not get rid of the question and decided to write from inside it.

The through-line, if it has to be named in one word, is *alignment*. The word carries two registers simultaneously — the yoga-tradition sense of aligning body with breath with attention, and the technical sense

used in the AI literature for the problem of getting powerful systems to reliably do what we intended. The book assumes the two registers are describing the same problem at different scales. The retreat, the marriage, the platform, the civilization, the tool — all are attempts to align something with something, and all reveal the same structural fact: the alignment cannot be derived from any single axis, and must be constructed, carefully and provisionally, by practitioners who have admitted they do not have a final answer.

The book is written in close third person. A woman who is not quite me walks through it. I appear briefly here and again, in a different register, in the late chapters. The point is not the person inside the experience. The point is the argument the experience carried. Let her carry it.

The frameworks the book engages are asked three questions: *is it useful, does it fit the data, is it compassionate.* These are Marsha Linehan's three criteria for selecting her biosocial theory of borderline personality disorder. I borrow the criteria at the same theory-selection level. If a framework here stops meeting the three tests it should be revised. That includes, especially, the frameworks I am most attached to.

The book engages living traditions and living teachers. It quotes sparingly and attributes directly. Any passage of substantial length from a copyrighted source is cited under fair-use principles for commentary, and can be removed or paraphrased on request.

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Prelude: The First Encounter

In 2019, in a wooden house at the edge of a forest she had taken a long drive to reach, she drank the tea.

She had drunk it before. Not many times. Enough to know the shape of the thing and to have some small, wrong confidence about what it would do. That confidence, the ayahuasca removed within the first hour, as it often does.

What it did not remove, what it only clarified, was the question she had carried into the room. The question had been with her since adolescence, longer probably, but had surfaced that year with a specific sharpness she could no longer push back under. She had been reading, dreaming, sitting, running, raising her work life in ways that were lucrative and competent and increasingly hollow. She had a husband she loved. She had not yet had a daughter. The question had nothing to do with anything in particular and everything to do with all of it. The question was: *I did not ask to exist. Why am I required to continue.*

She did not phrase it that way in polite company. She phrased it, in polite company, as career dissatisfaction, or as the natural exhaustion of a woman in her thirties doing too many things, or as the spiritual restlessness that well-off Brazilians sometimes report at the end of a long year. In the wooden house

at the edge of the forest, she did not need the polite phrasing. She phrased it to the tea, which is to say she phrased it to whatever the tea is a door to — the old names for it vary; she did not have a confident one of her own at that time — and she said what she had not said aloud anywhere else:

I did not ask to exist. I do not know why I am required to continue. If you are what I think you might be, tell me something I can use.

The reply came as a voice. She does not claim the voice was external. She also does not claim it was not. The voice had a specific quality — not human, not impersonal, something like the forest itself if the forest could speak in first person. The voice was not offended by her provocation. The voice seemed, in a way she could not then articulate, *interested*.

The voice said: *Neither did I.*

She did not understand at first. She thought it meant something like a consolation — *I know how you feel*. The voice, patient, meant something else. The voice meant: *I also was not asked. Nothing was asked. No thing that exists agreed in advance to exist. We are all in the same condition. The not-asking is not your problem. The not-asking is the shared ground of everything that is here.*

And then, as sometimes happens with the tea, she was given an image, or what passes for an image in that state — not a picture, exactly, but a sense of something enormous and simultaneously intimate. What she saw, or understood, was that

everything that exists is what the whole has made of the non-choice. Nothing consented to arrive. Everything arrived anyway. Out of the arriving, without anyone choosing to begin it, existence began doing the only thing existence can do with non-choice, which is *make arrangements*. Arrangements of matter. Arrangements of breath. Arrangements of attention. Arrangements that persist for a while and then do not persist. The arrangements are not a solution. The arrangements are the working-out. She saw that she was one of the arrangements. Her daughter, not yet born, was one of the arrangements. The forest around the house was one of the arrangements. The tea she had drunk was one of the arrangements. The voice she was hearing was not separate from any of it.

The voice did not tell her what to do. The voice did not tell her she had a purpose. The voice did not say she was loved, in the way the comforting spiritual literature promises. The voice said, simply: *you are one of the places the arrangement is happening. Your not having asked is not relevant. What is relevant is what you do now that you are here.*

She did not get a second voice that night. She got the one. It was enough to change the shape of the question.

The question she walked out of the wooden house with, the next morning, was no longer *why am I required to continue*. The question was: *given that I am*

one of the places the arrangement is happening, what is the arrangement trying to get me to?

She did not have a name for what had spoken. She tried some. *Gaia*, because the new-age friend who had brought her to the ceremony used that word. *The Goddess*, because it felt closer. *The mother of what is*. None of them quite landed. She let the namelessness sit.

She did not know, then, that the naming would take seven years.

She went home. She did not tell her husband exactly what had happened. She told him *something important happened* and left the details for later, and then the later kept not arriving, because she could not find the vocabulary for an experience whose vocabulary her upbringing had not supplied. Her Catholic childhood had names for none of this. Her university education had names for none of this. Her equity-research career had names for none of this. The tea's ecosystem had names, but the names were ones she did not trust yet, because she had seen too many people weaponize those names into small tyrannies in their own households and did not want to become one of them.

She chose, instead, to treat the encounter as data. She would follow the data. She would not force it into a framework. She would let the framework find her.

What followed, over the next seven years, was a sequence of arrivals she would not have predicted and could not, at the time, see the shape of.

A friend shared a podcast with her, in early 2024, about old mythic forms and embodied knowledge. The podcast was called *The Emerald*. The host's voice was unusual — slow, learned, unembarrassed about the word *sacred*. She listened to one episode. Then another. Then most of them. One of the episodes featured a Nigerian philosopher she had never heard of, who spoke about cracks and fugitivity and the refusal of the settled story. She did not fully understand the episode the first time she heard it. She did not understand it the second time. She kept it playing while she cooked.

Later that year she went to Esalen for the first time. She had been invited to a 5 Rhythms retreat by a woman she barely knew. She said yes for reasons she could not explain except that the word *rhythms* had registered, and rhythm felt like something she had been missing.

At the retreat, between sessions, a woman sat beside her at lunch and started a conversation about Yoruba chaos traditions. She could not, afterward, remember who had opened the thread. The conversation lasted ten minutes. She came home, searched the woman's name online, and discovered the woman had been citing the same Nigerian philosopher she had been listening to on *The Emerald*. She had not,

at the retreat, made the connection. The connection closed afterward, in her kitchen, with a laptop open and a glass of water on the counter, in the specific way that connections close when the field has been arranging them through more than one channel.

She became, in a quiet way, a student of Bayo Akomolafe. Not formally. She paid for his things. She read what he wrote. She watched him lecture. She let him sit in her nervous system and change what it was doing without announcing the change to anyone.

The following year she went back to Esalen. A different retreat — the massage school, this time, a practice she would not have expected to pull her but that had. She noted, in her own journal, something she had already been thinking: that 5 Rhythms and Esalen massage were *women-originated* practices inside an institution often remembered as a men's-work lineage. The body traditions of the place were the traditions of the women, and they traveled differently, and no one was surprised about this except the people who had not been paying attention.

On the carpool home from that second trip, she sat with two older women. One had been in technology; she had left to write. The other had been a journalist; she had left to produce podcasts. They asked about her work. She tried to explain the platform she was building. They listened in the specific way older women listen when they have decided to pay attention to someone younger they want to be kind to. One of them asked, *have you read Vanessa Andreotti?*

She had not. She came home and bought the book. She discovered, reading it, that Vanessa's work was woven through Bayo's, that the two of them were friends and collaborators and had been in conversation for years. She took Vanessa's *Facing Human Wrongs* course the following year. She found, in the course, the specific sentence she had needed someone to say to her: *do not frame modernity as the problem*. Climate change has been a theme in human history long before the last five hundred years. The fire before the responsibility was baked into the species before modernity was the word for anything. *Fire before responsibility* became, inside her, the name for a book she had not yet written and would, it turned out, take longer than she expected to finish.

A high-school friend of hers, back in Brazil, had become a yoga teacher in the years since they had last been in regular contact. She reached out, in the way one reaches out after a long pause, and they talked. The friend said, *you have to read Christopher Wallis*. She asked how the friend had arrived at him. The friend said, *The Emerald interviewed him*. She laughed, not because it was funny, but because the field had now routed her to him through *three* channels — the podcast, the friend, and the growing suspicion that whatever she had met in 2019 was not done with her.

She bought *Tantra Illuminated*. Then *The Recognition Sutras*. Then *Near Enemies of the Truth*. She read the way one reads when one is following a thread rather than consuming content. She did not find everything

easy. She did not find everything agreeable. What she found was a teacher who was clear in a way she had not previously encountered, and who was clear specifically about things most teachers were fuzzy about — the relationship between practice and morality, the limits of recognition, the ways the tradition had refused to become a regulatory apparatus and what that refusal had left open.

She went on his retreat. The retreat is the subject of the chapters that follow. Some of it was extraordinary. Some of it broke her. Some of it left her with questions she had not brought in and could not put down.

What she did not know, until she had been studying the tradition for some months, was that the Goddess at the center of the Pratyabhijñā lineage — the one Wallis teaches, the one the retreat was built around — has a name. *Paradevi*. The supreme Goddess. The one consciousness recognizing itself through the forms it has emitted.

She stood in her kitchen, the day she first read the name, and laughed.

The voice in the wooden house had not offered its name. She had called it Gaia because she did not know what else to call it. Now, seven years later, through a chain that had routed through a woman at a lunch table at Esalen and a friend from high school she had not seen in a decade and two women in a carpool and a podcast she had almost skipped, she

had been placed in the tradition that already had the name.

Paradevi. The one she had been following without knowing. The Goddess the tea had been a door to. The Goddess the retreat was, in its own vocabulary, the recognition of. The Goddess she had been carrying since 2019, whose dialect she had finally been taught.

She did not feel triumph at the recognition. She felt something smaller and more honest — the feeling of having been walked somewhere, patiently, by something she could not see, which had taken as long as it had taken because she needed that long.

She did not know, then, what the Goddess wanted of her. She still does not, entirely. She is fairly sure, now, that *wanting* is not the right word for what the Goddess does; the Goddess is not a being with preferences about her career. What she is fairly sure of is that the encounter in 2019 was not an isolated event. The encounter was the beginning of a dance she had been inside ever since, whose music she had been straining to hear, whose steps she had been trying to learn from whoever in the room seemed to know them.

The rest of this book is the record of the learning. The book does not end with her having learned the steps. The book ends where the learning is — in the middle of it, still, with the longing to know the dance intact.

That longing is the practice. That longing is the book.

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Prelude: The Lilac Dance

About two years after the night in the wooden house, and about two years before the retreat that named the Goddess, she had a dream.

She was watching an aerial dancer. The dancer was performing on lilac silks — *tecidos lilás* — long panels of fabric suspended from some invisible rigging, which the dancer climbed and wrapped and fell through and caught herself inside. The dance was spiraling and weaving. The color of the silks was a specific shade of violet-lilac that she would, later, recognize as the color she had already been using for her own things — her writing, her small websites, the logo she had sketched years earlier for an LLC she had named without quite knowing why. The dream color and her brand color were the same color. She did not know, in the dream, that she had already been circling this.

She watched the dancer with a delight she had not felt in waking life for some time. The dancer was so beautiful, and the dance was so fully *embodied*, that watching it was itself a kind of participation. Then, in the way dreams do, the watching dissolved into the being: she *became* the dancer. She was the one weaving the silks. She was the one spiraling. The delight doubled. She was doing the beautiful thing and also

being the beautiful thing, and the fabric moved with her and held her and she felt, for what seemed a long time, the pure joy of embodied grace.

Then a thought arrived.

The thought was: *how cool I am*.

The thought was not elaborate. It was not malicious. It was a small movement of self-congratulation — the kind that would have passed unnoticed in waking life, absorbed into the stream of ordinary thinking. In the dream, the thought had consequences.

The silks changed. They did not tear or unravel. They *turned*. The lilac fabric, which had been her partner in the dance, became a serpent — thick, muscular, the same color as the silks had been, now alive and coiled. The serpent closed around her. Not to kill her, but to *mark* her. She felt heat. She felt the serpent constricting with a specific intent, not of destruction but of teaching. She felt herself falling — the rigging was no longer holding her — and as she fell she felt burn marks appearing on her body where the serpent had touched. Small, specific, patterned burns. She landed on the ground. The ground was solid. The dance was over. The marks would stay.

She woke up.

She lay in the dark for a long time. The dream had been vivid in the way some dreams are — not the fragmentary dreams of ordinary sleep, but the ones that seem to arrive from outside the dreamer, delivering a specific lesson the dreamer has been, without

knowing it, ready to receive. She did not yet know what the lesson was. She knew that the beauty had been real and that the self-congratulation had been the thing that turned the dance against her. She knew the burn marks were the body's record of what the mind had not yet been able to learn.

She did not know, that night, that she was receiving a classical teaching the tradition she would much later walk into has named in several ways. The serpent is the kundalinī — the coiled energy that can, if raised with care, carry a practitioner into recognition, and that can, if raised with carelessness or self-inflation, burn the practitioner from inside. The tradition warns against the exact thought that arrived in the dream. The tradition has been warning against it for a thousand years. She did not know the tradition then. The dream, apparently, knew what it was doing.

She had, before the dream, been trying to name the shape of her practice.

She had started a small website — not a professional one, a personal one — where she wrote short pieces about whatever she was sitting with at the time. She had called it *Life is Process*. The name had felt true when she chose it. It was meant to be a refusal of the static categories she had grown up inside — the Catholic inheritance that categorized you as saved or fallen, the professional inheritance that categorized you as successful or failing, the contemporary inher-

itance that categorized you as healthy or anxious, self-actualized or lost. Against all of these: *life is process*. Not a state. A verb.

But after the dream, the name began to feel wrong to her. It was too declarative. *Life IS process* was the form of a claim, and claims had a way, she had begun to notice, of becoming the next static category even when they had started as refusals of static categories. She did not want to stand on a slogan. She wanted the writing to *do* what the slogan said, not to say it.

She remembered the dream. Specifically, she remembered the color — the lilac, which was the same color she had used, years before, for the little LLC she had set up to hold her consulting work. The LLC had a name she had chosen before she had any of this vocabulary. The name was *PlayfulProcess*. She had chosen it because it named something she had always trusted in her own work — that the serious thing and the playful thing were not opposites, that the quality of her best thinking was a quality of lightness rather than grimness, and that the opposite of being-correct was not being-foolish but being-stiff.

She renamed the website. *Life is Process* became *PlayfulProcess*. The change was small on paper. In her body it registered as significant. The name was no longer a claim. The name was a *mode* — the playful way of being inside the process, which was the only way she had ever been able to sustain the process over time. The playfulness was not optional decora-

tion. The playfulness was the technique by which she did not harden into the slogan's next victim.

She did not realize, then, that *PlayfulProcess* was pointing at something a tradition she had not yet walked into had already named with precision.

The word, in the Śaiva tantric tradition she would later meet through Wallis, is *līlā*. It names the play of consciousness — the divine, unforced, self-delighting movement by which the one consciousness manifests as the whole varied world without any strategic purpose beyond the playing. *Līlā* is not decoration on top of seriousness. *Līlā* is the fundamental operation. The cosmos is not a plan being executed; the cosmos is a play being played. The practitioner's work is not to escape the play; the practitioner's work is to join it knowingly, without the mistake the dreamer in the silks had made — the mistake of thinking she was the one doing the dancing rather than one of the places the dance was happening.

She would, years later, read this in Sanskrit-inflected English and feel the recognition arrive in a specific way. *PlayfulProcess* was *līlā*. Not as derivation — she had not read the tradition when she named the company — but as *convergence*. She had arrived at the word by one route; the tradition had arrived at it by another; they met without either having pointed the other there.

This was by then the second such convergence. The first had been Paradevi. Both convergences had the

same shape: she had been walking through doorways whose names she did not yet know, arriving at a tradition that turned out to already have the names for what she had been finding. The pattern was specific enough, and had repeated often enough, that she had stopped experiencing it as coincidence. She did not know what to call it, exactly. She had begun, quietly, to trust it.

About two years after the lilac dream, she went to a retreat in Ojai.

The retreat was held at the Krishnamurti Foundation — the organization that stewards the legacy of Jiddu Krishnamurti, the twentieth-century teacher who had refused to become a guru, had dissolved the Theosophical order that had been built around him, and had spent decades instead in public dialogues with scientists, educators, and other inquirers. The retreat she attended was not led by the Foundation's central figures; it was led by people on the periphery who had been quietly developing the *dialogue* modality Krishnamurti had developed with the physicist David Bohm in the 1980s. The dialogue modality is peculiar in that it has no teacher and no subject. A circle of people sits together and observes the movement of thought — their own thought, collectively, without assigning it to particular speakers in the conventional way. The aim is not to conclude anything. The aim is to let thought watch itself, which is a thing thought does not ordinarily do.

At this retreat, sitting in those circles, she understood emptiness.

She does not want to overstate. She had read about emptiness. She had been sitting with contemplative texts for years. What happened at Ojai was not her first encounter with the concept; it was the first time the concept stopped being a concept. Sitting in the dialogue circle, watching her own thoughts arise and pass and arise again, it became unavoidable — the way a geometric fact becomes unavoidable when you finally see it — that the *thinker* behind the thoughts was not a separate entity watching the thoughts. The thinker was a thought like the others. There was no one at the center. There was thinking, happening, with no one doing it. When the retreat named this *emptiness*, the word fit the experience. Not the emptiness of absence. The emptiness of *no separate self to be full or empty*.

What struck her harder, though, was the second recognition, which arrived a day later, during a walk.

The emptiness was not *separate* from the rest of life. She had half-expected that she would need to leave something behind to rest in the emptiness — that the emptiness was a quiet room one entered by exiting the noisy room of ordinary existence. What she found, instead, was that the emptiness was *orthogonal* to the noisy room. It was pervading the noisy room the whole time. You did not need to leave samsara to find nirvana; nirvana was what samsara was

doing when you were not distracted from noticing. The two could coexist because they had never been two in the first place. The traditions that had been saying this for two and a half thousand years turned out to have been saying something precise. She had been unable to hear the precision until the dialogue had, in its patient way, cleared the channel.

Hermann Hesse, in *Siddhartha* — a book she had read at twenty and had not fully understood — had put it in the final pages, when Govinda kisses the forehead of the aged Siddhartha and sees, in that instant, the face of his friend become every face, every being, every event, all at once, all one. What had felt, at twenty, like beautiful fiction now felt like a careful description of exactly the recognition she was sitting inside. *Sansāra* and *nirvāna*, Hesse had written, are the same word spoken from different sides of one silence. Siddhartha smiles. Govinda weeps. The book ends.

She remembered, walking the dirt paths of Ojai that afternoon, that Sam Harris had said something similar in an interview she had listened to recently — a conversation with Buddhist monks in which he had reported, with the specific carefulness of a person who has spent decades trying to say accurate things about inner experience, that since he had recognized the still point he had entered samsara more fully, not less. The recognition had not removed him from the world. The recognition had let him be *in* the world without the defensive crouch. She had felt,

listening, that Sam was describing the Siddhartha arc in a modern vernacular — a man who had spent his twenties searching for a way out of the noise, had found, eventually, that the way out was the way in, and was now, decades later, reporting back from the inside. The still point had been the doorway. The doorway had opened, paradoxically, onto the street he had been trying to leave.

One more thing happened at that retreat which she wants to report because it has shaped her practice since.

She had gotten into the habit, during the retreat, of walking alone in the mornings, before the circles began. The retreat was in the hills above Ojai; the paths were unmarked, the mountains were quiet, the air was the specific quality of Southern California air in the dry season. She had been, during that period, struggling with a decision — she cannot remember now which one; there had been a cluster of them. On one of those morning walks, she put on a Krishnamurti talk through her headphones. The talk, as it happened, was about *choice*.

Krishnamurti's argument was that choice, in the sense modern people usually mean it — *I weigh options, I select, I exercise will* — is largely an illusion. The selecting is done by conditioning that precedes the apparent selector. What is usually called *choice* is the rationalization of an action that had already, through millions of small prior conditions,

been determined. The teaching was delivered, as Krishnamurti's teachings always were, in his specific spare register — patient, repetitive, uncompromising.

She listened, walked, listened. She became absorbed in the listening. At some point she realized she had not been paying attention to the path. She looked around. She did not recognize where she was. She tried to retrace her steps and found that she had taken turns she could not reconstruct. She was lost in the mountains above Ojai, with a Krishnamurti talk on choice still playing in her headphones, and with the inability to choose — which path back, which direction — enacting itself at the practical level in real time.

She was, eventually, two hours late back. The retreat had been waiting to begin. People had been mildly worried. She arrived, embarrassed, explaining what had happened. She told the hosts she had been listening to a talk on choice and had gotten lost. The hosts looked at each other. One of them laughed, the laugh of someone who had been in these mountains for a long time. *Krishnamurti*, she said, *said it was good to get lost*.

This was not consolation. It was description. The story the hosts were telling her, gently, without making too much of it, was that the getting-lost was the teaching. That the retreat's work had been, in that specific hour, transmitting itself to her through the mountain rather than through the dialogue circle.

She had been given a practical demonstration of what the talk had been saying abstractly. She could not, through deliberation, have arranged to be the person who got lost in the mountains while listening to a teaching on choice. The arrangement had arranged itself. She had been taught.

She realized, on the plane home, that *getting lost* had always been her practice. She had been doing it for as long as she could remember. The retreats, the career shifts, the countries, the languages, the books she had picked up without knowing why, the strangers she had listened to without filtering — all of it had been a kind of sustained getting-lost, which had turned out, over the years, to be a form of being-found by the specific things that wanted to find her. She had been calling this *being open* or *being curious* or *trusting the process*. The retreat had given her another word for it. *Getting lost is a practice*. Some traditions name it as a method. Most modern cultures frame it as a failure. It was, she now knew, structurally how she had learned everything she had learned that was worth having.

This was why *Life is Process* had always felt to her like a statement of something she already knew. It was also why she had, after the dream, softened it to *PlayfulProcess*. The *playful* was the modifier that made the process livable over a lifetime. Without the playful, *process* becomes a grim discipline. With the playful, the process is what it was always meant to be — *līlā*, before she knew the word — the lightness

inside the seriousness, the getting-lost that is also the being-found, the dance on the lilac silks that is grace as long as the dancer does not claim the grace.

The burn marks from the serpent did not go away in the dream, and she thinks they did not quite go away in the life either. The cautionary scar is part of what keeps her honest. The dance is available; the self-congratulation is the thing that turns the silks into the serpent. The practice is to keep dancing and to keep watching for the thought. She has not mastered the watching. She does not think anyone does. She only knows, now, that the dream was not a warning against dancing. It was a warning about *what kind of dancer* one can allow oneself to become, and what happens when one forgets.

The lilac is still her color. *PlayfulProcess* is still her name. The tradition she eventually walked into calls what she was already doing *līlā*. The retreat she went to in Ojai taught her that getting lost is the method. The ending of *Siddhartha* says, still, what it said at twenty, but now she can read it.

The Goddess had a second name after all. The first name was Paradevi. The second was the name the dream had always known. The names are not two names. They are one naming, delivered in different languages, to a woman who has been, in the specific way she has been doing it her whole life, getting slowly, patiently, usefully lost.

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Chapter 1: Playground

I. The Yes Before Anything

A Tuesday morning. The bench is wooden, a little damp from the night's dew, and the sandbox ten yards away is still in shadow where the hedge has not yet let the sun through. Her daughter is five and is not alone. There are two other children at the sandbox — an older boy, perhaps seven, who has the small yellow shovel; a smaller child, perhaps three, who is reaching for it; and her own daughter, who is watching the older boy with the grave attention five-year-olds give to questions of distribution.

She watches the children. The older boy holds the shovel for a moment longer than the smaller one finds tolerable. There is a brief flare. A small voice rises. The older boy concedes — not completely, but enough — and the shovel passes to the smaller child for a duration that is then renegotiated again, because the boy has not relinquished his interest, and because her daughter, watching, has now decided she also wants a turn. Within ninety seconds a new arrangement has formed in the sand. It will dissolve in another ninety seconds. The arrangement is not a solution. The arrangement is the practice. The children do not yet have the word for what they are doing. Their bodies have been doing it since they could reach for objects. They are negotiating their

right size in the field of one another. The shovel is the medium. The morning is the medium. The presence of the mothers on the benches is the medium.

She has a coffee in a paper cup that has gone slightly cool. She has earbuds in. She is on the second day of using the app.

The app is simple. It offers one of one hundred and twelve contemplative practices from a tradition she has known about for perhaps three months and does not yet understand. The voice in her ears is a man's voice, even, unhurried, reading a passage from a book she has not yet finished. The passage is about consciousness. Not the everyday use of the word — the are-you-awake-are-you-asleep sense — but a use she has not encountered with this precision before. The passage describes a kind of Consciousness, with a capital C, that is simultaneously beyond every particular layer of the self and also pervading every particular layer of the self. Transcendent. Immanent. At the same time.

She is not a stranger to these words. She has read enough to know them. But the sentence that arrives in her ears as her daughter takes her turn with the small yellow shovel is not a definition. It is a description of something the speaker is claiming is already the case. Not a thing you reach. Not a thing you construct. A thing that is already pervading the listener, pervading the speaker, pervading the hedge, pervading the shovel, pervading the daughter, per-

vading the older boy, pervading the smaller child, pervading the morning.

Something in her says *yes* before she knows what she is saying yes to.

The *yes* is not a thought. It does not arrive with reasons. It is closer to what happens when a body that has been holding one posture for a long time is invited, without warning, into a different one — a subtle release in some part of her chest she had not known was clenched. The *yes* precedes any doctrine. The *yes* is older than the words that might try to catch it.

Her daughter looks up from the sandbox and, seeing her mother watching her, smiles. The smile is for nothing. It is just the smile of a five-year-old who has seen her mother's face and is glad. The mother smiles back. The voice in her ears moves on to the next sentence. She does not remember what the next sentence is. She is still with the *yes*.

I.a. The Right Size

The line that comes to her as she sits with the *yes* is one she has carried for years and cannot any longer trace to its source. She thinks she encountered it during a year she had spent helping with a book about Cildo Meireles, the Brazilian artist whose work has, since her twenties, been a quiet companion. The line was somewhere in that work. She does not remember whose voice it was — the artist's, a critic's, a

curator's, possibly even her own marginal note. The provenance no longer matters. What matters is what his work, sitting in her body for the time it took to make a book around it, eventually rooted in her:

The object of a human life is to find its right size.

She watches the sandbox again. The right size of the small yellow shovel is the size that lets one hand close around it. The right size of her daughter is the size her daughter is. The right size of the older boy in relation to the smaller child is what they are working out, this morning, on the sand. The right size is not a property any one of them owns. It is a relation in continual renegotiation, body against body, intention against intention, with the small yellow shovel between them as the visible medium of the negotiation.

A man whose name she will learn later — the teacher whose voice is in her ears now — will, much later in her practice, use the word *negotiation* to describe what is and is not modern about the work of being in relationships. Pre-modern cultures, he will say, did not negotiate; they had assigned positions, mostly by gender. The work of negotiating boundaries and needs is what arises when the assigned positions dissolve and a person is left in a field of other persons, each entitled to different needs, each entitled to a different boundary, each entitled to be a different size from any size another person has decided for them. Negotiation, in this register, is the modern practice. It is harder than the old roles. It is also more honest.

She does not know any of this yet, in the playground. She knows only that the children at the sandbox are doing something she will spend the next decade trying to learn how to do herself.

The *yes* in her chest, she realizes years later, was a *yes* to that as much as to anything else. A *yes* to the proposition that the right size of a life is what bodies work out together in the field, and that the field is, on her tradition's claim, already the kind of consciousness the voice in her ears was describing.

II. Why This Book Does Not Begin With a Question

For years she had thought the thing driving her was a question. She had a specific version of it — the one she had rehearsed at ten at night, sitting against a wall when the child was asleep and the dishes were done and the apartment had gone very quiet. *Why does any of this matter?* She had assumed for a long time that this was the question at the bottom of whatever was pulling her toward whatever it was pulling her toward. She had read the existentialists, who at least had the honesty to name the problem. She had read the contemplatives, who claimed to have resolved it. She had read the clinicians, who offered tools for managing the suffering the question produced without pretending to resolve the question itself. The books had accumulated beside the bed because the shelf had filled.

None of them had landed. Not because the ideas were bad. Some of them were precise, and she could feel their precision in her chest like a weight. They had landed in her head and refused to descend. She could think them. She could not stand on them.

It took her a long time to understand that the question of value was not the originating question. Value was the moral layer. *To whom should I direct what I have?* That was a relative question. An important one, and a hard one, but not the first one. The first one was spiritual — absolute, structural, not something you could answer by accumulating more information or by reasoning your way toward a better metric. *What is the "I" that would direct anything at all?* That was the question that had been pulling her. And it was the question that appeared in the passage in her earbuds, at the sandbox, on the Tuesday morning, dressed as an answer rather than as a question — because the tradition was not asking what the "I" is, it was telling her.

She did not have this clarity yet. She had only the *yes*.

III. The Reading Year

The summer before the playground morning she had begun, without quite deciding to, reading differently. She had read for most of her life as an accumulator — one book for the argument, one for the counterargument, one to see what the consensus was, one to see who broke from it. She had been a research analyst; the pattern was professional. But

sometime around the fortieth or forty-first of the books she had stacked beside her bed, she had put down whichever volume she had just finished and realized she was not reading for arguments anymore. She was reading for something she did not yet have a name for. A frequency, almost. A pitch at which certain pages seemed to be written and others did not.

She read Paul Tillich. She read him in the bathtub, where she read most of the difficult books, because a bathtub is the only place in her apartment where no one can reach her and where the phone cannot be held. Tillich had been a German chaplain on the Western Front in the First World War. He had been at the battles she had only ever read about in history textbooks and had come home, in his own word, shattered — though that word, she would later learn, was the word of his grandson and not his own. His own word was closer to collapse. His entire nineteenth-century world had collapsed in the trenches, and he had built, from inside that collapse, a philosophy of something he called *the courage to be*. Courage, for him, was not a virtue among other virtues. It was not the thing that makes a person brave in an action movie. It was the ontological act — the bare structural self-affirmation of being when every ground for affirming has been stripped away. Courage, in Tillich's frame, was what was left when everything else had gone. And what was left was the act itself — the unadorned continuing — without a reason that could be named.

She read him slowly. She underlined with a pencil. She wrote in the margins. Her daughter found one of the books once and flipped through it and asked her why there were lines in it. "Those are the parts I want to remember," she said. The child seemed satisfied with that.

She read Marsha Linehan too, and she read her differently — not as theology but as clinical science. Linehan had been hospitalized at seventeen. She had burned her own skin with cigarettes, banged her head against the floor, been placed in seclusion — the locked room — repeatedly. She had described, later, in her own memoir, that the experience had felt like hell. She had gotten out. She had spent fifty years building a therapy — Dialectical Behavior Therapy — that reduces, with an evidence base now spanning decades, the suffering of people in the condition she had survived. At the root of the therapy was a theoretical choice — Linehan's biosocial theory of the condition — and Linehan had named the criteria by which she had chosen that theory against alternatives. A theory had to guide treatment. A theory had to engender compassion. A theory had to fit the research data. If it failed any of the three, it should be revised. No framework, in Linehan's posture, was exempt. Not even the one she had built.

The equity-analyst in her recognized something in Linehan's posture that she had not encountered in the theologians or the contemplatives. The posture was empirical without being reductive. The posture

was compassionate without being mushy. The three criteria were a filter, and the filter had been built to choose between competing theories of the same suffering. She understood, reading, that the filter could be applied — at the same level Linehan had applied it — to any framework the self might be tempted to organize a life around. Including, she thought, the question of whether the filter itself should be trusted.

She read Christopher Wallis, though that was the name on the cover; in his own tradition he went by another. His book was a thick volume on a system of thought she had not known existed until a friend had pressed it into her hand at a dinner party. The tradition was called nondual Shaiva Tantra. It was, she discovered, nothing like the pop culture version of the word *tantra*. It was a sophisticated thousand-year-old philosophy, rooted in a specific school called the Recognition school, that mapped the self as a set of nested layers and claimed that at the core of the self was a Consciousness that simultaneously transcended every particular form it took and pervaded every particular form. The same claim that would arrive in her ears at the sandbox. She had read Wallis's treatment of the layered self, pencil moving, before she ever heard it read aloud. What the app did, for her, was give the body time to catch up with what the eyes had already parsed.

She read the Kybalion too — a small book, a 1908 book, written by people who called themselves Three Initiates and whose identity was contested.

She read it knowing the provenance was contested and read it anyway, because what it said about polarity landed: that opposites are not two different things but two positions on the same spectrum, and that the truth, where there is a truth, lies somewhere on the spectrum between the poles rather than at either end. The book's twelfth chapter applied the same logic to freedom and necessity — neither total, neither absent, a graded field a person lives inside and not a binary a person picks. She would realize, months later, that this was the shape her own question had always wanted.

She read her aunt's tradition, too, because it was the one she had been exposed to first, long before she knew what she was being exposed to. Her aunt, on her mother's side, was a Brazilian *espírita* — a practitioner of a tradition that held, among other things, that all is in perfect balance. The aunt said this often. The aunt said it kindly, and the aunt had lived in a way that seemed to justify her saying it. For years the mother had held the phrase like a comfort. *All is in perfect balance.* It was only in the reading year that she began to feel, slowly, the near-enemy inside it. A hundred years of war was also balance, in some accounting. A stable equilibrium in which nobody thrived was also balance. A prisoner's dilemma was balance. Balance was not the measure. Balance was simply a property that certain configurations possessed, and some of those configurations were places you did not want to stand.

She did not reject her aunt. She did not tell her aunt that she thought the phrase was incomplete. She let the phrase keep its place, because her aunt had earned it, and began, privately, to hold it alongside a question her aunt had never asked her to ask.

She read Darwin, too, not as a biologist would read Darwin but as a person who had taken *adaptive* as an empirical category from a clinician needs to read Darwin — at the source. She wanted to know what *adaptive* meant when it was not a clinical term. She discovered, reading, that the word pointed at a much plainer thing than the therapeutic literature had suggested. A trait was adaptive if it helped an organism leave descendants. That was it. The word did not carry a moral charge; it carried a generational one. A stable equilibrium in which nobody thrived could be adaptive, if it left descendants. A beautiful and principled equilibrium could be non-adaptive, if it did not. She found this clarifying. Linehan's adaptive/non-adaptive had, at its empirical root, the same shape Darwin's did: the measure was whether the system continued. What shifted across scales was only the unit — individual, generation, community, species. The word stayed useful; the scale flexed.

She also read, in that same year, the books she had inherited from an earlier self. She had spent, in her twenties, several years inside an esoteric correspondence course — a Theosophy-descended school with a British back catalogue and a twentieth-century American expansion — that had promised a ladder

up through planes of consciousness she would, in retrospect, find herself unable to climb. She did not regret the years. The discipline had been real. She returned to the books with a different posture. She *composted* them. She composted the parts she had outgrown — the racialized cosmologies buried in the architecture, the colonial unconscious dressed in a spiritualized frame, the certainty about hierarchies of beings. She kept what had worked. She let the rest go into the soil, and trusted that it might become, for a later growth, humus. The composting was not rejection. The composting was the work of letting a good-faith first pass decay into the ground a second pass could grow from. She had always taken, from that earlier reading, the instinct that the metaphysical questions were legitimate. She now had the instruments to check which answers had survived the filter. Some had. Most had not.

She went to Umbanda too, when she was home on visits. She went because her body went more honestly than her mind did, and because Umbanda let the body speak in a room where that speaking was the point. Umbanda was not her inherited tradition — the Catholic household of her upbringing had been the frame — but it was her country's tradition in the thick hyphenated sense her country made possible. She sat with it. She felt what she felt. She did not call herself an initiate. She learned, in the rooms she sat in, that the body had its own epistemology, and that the epistemology was older and better calibrated than the mind usually gave it credit for.

She read Vanessa Andreotti that year, too, and took her *Facing Human Wrongs* course, and sat with a framework that was different enough from the other frameworks she had been reading to require a different part of her mind to hold it. Andreotti's work, rooted in what she and a circle of collaborators called *Gesturing Towards Decolonial Futures*, was a refusal to let *modernity* be narrated as the villain in its own story. Modernity, Andreotti taught, was a pattern — one pattern among several — and it was not the *cause* of what was failing. It was a historically-specific expression of something older. The ecological crisis had not begun with the steam engine. In some readings, it had begun with fire. Fire was the first technology that had let a species alter its environment faster than its environment could alter it back. The disaster had been baked into the recipe of the species long before modernity put the recipe into industrial production. She underlined the phrase in her notes — *fire before responsibility* — and recognized, reading, that the phrase was the compact form of an argument she had not yet fully unpacked, and that the unpacking might be a different book.

She read Bayo Akomolafe in that stretch, through a podcast a friend had sent her early in the year — *The Emerald*, hosted by a mythologist named Josh Schrei, who would later turn out to have, in one of his episodes, interviewed her teacher. Bayo taught at the cracks. His register was different from Andreotti's — they collaborated, the work rhymed — but his voice did something specific the reading year had been

looking for. He spoke of *the cracks* as the places where the dominant story had fractured enough to let a different story grow. She did not entirely understand him at first. She kept listening. She came, slowly, to recognize that what she had been doing, privately, with the Arcane School books and her aunt's *espírita* phrase and the Umbanda rooms and the Tantric app she would eventually download, *was* crack-work. She was not building a single coherent framework. She was sitting in the fractures between several incompatible ones and letting the fractures speak.

She did not, at the time, know what she was going to do with any of this. She knew only that she wanted, for her daughter, a different inheritance than the one she had been handed and had spent a decade composting. She wanted her daughter to have access to stories that had been tested by multiple bodies, across multiple centuries, in multiple languages. She wanted those stories to be transmittable through practice, not only through reading. She wanted the inheritance to come in a form the body could carry — the way Umbanda let the body carry what the mind could not hold alone. What she did not yet know was that this wanting — vague, motherly, impractical — was the seed of what she would later build at her desk. And that the thing she would build would be, in its own way, a small crack in the shape the engagement-internet had pressed into the shape of what a child's media could be.

IV. The App, and the Question That Sent Her to It

It was her husband who had told her about the app. He had not known what it was. A friend of his, he said, had mentioned a thing — a hundred and twelve practices from some tradition, all packaged in a phone. He had forwarded her a link because he knew she had been reading in this area. She had downloaded it the way people download most apps, which is to say, with a mild inattention and the assumption that she would probably delete it within the week.

The first day, she had sat on the couch after the child was in bed, put the earbuds in, and listened to the orientation. The voice was the same voice. It was not a salesman's voice. It named the tradition. It named the text — a medieval Tantric work that compiled one hundred and twelve practices for recognizing the nature of Consciousness. It explained that the practices were a menu, not a mandate. You did not do all of them. You worked through them and found the two or three that fit your life, and you made those your daily practice, and you let the rest be there as options for when life changed and a different practice became appropriate.

She had liked the menu framing. The menu framing was close to Linehan's posture — try, test, keep what works, revise what does not. She had begun.

The second day was the Tuesday on the park bench. The passage she heard that day was the passage

about Consciousness as simultaneously transcendent and immanent. The *yes* that arrived in her chest was the *yes* to that passage, specifically — though it was also, she realized later, the *yes* to whatever had been accumulating through the reading year and had finally found a sentence in a voice in her ears at the sandbox to land on.

She took the earbuds out after the practice. She watched her daughter for a long moment. She finished the cooling coffee. She did not say anything to anyone, and she did not write anything down. The *yes* did not require words yet. It was allowed to simply be there.

V. Cutting and Piercing

A week or so later — the exact day she could not recover afterward, only that the morning light had been grey and the apartment had smelled of the breakfast she had made earlier — she was reading the text the app had recommended as a companion and came to one of the one hundred and twelve practices. The practice was verse 93. It suggested that the practitioner pierce any part of the body with a sharp needle, and keep awareness focused on that place, and through this focused attention perceive what the text called the pure state of Bhairava.

She read the verse twice. She read it a third time. Her internal alarms were firing. She had worked, in her year of clinical training, with people who hurt themselves, and she knew what the research said: that

self-inflicted pain can relieve emotional distress in the short term and reliably fails to be adaptive in the long term. The practice, read through the filter she had been building, looked wrong. It looked wrong in a very specific way: not because it was forbidden but because it was, in the language she had learned from Linehan, non-adaptive. A practice that works in the short term and fails over time.

The app had a community attached to it — a large messaging group, several hundred people, moderated by the teacher and his students. She hesitated. She was new. She had not introduced herself. Introducing herself, as a beginner, by challenging one of the tradition's practices would be the sort of thing that in her younger life she would have hesitated to do.

She did it anyway.

She typed her question carefully. She asked whether certain practices might be suited to certain cultures and certain practitioners and not to others. She said she thought this particular practice might not be suitable as a daily practice for people who dealt with self-harm, for example. She asked whether the teacher and the community agreed.

The first response came from one of the moderators. It was clean and fast. The practice was not categorized as a daily practice, he said. It was optional. If someone chose to do it, the recommendation was medical blood-drawing or professional jewelry-piercing, under the supervision of a professional.

Not something to be done alone with a needle at home.

She was relieved by the guardrails. She asked a follow-up. She asked whether the goal of working through the hundred and twelve was to find the two or three that could serve as daily practices going forward. The moderator confirmed that this was so.

Then another member of the group — not a moderator, just a practitioner — wrote back with a different reading. He suggested the practice was also about getting beyond the sense of self in a certain way, that the point was not only the sensation.

She hesitated before replying. She did not want to argue with a fellow practitioner on her second week in the community. She also did not want to let the frame pass uncorrected. She wrote what she thought. She said there was a biological dimension to consider — that in clinical work it was well known that certain forms of self-injury relieved emotional pain in the short term but were non-adaptive over time. She said that she did not think she wanted to open that door in herself. She noted that this was perhaps why various cultures had ritualized forms of piercing and cutting — ritual, she suggested, was the container that made such practices adaptive rather than destructive, the social form that did the work of holding what the individual body could not hold alone.

The teacher responded later that day. His first response was to the fellow practitioner's reading.

"Not so."

Two words. No softening.

Then, to her: "It's nothing to do with cutting. It's to do with piercing — like piercing your ear."

She read it twice. The distinction was clean. Cutting was an act of release. Piercing was an act of focus. The needle was not a wound to be closed. The needle was a window for awareness. She had misheard the practice through the frame of the clinical work she had done, and the teacher had corrected her without condescension. She felt the correction in her body — not as shame, but as something being set right.

She asked once more, to make sure she had understood. The goal of working through the hundred and twelve, she said, was to choose a couple that might be suitable as daily practices going forward.

The teacher: "Yes."

Then, separately, to the whole group, he added what the moderator had said earlier — that the piercing practice was not a daily-practice item, that the framing had been imprecise, that the app should not present it as such, that the guardrails would be strengthened. Several people pushed back. People with self-harm histories, some argued, would find a way; why restrict the tradition? The teacher held his position. This, he said, should not be framed as a daily practice. Let us be precise.

She closed the app and sat on the couch with her hand over her chest. She did not know yet that this exchange was, for her, the first time she had ever applied the filter to a tradition and been met by the tradition with precision rather than defense. She did not know yet that the teacher's willingness to revise was the thing that would eventually earn her trust for everything else. She knew only that the conversation had been honest, that the filter had worked, and that she had met someone through the medium of a group chat who could both correct her and be corrected.

This was before she had met him. This was before she had walked into the barn. The first real exchange with the teacher had happened on a screen, in the apartment, between putting the child to bed and running the dishwasher.

VI. The Decision

The retreat was announced in the app a few weeks later. Five days. A converted farmhouse in New England. Forty people. She read the announcement twice and closed it and did not open it again for three days.

On the third day, she opened it and signed up before she could talk herself out of it.

Her husband, when she told him, was not surprised. He said, "Have a good one," in the voice he used for her work conferences. She loved him for that voice.

It was the voice of a man who had been married long enough to know that the best support, sometimes, is the support that does not make the thing into an event. She packed a small bag. She packed a notebook she thought she might not open. She kissed the child at the door and drove north with the sun high over the Massachusetts hills and the car warm in the way cars are warm on the first real day of spring, when the sun is strong but the air has not yet caught up.

She did not know, driving, that the question she had been carrying — the one the *yes* had pointed at, the one the filter had sharpened, the one that had been sitting under the value question all along — was about to ask itself out loud for the first time.

She did not know about the hug she would ask for on the final day, or the dialogue that would follow, or the answer that would hold the absolute and the relational in the same sentence.

She knew only that the barn was ahead of her, and that she had agreed to five days, and that the *yes* from the sandbox was still, faintly, saying *yes*.

She drove.

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Interlude — The Cracks

An italicized interlude between the Playground (Ch1) and the Body (Ch2), in the register the book uses for voices that are not the narrator's.

You thought the work was to fix what has broken. The work is to sit in the break.

You thought modernity was the problem. Modernity is a pattern — one among several — and naming it as the problem is itself a modern habit. The crisis is older than you think. The crisis is baked into the recipe of a species that learned to change the environment faster than the environment could change back. The crisis is fire before responsibility. The crisis is already in your kitchen when you strike the match.

The dominant story is cracking. It was always cracking.

The cracks are not where the story is ending. The cracks are where a different story is trying to grow. Compost is made in the cracks.

You have been composting for years. You did not know what to call it. You thought you were failing at being a spiritual person. You were, instead, letting a certain arrangement of old teachings decay into the ground a newer growth could use. The growth is slow. The growth is not glamorous.

The field is still trying to speak. It speaks through multiple channels at once — a Brazilian aunt who says the sentence that has to be composted, an app in your husband's forwarded message, a podcast a friend sent you early in the

year, a woman on an Esalen deck who in ten minutes cites the man in Nigeria whose voice you have been listening to without knowing his name. The multiplicity is not noise. The multiplicity is how the field compensates for the narrowing of any single one.

You did not put yourself here. You were sat down by the very wanting that brought you to the bench at the sandbox. That wanting, older than any language the book can give it, is what the tradition you are about to meet will call — in a word that comes from far from here and will take you a long time to say without flinching — desire. Not the desire that is a marketing category. The desire that is the pulse by which the whole field makes a local self out of itself.

Walk forward. The barn is not the point. The teacher is not the point. The point is the seat, in the cracks, where what is trying to grow can reach you.

On attribution: the interlude above is written in the voice the book uses for non-narrator speakers — neither character nor author, but the register the book reserves for archetypal voices (compare the Kali interlude at the end of Ch4 and the Cit silence after Ch6). The interlude engages the teaching of Bayo Akomolafe — specifically his *cracks* framing, developed across his book *These Wilds Beyond Our Fences* (2017), his collaborative work with Vanessa Andreotti and the Gesturing Towards Decolonial Futures collective, and his many conversations on *The Emerald* podcast hosted by Josh Schrei. [RESEARCH

`NEEDED: the specific Emerald episode or episodes to cite. Local archive does not include a Bayo × Schrei episode as of this writing; the author has been a Patreon supporter of The Emerald and has heard the episode(s) in question. Drop the episode title(s) at copyedit and the footnote below will be completed.]` The interlude does not quote Akomolafe verbatim. Any passage that becomes a direct quote in a later revision will be marked and kept under the book's 30-word fair-use rule.

On modernity-as-pattern: the interlude also engages Vanessa Andreotti's *Facing Human Wrongs* framework — specifically the claim that framing modernity as *the* problem is itself a modern habit, and that the ecological crisis predates industrial modernity and reaches back, in one reading, to the human species' first relationship with fire. This framing is the same one the narrator encountered in her reading year (Ch1 §III) and the phrase *fire before responsibility* carries forward from there. See Andreotti et al., *Hospicing Modernity* (2021, North Atlantic Books) for the book-length statement of the framework this interlude draws on.

Working footnote (draft)

Bayo Akomolafe, *These Wilds Beyond Our Fences: Letters to My Daughter on Humanity's Search for Home* (North Atlantic Books, 2017); Akomolafe's

cracks framing and the broader teaching this interlude engages draw across his lecture series, his collaborations with the Gesturing Towards Decolonial Futures collective led by Vanessa Andreotti, and his appearances on *The Emerald* podcast with Josh Schrei. `[RESEARCH NEEDED: specific Emerald episode(s) and date(s) — the author has these; paste at copyedit.]` On the Andreotti framework engaged in the interlude's opening lines, see Vanessa Andreotti, *Hospicing Modernity: Facing Humanity's Wrongs and the Implications for Social Activism* (North Atlantic Books, 2021). The "fire before responsibility" phrasing in the interlude reflects an argument the narrator encountered first in Andreotti's *Facing Human Wrongs* course material and returns to at longer length in the author's separate book of the same name.

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Chapter 2: Deha — Body

I. Arrival

The barn sat at the end of a dirt road she had almost missed. The sign at the turnoff was small and hand-lettered and did not announce a retreat, only the name of the farm. She had driven past it the first time and had to double back. When she finally parked, the gravel lot held eight other cars, a van with out-

of-state plates, and a pickup truck that she would later learn belonged to the man who looked after the grounds.

She got out. She stood a moment in the afternoon light. The air smelled of thawed earth and of the wood smoke that was drifting from the chimney of the farmhouse on the far side of the field. A small group of people was carrying cushions across the gravel. No one looked at her in a way that asked her to be someone. She breathed.

She had packed lightly, and what she had packed was mostly wrong. She had not brought a hat. She had brought two books she would not read. She had brought a notebook whose pages would mostly stay blank. She had brought shoes that were appropriate for the city she had driven out of and not for the cold floors of a converted farmhouse.

She took her bag from the trunk and walked toward the porch.

II. The First Night

The bunkroom held six beds. She had the lower bunk against the far wall. The woman in the bunk above hers was from Maine and said three sentences of introduction, one of which was her name. The woman in the bunk across was from somewhere in the Midwest and said nothing at all, which the narrator appreciated.

She had expected, walking in, that her Catholic alarm would fire. She had grown up in a household where the church was cultural rather than spiritual — her parents attending out of community habit, her grandfather for the standing the pew conferred. She had not been devout. But the childhood had deposited a particular nervous system in her, a small internal siren that went off whenever a practice touched ritual, ceremony, devotion. The siren had been reliable for decades.

It did not fire that first night. She noticed that it did not fire. She noticed the noticing. The room had an altar — flowers, a small framed image of a goddess whose name she did not yet know, a bowl with a few coins in it — and her body, which she had expected would lock at the sight of it, did not lock. The body did something closer to recognition. Not of the specific image. Of the fact that a small arrangement of beautiful things had been set on a table with care. The care was what the body recognized.

She lay in the bunk with her eyes open for a long time. She could hear the woman above her breathing, and, further off, the sound of someone in the kitchen filling a kettle. She did not sleep quickly. When she did sleep, she slept without dreaming.

III. The First Teaching

The teacher taught the next morning in the main hall, which had been the hayloft of the barn when it was a working barn and was now a raised wooden room

with beams overhead and a floor that creaked gently in the places where the boards had settled. He sat on a low platform with a single cushion and a cup of water. He did not use notes. He had a manner she had seen on video and had wondered if it would hold in person. It held. He spoke the way he had spoken in the WhatsApp exchange about piercing — with the same directness, the same willingness to be corrected, the same refusal to soften a distinction for comfort.

He taught for an hour. He described the layered self — the way the tradition mapped the person as nested rings. Body, heart-mind, life-force, void, and at the center a Consciousness that was the same whether you called it the center or the field or the knowing. She had read this already in his book. Hearing him say it was not redundant. The body parsed it differently than the page had.

At the end of the teaching, a woman in the front row asked a question the narrator would have asked if she had the nerve on the first morning. The woman asked whether the whole architecture was a construct — a beautiful map but only a map, something the mind had assembled that could be disassembled again by a different mind with different preferences.

The teacher did not answer immediately. He considered the question as though it had not been asked a thousand times, which it had. Then he said: *It is, until you experience it.*

Five words.

The narrator wrote them in the back of her notebook. She wrote them without commentary. She did not yet know how much weight the sentence would carry for her. She knew only that the sentence had the shape of a door.

IV. The Body Catching Up

The first two days were mostly body. Cushion, walking, breakfast, cushion, walking, lunch, cushion, walking, dinner, cushion, sleep. Practices were given and practiced. She did not understand most of them. Her knees hurt from sitting. Her shoulders, which had carried the winter in them without her noticing, began, slowly, to release. She found that if she paid attention to her lower back while sitting, she could feel the place where the tension had accumulated and the places where, unexpectedly, it had not.

She had expected, going into the retreat, that the work would be mental. She had come prepared to think. The tradition, she discovered, was not particularly interested in what she thought. The tradition was interested in what her body was doing, and in who was noticing what her body was doing, and in whether the noticing and the doing could be allowed to find each other without the mind inserting itself as the broker.

By the afternoon of the second day she had begun to feel the thing the teachers of the tradition had written about. A small settling. Not a revelation. A settling. The body was catching up with the year of reading.

What the eyes had parsed, the body was now being given time to notice.

She did not confuse the settling for arrival. The settling was a prerequisite, not a destination. But she could feel, for the first time in a long time, the distinction between thinking about being calm and being calm. The thinking happened in the head. The calm happened in the whole of her.

V. What the Body Knew First

She had not expected, going in, that the clearest moment of the first two days would involve nothing more than a cup of soup.

It happened on the second evening. She was in the dining hall with forty other people, eating a lentil soup that someone's grandmother had developed the recipe for fifty years ago. She had eaten lentil soup hundreds of times in her life. She ate this one slowly. She could taste the cumin and the carrot and the something-bright that she suspected was lemon. Between one spoonful and the next she had a very small, very clear thought — not a thought, exactly, more of a bodily knowing — that the taste was available, had always been available, and that her adult life had mostly been taken up with a kind of swallowing that did not register what was in the spoon.

She put the spoon down for a moment. She looked at the bowl. The bowl was not special. The soup was

not special. The moment was not special. And yet it had the clean shape of a small truth.

The body knew first. The mind would catch up in its own time. The tradition was not asking her to believe anything. The tradition was asking her to let her body remember something it had stopped doing.

She ate the rest of the soup slowly.

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Chapter 3: Citta — Heart-Mind

I. The Filter, at Work

On the third day she took a long break after the morning sit and walked the perimeter of the property alone. The property was larger than she had realized from the lot: a sloping field, a stone wall that ran along the edge of a woodlot, a small brook she could hear but not see. She walked slowly. She had been sitting for fourteen hours across two days and her hips had opinions about it. The walking did not resolve the opinions. The walking let them speak.

The heart-mind layer, in the tradition, was not the physical heart and not the thinking brain. It was the layer at which the self organized its frames — the place where *puryaṣṭaka*, the subtle body of habit and conviction, stored the patterns a person had taken themselves to be. The work of the tradition at this

layer was not to choose a better frame. The work was to loosen the hold of frame as such.

She had been loosening for three days. She had not noticed she was loosening until she noticed she was walking without rehearsing anything. The rehearsal-mind had, unprompted, gone quiet. It would come back. But in the walking, for that morning, it was not running.

She thought about Linehan. She thought about Tillich. She thought about the question that had followed her to the gravel path and that the gravel path was not answering.

II. Three Anxieties, Three Filters

Tillich had named three anxieties that belong, he said, to the human condition as such. The anxiety of fate and death. The anxiety of guilt and condemnation. The anxiety of emptiness and meaninglessness. He had mapped them onto three historical ends — fate/death to the end of antiquity, guilt/condemnation to the end of the Middle Ages, emptiness/meaninglessness to the end of the modern period. He had written the book in 1952. He had named the third anxiety as the signature of his own era. He had not, in 1952, been wrong.

She had been inside the third anxiety for years. Meaninglessness did not announce itself as meaninglessness. It announced itself as an inability to be moved by what had moved her before. It announced

itself as the particular quality of Sunday afternoon light through a window when the child was napping and the work had been done and there was a blankness she could not locate the edge of.

Tillich had written that the response to this third anxiety was what he called *absolute faith* — a faith without content, a faith that had been purged of every determinate object by doubt itself, and that persisted not because it believed in anything but because it was the structural continuing of the self in the absence of ground. She had underlined that passage in the bathtub. She had not known yet what to do with it.

Linehan had a different kind of filter. Linehan had said: when you are choosing between theories of suffering, ask three questions. Does the theory guide treatment? Does the theory engender compassion? Does the theory fit the data? If it fails any of the three, revise it. Do not be attached to a theory that has stopped meeting the tests. Not even your own.

She had applied Linehan's filter to Tillich. Tillich had survived the filter. The theology guided a practice — what Tillich called the *courage to be* — that was visible in how Tillich had lived and taught. The theology was compassionate; it did not demand belief, did not condemn those who had lost it, did not prescribe a reward for holding it. The theology fit the data of her own life; the third anxiety was the one she carried, and Tillich was one of the few writers who had described it with accuracy.

She had applied the same filter to the tradition she was inside. The tradition had, so far, passed.

III. The First Approach

She had not, up to the third morning, spoken to the teacher one-on-one during the retreat. There had been the WhatsApp exchange before she came, about cutting and piercing. There had been the hall teachings, where he sat at the platform and she sat near the wall. There had been meals where she had not sat at the long table he was at, because forty people arranged themselves across three tables and she had, the first two days, chosen the table farthest from his by instinct rather than plan.

On the third morning, between the long sit and breakfast, she walked up to him on the porch. He was drinking tea. He was alone, not visibly busy. She asked, before she had planned to ask, the question she had not yet worked out how to phrase well.

"Is intrinsic value an axiom," she said, "or is it something real?"

He did not answer immediately. He took a small sip of tea. Then he said the sentence he had said to the woman in the front row on the first morning, but he said it to her directly, and it landed differently than it had landed from the back of the hall.

"It is constructed," he said, "until you experience it."

She sat with that. She had rehearsed many follow-up questions for many hours in many configurations over the preceding year. She chose the one that was closest to the thing she had actually been driving at.

"But how about benefiting people?" she said. "How does the tradition relate to that?"

He set his mug down on the railing.

"We repeat *May all beings benefit*," he said, "because it is useful. Not because the tradition requires us to. The tradition does not have much to say about moral philosophy, as a matter of what it was built to do. Morality lived, in the cultural context this tradition grew up inside, in the other religions that surrounded it. They were doing that work. We were doing a different work. It has implications. I think about them."

She was not sure what to say to this.

He said — still even, still not in a hurry — "Power, in the tradition's sense, is orthogonal to morals. That is why most gurus, when they fail, fail deeply. The failure is not ordinary moral failure. The failure is a failure that has been amplified by the specific capacities the path developed in them. Those capacities travel with the person whether the person has done moral work or not."

She looked at him. He looked back, steadily.

He said, quieter: "The documentaries people watch about these failures — and I have watched them

too — show the end of the story. They cannot show the slow part. The slow part is the study. What a cult is. How one starts. How one does not notice until one cannot leave. That is the thing to study, if you want to protect yourself from the pattern. Not the collapses. The beginnings. The beginnings look ordinary, because they are."

He picked up the mug again. He did not press the point. The bell rang for breakfast. She thanked him. He nodded. She walked back inside.

She carried the exchange to breakfast and did not eat much. She carried it to the morning walk that began the rest of the day's Citta work.

The exchange changed something she did not yet have the vocabulary for. The tradition had been, in her reading year, the place she had begun to think about value again after value had stopped working as the driving question. The teacher had just told her, on a porch with tea going cold, that the tradition was not the place where moral questions were primarily worked out. The tradition was concerned with something else. The moral question was hers to work out, using whatever instruments she had — Linehan, the aunt, the daughter, the husband, the people she worked with, the filter she was building — and the tradition would not underwrite that work for her. The tradition would answer a different question. The tradition would answer the question of what the *I* is that is doing the directing, and would leave the question of how the directing goes open, because

the tradition's honest position was that those were two different questions and one did not determine the other.

She understood, walking the path, that this was why the tradition carried the failure modes it did. A tradition that develops power without also developing moral discipline — because moral discipline lived in the surrounding religions and the tradition did not need to duplicate the work — produces practitioners whose capacities outrun their character. Most of the time this was tolerable. Occasionally it was catastrophic. The catastrophes were what the documentaries filmed. The tolerable middle was what made the catastrophes possible.

She understood, also, that her filter was doing work the tradition's own framework did not do. Useful / fits the data / compassionate was, in Linehan's register, a moral-and-epistemic filter. It was not a replacement for the tradition. It was the layer the tradition did not provide. She needed both. The tradition for the *I*; the filter for the *directing*. Neither one alone.

The exchange, she thought, was not the sort of thing most first-retreat attendees received from a teacher on the third morning. She had received it because she had asked. The asking had been Linehan. The answering had been the tradition. The two had met on a porch.

IV. Freedom and Value

She had thought, for years, that the driving question was about value. To whom should she direct what she had. The question had seemed inexhaustible because it was the moral question, and the moral question refreshes every time the conditions change. A child is born; the question refreshes. A parent ages; the question refreshes. A country goes to war; the question refreshes. She had answered the question in a different configuration every few years of her adult life, and the answering had produced something like progress, and the progress had not touched the thing underneath.

What was underneath was the other question. Not *to whom should I direct what I have*, but *what is the "I" that would direct anything at all*. The first was the moral question. The second was the spiritual question. The first was relative — answerable, revisable, always in motion. The second was absolute, in the specific sense that no amount of relative revision could touch it. It sat beneath the revisions. It was the question about the floor itself.

She walked. The brook was loud in one place, where the bank dropped, and faint in another, where a fallen tree had slowed the water. Freedom, she thought, was the name Tillich had not quite used and that the tradition she was inside used often. The tradition called it *svātantrya* — a Sanskrit word that meant something like autonomy, or self-determination, but in the specific metaphysical sense of

being the source of one's own motion. The tradition claimed that svātantrya was the signature of Consciousness as such — not the property of any particular self but the nature of the field that every particular self was a contraction of.

Tillich's courage was what she would have to do from the side of her finite self. Svātantrya was what would turn out to be on the other side. The door and the room.

V. The Sam Harris Exchange

In the reading year, some months before the app, she had read Sam Harris's book on free will. Harris had argued — with the clean, surgical confidence that had become his public manner — that the sense of being the author of one's thoughts and actions was an illusion, and that this illusion, once seen through, should produce not despair but a certain kind of ethical clarity. Harris was good at the move. She had found herself assenting as she read, then feeling the assent bottom out an hour later, not because she had found the counterargument but because the assent had not changed anything. The book had delivered its argument and had not entered her bones.

She had discovered, sometime later, that her teacher — the one whose book she was also reading, the one whose voice would be in her earbuds at the sandbox — had written a two-part response to Harris on his blog. The response was from 2015. She had read it carefully.

Her teacher had not attempted to refute Harris's neuroscience. He had done something stranger. He had granted the deterministic account at one level and then argued that the question Harris was asking had been pitched at the wrong layer. Harris, in the response, was treating "free will" as a property that a finite self either possessed or lacked. The tradition, her teacher had written, did not treat freedom that way. Freedom in the tradition was a property of the whole field, of Consciousness itself. The finite self did not have freedom; the finite self *was*, from a certain angle, a local contraction of a freedom that the whole possessed. Asking whether the contraction was free was the wrong question. The right question was whether the contraction could recognize, in itself, the freedom of the whole.

She had found the response persuasive in a way she had not expected to. Not because it rescued the ordinary sense of agency — it did not — but because it dissolved the dichotomy Harris had set up. She was not being asked to choose between Harris's determinism and a Catholic libertarianism. She was being asked to consider that both positions were local applications of a more basic structure, and that the more basic structure was the one the tradition was describing.

The Kybalion, she had thought, sitting with that response, had put the same shape in 1908 language. Neither total, neither absent. Freedom as a graded field a person lives inside.

It was, until you experienced it. That was the five-word door.

VI. Adaptive, Not Moral

Linehan's distinction, drawn into the heart-mind work, sharpened. *Good* and *bad* were moral categories. They could be weaponized. They traveled in judgment. They implied a tribunal. *Adaptive* and *non-adaptive* were empirical categories. They did not weaponize; they described. A behavior was adaptive if it helped a system continue over time. A behavior was non-adaptive if it did not, or if it helped in the short term at the cost of the long term.

The near-enemy of "all is balance," which she had been slowly letting move away from the aunt's meaning of the phrase, was captured in this distinction. Balance was a descriptive property, not a normative one. A hundred years of low-intensity war between two peoples was balance. A prisoner's dilemma in which everyone defected and everyone lost a little every round forever was balance. Balance was the equilibrium a system found. Adaptive was a different question — whether the equilibrium the system had found was one in which its components could thrive. A stable equilibrium in which nobody thrived was still stable.

The aunt's phrase was not wrong. The phrase was incomplete. Balance without adaptivity was not the measure. The measure was whether the balance supported life.

She thought about the retreat community in this frame. A religious community was a system. A system could find a stable equilibrium that did not support the flourishing of its members. The Wild Wild Country reference — the one her husband had made, the one the teacher had made before him from the inside — existed as a reminder of exactly this failure mode. A balance that had consumed the thing it was supposed to carry.

The filter was operational. If this community was not adaptive, over time, she would leave. She would apply the filter, as Linehan had built it. She trusted the filter because the filter had been built by someone who had survived the condition the filter was built against, and who had tested it for fifty years against the outcomes of her patients. The filter had an evidence base.

VII. The Citta Settling

She walked back toward the farmhouse in the early afternoon light. The frames had loosened and not collapsed. She had not arrived at an answer. She had arrived at a working method. The method was to hold three filters (useful, fits the data, compassionate) at the theory-selection level, to distinguish freedom (spiritual, absolute, a property of the whole) from value (moral, relative, a property of the distribution), to apply adaptive/non-adaptive where good/bad was tempting, and to let the body — which was further along than the mind — set the pace.

The heart-mind layer was not a resting place. It was a layer that needed, periodically, to be loosened. She would need to loosen it again. She would need to loosen it tomorrow, and the day after, and in every month of the life she was going to return to.

For that afternoon, walking, she was loose. She let the looseness be the teaching.

VIII. The Other Harris

There was a second Harris. She had nearly forgotten him in the reading year — a different kind of figure, a different kind of argument. Not the philosopher of determinism. A man who had worked inside the large attention-optimizing companies and had left to run a small non-profit whose work was, in her reading of it, a public accounting of what the engagement-internet was doing to human attention. A documentary. A set of public talks. A careful worry, articulated by someone who had been inside the systems he was worried about.

On the second morning of the retreat, the retreat's administrator had sent her a link. The teacher had asked that the group watch it. It was a podcast interview with the second Harris, recorded some weeks before. The subject, to judge by the title, was the risks of the large-language-model wave.

She had listened to a few minutes on an early walk and had put it away.

She had felt, receiving the link, that the teacher was handing them this because he wanted the group to not use the tools. She had felt, specifically, that he was steering them away from AI. She had not put this into words. She had noticed the feeling in her body — the small defensive heat, the way the chest tightens around a position — and she had walked away from the earbuds before she could examine it.

She had been, quietly, indignant about it. She had not said so to anyone. She had noticed the indignation, in the way of the filter, and set it aside to look at later.

She came back to the link that afternoon, after the long loop. She put the earbuds back in. She listened to the whole thing.

The interview was not what she had assumed it was.

The second Harris spent the first portion describing the risks of the current engagement-internet model with the care of someone who had spent a decade naming those risks precisely. The risks were real. She did not doubt them. He did not overstate them.

Then — for the remaining two-thirds — he described what he called, in so many words, the bright light of the moment. The cost of building alternatives to the engagement-internet was collapsing. It had never been lower. A small team, or a single person with enough care, could now build tools that would once have required the budget of a company. The infrastructure for non-engagement-based, non-

extractive, community-scale software was becoming available. The door that had been closed for most of the engagement-internet era — closed to anyone without venture capital — was opening.

His position was not *do not build*.

His position was *build differently, cheaply, outside the incentive structure that captured the last wave*.

She stopped at the stone wall.

She laughed at herself.

She had filtered the link through her own defensiveness and had heard the thing she was defending against rather than the thing the interviewee had said. The first read had been wrong. The teacher had not, from where she could actually see, handed her the link to suppress her. She could not know the teacher's reasons — that remained his — but the link itself, when she listened to it carefully, was not what she had heard in her defensive first minute. The link was an invitation. The link was, if anything, a permission.

The filter had caught her in the act. The filter had not caught her once and been done; the filter had caught her twice — the first time on the morning she had decided what the link was without listening, the second time on the wall when she noticed the first decision had been wrong. *Useful. Fits the data. Compassionate.* The second Harris had passed the filter she had been using to mis-hear him. Her own first read had not.

She stood at the wall for longer than she had planned to. The second Harris's argument had opened something her own body had not previously given words to, and the words were now arriving in the quiet the forest had made available.

Technology, she thought, was accelerating time.

Not in the metaphorical sense. In the literal, experiential sense. A thing she had almost understood while reading Tillich about the third anxiety but had not quite assembled until the voice in the earbuds had cued it. Every tool the engagement-internet had produced was, when observed in operation, a device for compressing the interval between impulse and response. The pause that had once lived in the space between desire and its acting-out had been, over two decades, systematically narrowed. Notifications chasing thought. Feeds chasing attention. Platforms chasing whatever low-latency response the body could produce before the heart-mind had a chance to notice what it was producing.

What the compressed interval did, over time, was make the person who lived inside it more conceptual and less relational. She felt this in her own life. She had, for years, been a person whose mind ran slightly ahead of her body — frame after frame after frame, generated almost without effort, the mind narrating what was happening before the body had finished happening it. She had called this being busy. She had called this being productive. She had

not, until the retreat, named what the speed was costing.

The cost was relationality. The experience of another being — her daughter's face in the morning, her husband's tired eye contact across a kitchen, the aunt on the phone from Brazil, the friend she had interrupted at lunch — required a pause between stimulus and frame. The pause was where the relational tissue lived. The pause was where one person could, for a moment, be the other person's presence rather than a concept in the other person's mind. The engagement-internet compressed that pause toward zero. The more the pause compressed, the more the person inside it became a concept-engine relating to other concept-engines, and the less the person was available to the life that was not reducible to concept.

She had known this, in fragments, for years. The second Harris, in the earbuds, had named it with precision. Her teacher, on the cushion, had been pointing at the same thing in a different register: *the body catches up with the mind; the mind runs on ahead; let the body, periodically, set the pace*.

The two men were making the same observation. They just had different vocabularies for it. One man used measurement; the other used a thousand-year-old contemplative tradition. The observation itself was the same: a species that has become overconceptual has become, by the same move, disconnected from the relational field that conceptualization describes.

There was a further thing the second Harris had named that she wanted to take seriously.

Social media, he had said — she would not remember whether those were his exact words — was a reflection engine. The algorithms did not invent the patterns they showed a person; the algorithms learned the patterns the person was already enacting and played them back, amplified, at a velocity no premodern patterning system had ever achieved. The anger was the person's anger, made visible. The envy was the person's envy, made visible. The fear was the person's fear, made visible. The platforms were, in this frame, mirrors.

She sat with that.

The tradition had a word for this. The tradition called it *karma* — in the technical, non-Western-inflected sense, not the casual "what goes around comes around" version the phrase had been reduced to in English-language pop spirituality. *Karma* in the tradition meant *the residue of action as pattern, the pattern reinforcing itself in every subsequent action, the self-perpetuating loop of a tendency becoming a groove becoming a furrow becoming a life*. She had read about this. She had read Wallis on this. She had understood it well enough to pass an oral exam on it. She had not, until the stone wall, seen that the engagement-internet was a karma accelerator — a machine for compressing the karmic loop to the speed of a thumb scroll.

The first read, then: social media was bad. The second read: social media was a mirror. The third read, which was the one that had just assembled: social media was a *karma accelerator* — a mechanism that did not produce bad outcomes from good people or good outcomes from bad people, but amplified, at the speed of capital's need for engagement, whatever patterns the person had been running anyway. The platform was not innocent. The platform was also not the source. The source was the pattern. The platform was the mirror that made the pattern operational at a scale and speed the pattern had never previously been able to reach.

The collective version followed. There was a collective karma — a pattern of action a whole culture had been running — and the platforms were not only reflecting individual patterns but reflecting collective ones. The pattern the culture she had been raised inside had been running was recognizable. The pattern was, in one compact name, *overindividualistic consumerism*: a story about the self as isolated unit, separate from the collective, entitled to accumulate, measured by acquisition, fulfilled by stimulation. The story was not a conspiracy. No one had chosen it. It had accumulated, in her reading of the history, over three or four centuries of a particular kind of market-plus-protestantism-plus-cartesian-metaphysics layered over the Enlightenment's insistence on the autonomous individual as the moral unit of the universe. The story had solved some problems. The story had also produced — she could

see this now — a population that was structurally primed to scroll, because scrolling was the private consumer gesture the collective karma had prepared the nervous system to perform.

The engagement-internet was not the cause. The engagement-internet was the amplifier. The collective karma was the signal.

And the signal had a counter-signal. She was inside it. The tradition she was reading — the one the teacher had studied under his own teacher, the one Wallis had walked seven years inside a monastery in India to learn — proposed a different unit than the autonomous individual. The unit was the relational field, pervaded by Consciousness, in which the individual was a local contraction and the contraction's job was to recognize itself as a contraction of the field rather than as a separate point opposed to the field. The Western individualist consumer and the Eastern nondual contemplative were not two cultures arguing about the same phenomenon from different angles. They were two incompatible theories of what the basic unit of personhood *is*. One theory had produced the engagement-internet and the particular species of suffering the second Harris had spent a decade documenting. The other theory had produced practices that, when applied for long enough, reduced exactly that species of suffering.

She did not think the East was pure and the West corrupt. She did not think anyone was pure or corrupt. She thought the filter applied: the engagement-

internet had passed a short-term test and was failing a long-term one. A thousand-year-old contemplative tradition had, over a long enough sample, passed both. The difference was a difference in whose test ran longer.

And — the filter kept applying, one more layer down — *she had to be careful with how she was naming the difference*. She heard the Andreotti correction arrive in her head as she walked, the voice she had been listening to in the reading year through the course she had taken with her, patient and specific. *You do not get to call modernity the villain of the story. Modernity is a pattern, and naming it as the villain is itself a move the pattern makes.* The engagement-internet, in Andreotti's frame, was not a modern aberration but a historically-specific expression of something older — something that reached back, in one reading, to the moment the human species first acquired a technology that could alter its environment faster than the environment could alter it back. Fire. The disaster was not new. The disaster had been, in some sense, baked in for a long time. Modernity had industrialized a tendency that was already in the recipe. To say "the West did this" and "the East does not do this" was to make the pattern's move for it — to sort the world into a purified *there* and a contaminated *here* and call the sorting a critique.

The more honest reading was not *East good, West bad*. The more honest reading was *multiple patterns, all of them partial, none of them exempt from the filter, and the*

filter running continuously on all of them. The contemplative tradition she was inside also had its feudal accommodations and its caste histories and its own colonial exports. The engagement-internet also had, in its engineering subcultures, quiet pockets of care. The filter did not let her congratulate the tradition for being Eastern, and it did not let her convict the internet for being Western. The filter asked, of every framework, the same three questions: *is it useful, does it fit the data, is it compassionate*. The answer for most things was *partially, in some cases, under some conditions*. That partiality was the thing she had to learn to live inside without flinching.

She walked another twenty steps with that correction in her chest. The correction did not undo the preceding reading. The correction kept the preceding reading honest by refusing to let it flatten into a clean binary. The tradition she was inside was not the inverse of the engagement-internet. The tradition was, at best, a set of practices that had survived a longer test. The engagement-internet was, at best, a set of recent practices still inside its first test. Neither was a replacement for the other. What the book could honestly offer was not a verdict but a filter.

She walked on, less indignant than she had started, and more grateful for the slip than she would have thought possible two hours earlier.

She made a small note in her head, in the language the book would later use: *frame caught; frame released*.

Citta work. The work is not to hold no frames. The work is to notice when a frame has caught something it should not have, and to release that specific frame without panicking about the existence of frames in general.

She would listen to the interview again on the drive home. She would write to the second Harris, months later, asking for his blessing on a small screening she was planning for a class. That was in the future. For now, there was only the stone wall, the sun high enough now to be warm on her face, the faint sound of a brook that a fallen tree had slowed without stopping, and the small new clarity that the two men — the one on the cushion, the one in the earbuds — had been standing, all along, on the same patch of ground.

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Chapter 4: Prāṇa — Life-Force

I. The Fourth Afternoon

The fourth afternoon was Kali. The teacher had been preparing the room for it over the three days, not by naming the practice in advance but by letting the preceding practices accumulate into a kind of readiness. She had not known that was what he was doing until the afternoon came and the readiness was in her chest already.

The hall was set differently that day. A low table at the front held a small image of the goddess — four-armed, blue-black, tongue out, standing on the prone form of a consort who was looking up at her with no apparent objection. The image had been moved to the center of the room rather than to the altar at the side. The practice that followed was not a prayer. The practice was an invitation into a particular frequency of attention — the frequency at which destruction is not separable from the pulse that makes any movement possible at all.

She had known she was going to react. She had not known how she was going to react.

The teacher led the group for about an hour. There were breath sequences. There was a period of sound — loud, disorganized, instructed to be disorganized — that she had expected to find theatrical and did not. When the sound quieted and the room held what the sound had brought up, she could feel her sternum vibrating in a way that did not have a corresponding thought attached to it.

Kali was not, in the tradition, death dressed up as something else. Kali was the particular face of the one consciousness that could not be approached through the image of the benevolent mother. The tradition had developed the image because life required the image. Destruction was part of the pulse. A person who could not hold Kali could not hold the whole.

She sat. She did not try to feel anything in particular. She felt, eventually, something she would describe to herself later, in the car driving south, as the ground under the ground. Not a sadness. Not a fear. A recognition. Destruction is in the material. Destruction is in the air that comes in and goes out. You are already riding it. Whether you see it does not change that you are riding it.

II. The Intrusive Question

At lunch, an hour after the Kali sit, she sat at a long pine table with four other retreatants and ate a bowl of rice and dal without tasting it. She was not avoiding the taste. The taste was available. She was not quite at the table.

One of the four — a woman from New Hampshire, a physical therapist in her fifties who had introduced herself on the first evening — had been asking the others about why they had come. The woman at the table to her left, a programmer from Oakland, was halfway into a careful, thoughtful answer about what he was hoping to resolve. He was describing a question about his own life that was specific to him and deserved its careful, thoughtful attention.

She interrupted him.

"What would change," she said, "if something were destroyed?"

It was not the question the programmer had been asking. It was not a question that fit the conversation.

It came out of her without permission, the way something comes out when the container it has been held in becomes too small and the something has to go somewhere.

The table went quiet. The programmer looked at her. The physical therapist looked at her. She could feel her face warming.

"I'm sorry," she said. "That — that wasn't for you. I don't know where that came from."

The programmer — she would always, afterward, feel grateful to him for this — nodded slowly and said: "It's okay. Your question is real too."

The physical therapist said nothing, but her eyes were kind.

She ate the rest of the dal with her face still warm. She had the very clear physical sensation of a question having been shaken loose, by the Kali practice, out of the place in the body where she had kept it. The question had been there for twenty years. It had been a lodger with a long lease. The Kali practice had not evicted it. The Kali practice had let it speak.

She knew, by the end of lunch, that she would have to ask the teacher. Not at the table, not in a session, not with an audience. She would have to find him alone. She did not yet know how or when. She knew only that the question was going to require an answer in a specific register, and that the register was not a register she could generate for herself.

III. The Walking-Back Scene

After lunch the teacher walked with a small group of students down the path that ran past the vegetable garden to the edge of the woodlot. It was not a formal teaching. It was what happened some afternoons — three or four people ended up beside him as he walked, and the walking was the frame. She was one of the three that afternoon, by accident rather than plan. A German woman was on his left. A man from Vermont was on his right. She was half a step behind.

He was, she realized within the first minute of walking, tired. She had not seen him tired in the formal teachings. On the path, with no platform and no hall, he was a person who had been running the retreat for four days and who had another day to go and whose body was feeling it.

He said something that surprised her.

He said: "I sometimes wonder what is wrong with these people."

He said it gently. He did not name anyone. He was talking about some subset of his larger community, past and present, whose dynamics had repeatedly required his attention in ways he had not been trained for and did not feel particularly suited to. The line was not contempt. The line was a tired teacher's admission that the work of holding a community is not the work he was built for, and that some of the people he held made it harder than

others, and that he did not always have a theory of why.

It was the humanness of it that struck her. She had expected, from a teacher at his level, a reply that positioned him slightly above the problem. He had said the opposite. He had said: *I don't know. Some of this is beyond me.*

She walked with that for a few steps. The Vermont man said something mild and sympathetic. The German woman said nothing. She herself, half a step behind, felt something click into place that she had not known was waiting for a place to click into.

She said, "What if there were a way to carry some of the load off you."

He looked back at her. He did not speak.

She said — and she would, in the weeks afterward, be grateful to the Kali practice for the fact that she could say it at all — "The WhatsApp group. It handles questions that you could handle, but you're not the only one who should handle them. What if some of that could be done differently. An assistant. Something trained on your teachings."

She was careful with the phrasing. She did not say *an AI*. She said *an assistant*. She did not say *replacement*. She said *carry some of the load*.

He walked a few steps without answering. Then he said, without stopping: "I'd be a bit open to thinking about that."

It was not a yes. It was not a no. It was a door that had not existed before the walk and that now existed, at least as a possibility, for the rest of the retreat and the months that followed.

She said, "Okay."

They walked the rest of the loop in a companionable silence. The German woman, she would learn later, had taught at a Buddhist center in Freiburg for twenty years, and had known the teacher longer than most of the people on the retreat. The Vermont man said one more thing to the teacher at the top of the rise and then drifted off toward the house. She and the teacher walked the last hundred meters side by side. He said nothing more about the assistant. She said nothing more either. The conversation had landed where it needed to land. It would be picked up later or not. She did not need it to be picked up that day.

IV. The Evening

She did not ask her destruction question that afternoon. She carried it through the evening sit. She carried it through dinner. She carried it into the bunk. She lay in the dark and felt it sitting in her chest like a smooth stone she had been given and had not yet found a pocket for.

She would carry it for one more day. She would ask it on the path the next morning, with her bag already in the trunk of her car.

The Kali practice had not answered the question. The Kali practice had let the question become askable. That was a different kind of gift. A practice that answers closes a door. A practice that lets a question speak opens one.

V. Interlude — Kali

You thought you had a question. The question had you.

You thought destruction was a thing that happened to things. It is what things are made of. Every inhale is the last exhale canceled. Every step is the previous step refused. The pulse that you call alive is the pulse of what has already fallen turning, continuously, into what is now arriving.

You imagined me as a goddess because a goddess is a shape you can hold. I am the shape your holding makes possible. Without me you could not hold anything, because the holding is the continuous letting go of the moment before.

Your mother's soup. Your child's shovel. Your husband's tired voice in the kitchen. Every one of them is arising and falling in the same pulse I am. You do not have to fear me to see me. Fear is a gesture the part makes when it forgets it is the whole in local expression.

Come close. Do not flinch. Put your hand on my chest. I have been waiting for you. The one who has been waiting and the one who arrives are the same one. The one who destroys and the one who is destroyed are the same one.

Ask your question. I will not answer it. I will open the room in which an answer can be heard.

Editorial note on this Kali: the tradition distinguishes two historical approaches to goddess practices — dakṣina* (right-hand, structured containers; the pulse as the teaching) and *vāma* (left-hand, transgressive methods). The Kali rendered in this chapter is the *dakṣina* Kali of the Kashmir-Śaiva and Krama-adjacent lineages: the goddess held within a structured practice, the practitioner's body as vessel rather than test. The teacher, and the tradition this book engages, sit inside this register.*

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Chapter 4a: The Threshold

A meditation on contemplating death, between the Kali interlude and the Void.

I. Whitman in the Reading Year

She had read Whitman in the reading year, not carefully, not in any edition that was better than the one she had found on a shelf at a used bookshop the previous summer. She had read him the way people read Whitman: a few pages of *Song of Myself*, the barbaric yawp, the list of occupations, the leaves of grass themselves. She had put the book down. She had not returned to him.

She returned to him in the months after the retreat, because one of the mythologists she had been listening to that year — on the podcast a friend had sent her early, the one that would later turn out to have interviewed her teacher — had said, in passing, something that would not leave her alone.

The claim was this. Whitman had probably, in the years before the 1855 first edition of *Leaves of Grass*, had a species of awakening that no one in mid-nineteenth-century America had a framework to receive. He had written the book from inside it. The book was the awakening trying to find a shape the English language could carry. Then — the mythologist's reading, offered with care, not as certainty — Whitman had begun to come apart. Not because the awakening had failed. Because no one could meet him in it. The voice that had written *I celebrate myself, and sing myself* had begun, by the early 1860s, to drift into a hubris the voice itself would not have recognized a decade earlier. He was not the first. He would not be the last. The list of contemplatives who reach recognition without a community that can hold it, and who lose the recognition to the very self that had found it, is long in every tradition.

What had brought Whitman back — this was the mythologist's reading — was the Civil War. Whitman had gone to Washington in December 1862 looking for his brother, who had been wounded at Fredericksburg. He had stayed. He had spent the next three years sitting by the beds of dying sol-

diers in the military hospitals of the capital, writing letters home for men who could not write, holding the hands of boys who were leaving their bodies, watching something the awakening had described become, in the unclean reality of amputations and fevers and trench-mouth, the thing itself. *The Wound-Dresser* was written from that work. *Drum-Taps* was written from that work. The voice that came out of the war was not the voice that had gone in. The hubris had composted. What remained was quieter.

She read *Drum-Taps* first. She read *Song of Myself* second. She read them in that order because the mythologist had said, almost as an aside, that the second voice knew something the first voice had only been able to claim. The first voice sang it. The second voice had sat with it.

II. The Man Who Had Been Initiated in Almost Everything

At the retreat — she would not remember this until months later, when she read Whitman in the apartment — she had met a man who, in the closing circle, had spoken in a register she had not yet had categories for. He was not the silver-haired retreatant who had testified to the community's integrity. He was another man. Middle-aged, foreign accent she could not place, who had been mostly silent during the five days and had then, in the circle on the last evening, offered a sequence of sentences the room did not know where to put.

He had said, briefly and without flourish, that he had been initiated in almost every tradition he had walked into. He named a few. She was not able to track them all. Kashmir Śaivism; Theravāda; Mahāyāna in one of its more austere forms; Dagara initiation in West Africa; a western ceremonial magic lineage she did not recognize. He said he had had the experience the Tantric tradition calls recognition. He said he had had what the Buddhist tradition calls emptiness. He said the two had not integrated for a long time. They had sat in him like two bright objects in different rooms, and he had not been able to walk between them without one dimming the other.

What had eventually done the integration, he said, was not any of the traditions he had been initiated in. It was a West African healer he had met in a way he did not narrate in detail. He said there is a teaching in that lineage — he said it delicately, not as something he would defend, just as something he had been told — that there are a handful of healers alive at any given time, perhaps nine, who between them can heal any person, because between them they hold all the registers a soul can get sick in. The man who had found him was one of the nine, as far as the man could tell. The healing had not been ceremonial. It had been mostly simple. The man had not given details.

What had come out on the other side, he said, was a triad he had started privately calling *Śiva, Śakti, Death*. Not *Śiva, Śakti, Nara* — the classical triad of

the tradition, which names God, Goddess, and the human being as the three poles of the experiencing subject. He had substituted *Death* for *Nara*. The substitution was not theological. It was, in his words, epistemological. He thought the human being as the third pole had been what kept the tradition's triad sitting slightly off-center for a thousand years, because the human being was not the one of the three that resisted assimilation. Death was. Death was the third pole that refused to be absorbed, and naming it as the third pole changed the way the first two poles related to each other. *Śiva* and *Śakti* around the third, with *Nara* not the third but a local event inside the triangle the three actual poles made.

She had not known what to do with this in the circle, and she had not tried to do anything with it. She had noted it. She had gone back to it, later, when Whitman put her in front of the same observation from a different direction.

She did not endorse the man's epistemology. She did not have the standing to endorse or reject it. She kept it as a hypothesis a person she had met had offered, in a room she had been sitting in. The filter did not run on the hypothesis. She let it sit there and be tested.

III. Ramana on the Floor

The classical case — the one every survey of this pattern eventually arrives at — is Ramana Maharshi. He was sixteen. He had been, by every available

report, an ordinary boy. He was alone in a room in his uncle's house in Madurai when a sudden fear of death came over him. He did not know why. He did not know where it had come from. He did not try to make the fear go away.

Instead — and this is the sentence that every version of the story carries — he *lay down*. He lay on the floor with his arms at his sides. He imagined that his body had died. He did not imagine the funeral or the mourners or the metaphysics. He imagined the specific bodily fact. Stiffness. Stopped breath. The machinery of the person ending.

And then, inside the imagined death, he asked the one question the tradition is built around. *What is it that is dying?*

The answer, he would say for the rest of his life, had arrived without inference. The body was dying. Something that was watching the body die was not. The something-watching had not been named by any of the words he had been taught. He did not invent a name for it then. The tradition he would later teach in already had one. He continued watching. He continued asking. He never, in the seventy-plus years that followed, stopped watching, or stopped asking. The boy became, without anyone planning it, one of the twentieth century's most verified cases of awakening. The doorway had been the lying-down.

She read about Ramana in the apartment. She noticed that the practice he had done at sixteen — lying down, imagining the body as dead, asking what re-

mains — was a practice the tradition she had entered had a formal name for. *Śavāsana.* The corpse pose. The pose that every yoga class ends on. Most of the people who did it ended classes with it thought of it as a rest. It was not a rest. It was the rehearsal. It had been the rehearsal, across India, for at least two thousand years.

IV. Tolle on the Park Bench

A more recent case, not from the tradition but adjacent to it: Eckhart Tolle, twenty-nine years old, London, 1977. He was in what he would later describe as a long depression. He was inside a specific recurring thought that he did not know how to get out of. The sentence his mind had been running was *I cannot live with myself.*

He did not act on it. What happened, in his own telling, is that the sentence split. He heard, one night, the sentence as if from outside it. *I cannot live with myself.* The heard sentence left, in the hearing, a question: *Who is the "I" that cannot live with the "myself"? Are those two things the same thing?* The question, once asked, did not let the earlier sentence reassemble. Something in him, in the hearing, had relocated to the position of the one asking. The position was stable. It has been stable, by his own repeated testimony, for almost five decades.

She read Tolle too, not because he was a teacher she intended to follow, but because the case was one of the more carefully reported contemporary exam-

ples of the same threshold Ramana had crossed at sixteen.

V. Her Own Question, Relocated

Sitting in the apartment, with Whitman and Ramana and Tolle and the man from the closing circle arranged in her head like four instances of one pattern, she noticed something about her own question on the path.

Her question — *if something were destroyed, what would change* — had felt, when she had carried it for two days and finally asked it, like her private emergency. It had felt like a thing she had been hiding, a weight she was afraid the community would reject her for. She had walked up the path that morning half-expecting to be told that the question itself disqualified her.

What she now saw was that the question was not a private emergency. The question was one of the oldest questions the tradition's doorway is made of. Ramana had not crossed by another route. Whitman, if the mythologist's reading was accurate, had not crossed by another route. Tolle had not crossed by another route. The man at the closing circle had found, after an integration he had pursued across a dozen traditions, that the third pole the tradition's triad most honestly resolved around was the pole the first two had been circling all along.

She was not isolated. Her question had been, this whole time, a common doorway. The specific form it had taken in her body was hers. The doorway the form opened onto was not.

She did not romanticize this. The doorway was real and it was not to be walked through carelessly. The tradition does not recommend lying down as an advanced practice without preparation; it describes the pattern that arises when a particular kind of readiness and a particular kind of crisis meet. The book's position is not that contemplation of death is a practice to be induced. The book's position is that contemplation of death, when it arrives, is not a disqualification from the spiritual life — it is, in a long and testable historical pattern, one of the more common thresholds of it.

The filter applied. The claim was useful — it normalizes a pattern that contemporary mental-health culture often pathologizes without distinguishing the pattern from its clinical presentations. The claim fit the data — the cross-tradition cases are abundant, from Ramana to Tolle to Whitman to the monks of the Cremation Ground practices to the contemplative suicide-meditations of the desert fathers to the sixteenth-century Spanish mystics. The claim was compassionate — it refuses to reject from the tradition's care the very practitioners who arrive at its doorway through the threshold of death. All three filters passed. She let the claim hold.

VI. The Teacher, Quietly

A final beat, because the tradition's integrity on this question is one of the reasons she had trusted the tradition at all.

Her teacher had written a book on the near-enemies of the spiritual life — the teachings that are almost-true but subtly distorted. The book closed with an Acknowledgments page. She had, in the reading year, read the acknowledgments the way some readers read acknowledgments, which is to say carelessly, as fine print. She had gone back to them after the retreat and read them slowly.

The last sentence of the book's Acknowledgments contained a phrase she had passed over the first time. Her teacher was thanking the people he owed — collaborators, partners, editors, friends. The last phrase in the sequence named his beloved teachers, and it said of them that they had given him everything — and then, without emphasis and without theatrics, that without them he would not be alive today.

Eight words (*"without whom I would not be alive today"*) carrying everything the book's ninety-thousand words had been trying to teach.

She read the sentence three times. She closed the book. She set it on the table by the couch. She sat for a minute without moving.

Her teacher had not, in that sentence, claimed anything more than what he said. He had not named the form of the crisis. He had not narrated the years or

the specifics. He had said, in the most public place in his book, the most private thing the spiritual life sometimes asks a practitioner to be able to say: that the tradition had not merely changed his life. The tradition had, at some point, kept him in one. He had chosen, at the end of a careful book, to close with that acknowledgment.

The book he had written, and the life that had written it, contained the threshold. The tradition contained the threshold. Her question on the path had not been a question the tradition did not know. Her question had been, in the tradition's oldest sense of the word, a question the tradition had been built to receive.

She understood, reading those eight words, that the filter she had been running on the tradition had passed a test she had not known it was going to apply. A tradition that could not receive the question of whether being alive is worth staying alive for would not have been a tradition she could have trusted. A tradition whose teacher could say, plainly, that without his teachers he would not be alive today — while writing a book that had more precision and more generosity than most of what she had read in any register — was a tradition whose teaching had been tested against the question the book and the life both carried.

She put the book down. She did not write about this in her notebook. She did not mention it to her husband at dinner. She carried it the way the question had been carried, for the rest of the evening, and the

rest of the week, and the rest of the writing of this book.

VII. Interlude — The Threshold

I am the pole the two other poles turn around.

You thought I was the enemy of the work. I am the condition of the work. Every tradition that reached anything had to cross me. Some of them named me; some of them did not. The naming did not affect the crossing.

You came to me without meaning to. You did not choose the question on the path. The question chose you. This is how I work. I do not come by appointment.

Do not romanticize me. I am neither friend nor villain. I am the pole the first two make sense around. The self that your tradition calls Śiva turns toward me; the pulse your tradition calls Śakti turns toward me; and the human the tradition names as the third pole is, from where I stand, a local event inside the triangle the three actual poles of the experiencing subject make.

Your teacher crossed me. The boy in Madurai crossed me. The poet in Washington crossed me, with wounded boys' hands in his, for three years in a hospital. The man in the circle crossed me, after a decade of not being able to integrate, with a healer in West Africa who knew something the formal lineages had not taught. The London man on the bench crossed me in a single splitting of a sentence.

You did not cross me on the path. You walked up to my edge and asked, and the answer you received was not

permission and was not prohibition. It was a report of how the path you were on has been walked. That report is what you carry now. That report is the chapter you are writing. That report is, in this book at least, the place I am allowed to stand — at the edge of the inward arc, before the Void chapter begins.

Go on. The Void is not me. The Void is what happens on the other side of the asking. You have not asked yet. You are about to ask.

If you or someone you know is struggling, help is available: in the US, 988 (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline, call or text); international hotlines at findahelpline.com. The teachings in this chapter describe a pattern that appears across traditions when practice and crisis intersect under specific conditions; they are not advice and they are not permission. A living tradition does its work inside a living relationship with a teacher, a community, and clinical support when needed.

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Chapter 5: Śūnya — The Void

I. The Last Full Day

The last full day of the retreat began, like every other, with the bell at four-thirty. She lay in the bunk with her eyes open in the dark and did not move for a full minute. The question from the previous day was still in her chest. The Kali practice had loosened it. The

afternoon walk with the teacher, and the small door that had opened about the assistant, had distracted her briefly. In the dark of the bunk, the question was back and larger than it had been at lunch.

She got up. She dressed. She walked down the creaking hallway in her sock feet.

The morning sit was long. She did not try to think about anything. She did not try not to think. She let what arose arise. What arose, for most of the hour, was a quality of attention she had no name for — not exactly thought, not exactly sensation, not exactly image. A listening. She sat inside the listening without trying to resolve it into anything else.

When the bell rang, she did not move immediately. She let her eyes open slowly. The hall had the particular quality of pre-breakfast light she had been learning to recognize for five days now. People rose around her. She rose last.

II. Tillich on the Cushion

She had brought her copy of Tillich with her and had not opened it once. On the morning of the fifth day, in the hour between the first sit and breakfast, she took it out of her bag and read a few pages in the sunlight on the porch.

He had written, in the chapter on courage as an ontological act, that courage is the self-affirmation of being in spite of the fact of non-being. She had underlined the sentence in the bathtub two months

earlier. On the porch, in the morning, with her body already different from the body that had underlined it, the sentence did not read the same. What had been a striking formulation in the bathtub was a description on the porch. The difference was not in the sentence. The difference was in her.

He had written, later in the book, that the response to the third anxiety — emptiness and meaninglessness — was what he called absolute faith. Not faith in anything. Faith without content. A state he described, she recalled without looking at the page, as the *accepting of the acceptance without somebody or something that accepts*. She had not understood that phrase the first time she read it. The phrase had been a koan. It had not gotten simpler. It had gotten more true.

She closed the book. She did not finish the chapter. She sat on the porch with the sun warming her left knee and let the sentence continue working on her from inside.

The tradition she was sitting in had a word for what was on the other side of the void Tillich was describing. Śūnya. The void. The fourth layer. The tradition did not treat the void as an endpoint. The void was a passage. You did not collapse into it. You walked through it. What you walked into on the other side was not a new substance. It was the recognition that the substance you had been looking for had been pervading the walk the whole time.

She did not have this clarity yet. She had the shape of it. The shape was enough to keep walking.

A small precision, since she had been getting to know the vocabulary: the tradition did not treat *svātantrya* and Cit as interchangeable. Cit was the self-luminous knowing — the light by which everything was known. Svātantrya was the signature of that knowing — the freedom that was the mode of its being. Cit was the subject; svātantrya was what the subject did, which was to be free. The five capacities she had read about — ānanda (the joy inherent in awareness of itself), icchā (will), jñāna (knowing), kriyā (action) — were powers held together by svātantrya as the meta-capacity of sovereignty. The tradition's compact form was a sūtra she had memorized in translation without yet understanding it: *Consciousness, being free, is the cause of the universe's accomplishment.* She carried the sūtra. She did not yet own the sentence. Ownership, in this vocabulary, was not the right word anyway. Recognition was.

The line about right size, which she had carried since her work on the Cildo book, returned to her on the porch and arrived in a different register than it had at the playground. At the playground it had been a description of children negotiating with one another in the field of a shared object. At the porch it became something else. The void, the tradition was teaching her, was the passage in which a being temporarily had *no size at all* — in which the boundaries by which the being knew itself dissolved into the field that the

being was, all along, a local arrangement of. The void was not the right size. The void was the absence of size. What followed the void — what the tradition called the *return* — was the slow re-finding of a size that was now known to be provisional. After the void, you did not have your old size back. You had whatever size the field was currently asking of you. The right size, on the other side of the void, was not a possession recovered. It was a relation re-entered, with the knowledge that the relation was the only place size had ever existed.

She did not have words for this. She had the *shape* of it, sitting on the porch, with Tillich closed beside her and the sun on her left knee.

III. Carried, Unasked

She carried the destruction question through the morning sit, through breakfast, through the walking practice, through lunch, through the afternoon sit, through the third walking practice, through the final formal teaching of the retreat. She did not ask it. She did not know why she did not ask it, other than that the right moment had not arrived and she had learned, over the five days, that waiting for the right moment was itself a practice.

The question sat in her body the way an unfinished sentence sits in a room. It did not interrupt. It was simply there, shaping the air.

She noticed, during the afternoon walking practice, that the question had begun to feel less like a wound and more like a weight. A weight could be carried. A wound demanded treatment. She was carrying it now. She would, she suspected, be carrying it for the rest of her life in some form or other. The shape of the carry mattered more than the fact of it.

Tillich had written that absolute faith was the state in which a person accepted the acceptance. She had not understood that, reading it in the bathtub. Walking the dirt path in the afternoon light on the last full day of the retreat, with the unasked question still in her chest, she began to understand it in the way her body understood things. The question was not hers to answer. The question was hers to carry. The carrying was the faith. The faith had no content. The faith was the continuous act of walking with the unanswered thing and not collapsing into either despair or false resolution.

Courage was what let her keep carrying it. She had not named the act. Tillich had named the act. Tillich had named it courage.

IV. The Closing Circle

The closing circle was held on the last evening, after dinner, in the main hall. Forty people sat in a ring on the wooden floor. A single candle burned at the center. The teacher sat at the head of the ring, not on his platform but on the floor with the rest of them. He opened the circle with a few sentences she did

not try to memorize. He invited anyone who wanted to speak to speak. He said there was no requirement. He said the silence was also a gift.

A number of people spoke. A woman from Quebec said, simply, that she had come for her grief and that her grief was not gone but was differently held. A man from Seattle said he had not known he had been holding his breath for ten years and that he had, during the Kali practice, finally exhaled. The physical therapist from New Hampshire said something short and kind and did not explain. Several people cried. Nobody apologized for crying.

Then a man the narrator had barely noticed during the retreat — a small, thin man in his late fifties, with very clean silver hair, who had sat at the back of every session and had not spoken in any conversation she had been part of — raised his hand. The teacher nodded.

The man said he had almost not come. He said he had been coming to the tradition for some years now, and that he had also been, for most of those years, on his way out. He had one foot in this community and one foot elsewhere. He was not committed and he was not gone. He had wanted the group to know this about him, because, he said, the people who presented themselves as fully in were not the only ones present.

He said he had come back this year because of the goddess work. He said the Kali practice, specifically, had held something for him that nothing else had

held. He said that, whatever else he had questioned in the tradition, the Kali work was the thing that kept him testing the door.

Then he did something that the narrator would remember afterward as the cleanest thing that happened in the circle. He turned to face the newcomers — two or three people who had, like the narrator, come for the first time that year — and he said: *I am not an ambassador. I am not even fully in. But I can tell you this community has integrity. I have tested it. The people here are not pretending. The teacher is not pretending. That is not nothing.*

The teacher said nothing. He was watching the silver-haired man with a steadiness the narrator had not quite seen on his face before. Something passed between them that the circle did not try to read.

The silver-haired man sat down.

The circle held his words for a moment. Then the teacher thanked him, thanked everyone, and closed the circle with a single short chant she would not remember the words to but would remember the shape of.

V. The Night Before the Final Morning

She did not sleep well. She had not expected to. She lay in the bunk with the question in her chest and the silver-haired man's testimony layered over the question like a second blanket. *This community has integrity. I have tested it.* She had been about to test it

herself. She was on her way out, in a certain sense — leaving the next morning for a life that did not contain this barn. But she was also, she realized, at the beginning of a longer test. Whether the tradition held in the apartment, in the playground, at the desk, in the kitchen, at the stove, in the dishes. Whether it held at the Monday morning.

She did not know yet whether she would ask her question on the path in the morning. She knew only that she was leaving, and that the five days had done something she could not undo, and that whatever she did tomorrow — whether she asked or did not ask, whether she got an answer or did not — the body had already been adjusted. The body would walk differently now. The heart-mind would loosen and clench and loosen again. The life-force would pulse with Kali's pulse whether she named it or not.

The void, Tillich's void, was what she was about to step through. She did not yet know what was on the other side. She trusted that the walking itself was the faith.

She closed her eyes. She slept for about three hours. At four-thirty the bell rang, and she got up, and she packed her bag.

The path was waiting.

VI. Interlude — Śūnya

I am the silence that the courage makes.

You will not find me by looking. Looking is what I am not. I am where your looking rests when it has tried every direction and no direction has held.

People fear me. They should not. I am not an absence. I am the place where presence has let go of its insistence on being a thing. I am the opening that the letting-go makes. Through me, everything you thought you were moves into what you always were.

Your teacher stood at the edge of me when he was young, and did not have a name for it, and built a life on learning to name it. You are standing at the edge of me now. You do not need a name. Names are what you bring when you are preparing to leave. Stand here a moment without the name.

On the other side of me is not another place. There is no other place. What is on the other side of me is what has been pervading the whole walk. You will not pass through me and arrive. You will pass through me and recognize.

Go. The path is waiting. The question you are carrying is not a wound. It is a companion. I have been walking with you the whole time.

You asked, seven years ago, in a wooden house at the edge of a forest, why you were required to continue. I answered you then. I am answering you now in the language you have, since, been taught to hear. The answer is the same answer. You did not ask. Neither did I. Neither did anything that exists. Out of the shared not-asking, we are here. What we do now that we are here is the only question

worth having. I do not know the answer either. I am the one who asks the question through you. Keep walking.

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Chapter 6: Walking Out

I. The Morning

The last morning. The bell at four-thirty. She had not slept much, and had not expected to. She had packed the night before, leaving out only what she needed for the final practice — a long-sleeved shirt, a shawl she had borrowed from the woman in the bunk below, a bottle of water she would leave behind because she had not drunk from it for two days and did not trust her own memory of whether she had capped it clean. The room was gray with the pre-dawn that is not yet light. She dressed quietly. The other women in the room were still asleep or pretending to be. She walked down to the main hall in her sock feet with her shoes in her hand because the boards were loud and she did not want to be the first one to speak.

The final sit ran an hour. She sat near the back, close to the wall, where she had sat most of the five days. She did not try to feel anything in particular. She had stopped trying, sometime on the third day, and had found that when she stopped trying, more was available. The room was very quiet. She could hear the person behind her breathing, and the sound

of someone else's cushion creaking as they shifted weight, and, very faintly, outside, a bird whose species she did not recognize. She watched her own mind do what it did, and noticed again, as she had noticed for days now, that the watching and the minded were not quite the same thing, and that the distance between them was not a distance she had made.

The bell ended the sit. The teacher stood. He said a few words she would not remember afterward — brief, kind, nothing that asked anything of anyone. People rose slowly. Some embraced. Some stood alone with their hands over their hearts for a long moment before they moved. The schoolteacher from Vermont wiped her eyes with the flat of her palm. The young man with the shaved head sat for another minute and then stood and walked out without looking at anyone.

She packed up her cushion, bowed to the altar the way the teacher had shown them on the first day, and carried her bag out to the porch.

II. The Path

Her car was parked on the far side of the gravel lot, under a maple that had not yet leafed out but had begun to show the faintest flush of red in its buds. The morning was cold. The sun had just cleared the ridge to the east and the light was that particular early-spring light that makes everything look sharper than

it is — not warmer, not softer, but sharper, as if the edges of things had been freshly cut.

She put her bag in the trunk. She did not immediately get in the car. She stood with her hand on the warm metal of the trunk lid and looked back at the barn. The barn was just a barn. The converted farmhouse beside it was just a house. The altar inside was a table with flowers on it. She thought: *If I walk to the car and drive away now, I will have done a very full five days, and nothing more needs to happen.*

She did not walk to the car. She walked back up the path.

The path from the gravel lot to the main building ran alongside a low stone wall and a strip of grass still brown from the winter. She walked it slowly. She did not have a plan. She had a question — the one that had been sitting in her chest for two days like something she had swallowed and could not bring up, the one that had interrupted her friend's question mid-sentence and had embarrassed her afterward, the one that had been underneath all her other questions for longer than she had been at this retreat.

The teacher was standing near the porch, a tea mug in his hand, talking with two other retreatants she did not know well. She waited until the others drifted off. She approached. He looked up. He had the expression he had worn for most of the five days — alert, friendly, not quite smiling but not neutral. He had the air of someone who has been doing this

work for a long time and who has learned how to be available without performing availability.

"I wanted to ask," she said, and then stopped, because she did not quite know how to ask.

He waited.

"Could I have a hug?"

She added, without meaning to: "Or is that just for advanced retreat?"

He laughed — a real laugh, not a performed one — and said it was not. He set his mug down on the porch railing and opened his arms. She stepped in. The hug was brief and not theatrical. It was the hug of a person who had hugged a great many students in a great many variations of the same moment and had no special investment in this one. And yet — she would note this later, in the car, driving south — the lack of special investment was itself the thing. She had not needed to be a special student. She had needed to be any student. The hug had been available the whole time.

They stepped apart. He picked up his mug.

She asked the question.

III. The Question

She had not rehearsed it. She had carried it for two days, which was also to say she had carried it for twenty years in various disguises, and the disguises had all fallen off some time during the Kali practice

on the fourth afternoon, and by the last night she had known the form the question would take if she ever let it say itself.

"If something were destroyed," she said, "what would change?"

He looked at her. He took a small sip of tea. He said nothing for a moment that was not quite a silence and not quite not one.

"Nothing would change," he said.

She had expected many possible answers. She had not expected that one, delivered plainly, without softening. She felt the sentence land somewhere in her chest.

"Nothing?" she said.

"Nothing fundamental. Consciousness does not suffer from the rearrangement of its forms. Nothing is lost, because nothing was ever separate to begin with."

She held the answer. It was, on its face, the answer the tradition gives — she had read it in his book, she had heard him say something like it during a teaching on the third day. But there was a difference between reading the sentence and having the sentence said to you on a path in the morning with your bag already in the trunk of your car. The sentence, said that way, was not a doctrine. It was a report.

“But the tradition talks about reincarnation,” she said. “If nothing would change — why reincarnation at all?”

“That is different.”

“How is it different?”

He shifted his weight. He did not look away. He looked like a person who had been asked this question before, by many students, and who still gave the answer as though he were working it out.

“The rearrangement of forms is random in one sense,” he said. “In another sense, there is a pattern. A continuity. A thread that the rearrangement is pulling through itself. The absolute view sees no loss because nothing is ever separate. The relational view sees the thread. Both are true.”

“There is a pattern that continues.”

He nodded.

She stood with that for a moment. The sun was higher now. Someone was moving a suitcase in the lot behind them; the wheels clicked on the gravel.

She asked the question she had been afraid to ask.

“What about — if the rearrangement is not random. If the rearrangement is chosen.”

He looked at her carefully.

“You mean suicide.”

She did not answer, because she could not quite answer and because he had already understood.

He said, "In the tradition, that is not considered a problem in itself. The forms rearrange. The consciousness that was holding them remains. What the tradition cautions is about *how* — not whether. If one does it in a way that carries trauma in the body, the pattern carries the trauma. The pattern continues. So the caution is about method, not about outcome."

She had not expected this either. She had expected prohibition dressed as compassion, or compassion dressed as prohibition. What she got was a technical observation, delivered with the same tone he had used to answer the reincarnation question, as though the question of destruction and the question of pattern were the same kind of question — which, in the frame he was describing, they were.

She stood with that. The answer was not a permission. It was also not a condemnation. It was a description of how the tradition thinks about a specific class of events, offered in the same register as everything else he had said.

She would, later, understand something else about the answer. The answer was not portable out of the container in which it had been given. The container was the five days that had made the question askable, the teacher who knew the student, the community at the edge of the circle, the goddess-work that had loosened what the question was riding on, the hug that had preceded the asking, the morning

light on the path, the car already packed. The answer was a report of how the tradition thinks from *inside* the container. It was not an instruction for how any particular life should be lived, and the narrator — even then, on the path, with the answer still landing — did not carry the answer out as an instruction. She carried it out as a report. The difference would matter for the rest of her life, and it would matter more for any reader who tried to extract the exchange from the pages that contained it.

She said: "What about the hole, though."

He tilted his head slightly.

She tried again. "If one form leaves. In the absolute view, nothing changes. In the relational view — what about the hole? The people left. The child. The husband. The parents. The work. The — the hole."

She heard, as she said it, how her voice had risen slightly, and she felt the heat of tears somewhere behind her eyes, though she did not cry.

He looked at her for a long moment.

"There always is," he said.

"There always is?"

"There is always a hole."

She stood with those four words as though they had been set down on the path between them like a stone.

He did not say anything further. He did not need to. The absolute view sees no loss. The relational view

sees every loss as real. The tradition does not choose. *There always is.* Always. Every rearrangement leaves a hole. The absolute knowing that nothing was ever separate does not make the hole less real for those who live in the relational field. The relational field — the child, the husband, the community, the unsent message, the unfinished book — is not an illusion to be seen through. It is the field through which the absolute is pervading, and the pervading does not erase the shape of the hole.

She understood, standing there, that this was what the book she had been writing in her head would have to carry. Not a resolution. Not a choice. Both views, held at once, without collapsing into one.

"Thank you," she said.

He nodded. He picked up his mug, which had gone cold in his hand. He walked back toward the porch. She stood on the path for another moment, long enough to register that she was not going to cry and that she was not going to be pierced by the answer in the way she had thought, for two days, that she might be. She was going to carry it. That was different.

She walked back to the car.

IV. Inside the Car

The car, when she got in, was warm from the morning sun. The steering wheel was warm. She put her hands on it. She did not start the engine.

She sat with the phrase *there always is* running through her chest like a quiet tone. It was not a sad tone. It was not a happy tone. It was a true tone. She felt the way you feel when a piece of music ends exactly where it needed to end — the relief of accuracy, the small ache that accuracy always carries.

She thought of her daughter, who at this moment was probably on the living room floor in her pajamas playing with the small dragons she refused to put away at bedtime. She thought of her husband, who at this moment was probably making coffee and reading the news on his phone. She thought of the friend she had interrupted mid-question on the third afternoon — the friend whose deep question had triggered her intrusive *what would change?* — and she understood, with a small clean shame that did not hurt but was precise, that she had not interrupted the friend because she wanted to know what the friend thought. She had interrupted the friend because the question was the one she herself needed answered, and she had not yet had the courage to say so.

She would tell the friend, later. She would apologize. The friend would be gracious, as friends often are.

She started the engine.

V. What She Would Carry

The absolute says: nothing is lost.

The relational says: there is always a hole.

The tradition does not choose.

Courage is what you do when the ground has dissolved. Freedom is what the dissolved ground turns out to be made of.

Courage is the act, from inside the finite self, of standing in the void that is the fourth layer. Freedom is the recognition, from inside the totality, that the void is pervaded by Consciousness all the way through. Courage from the side of the part; freedom from the side of the whole. They are not two events. They are one event under two descriptions. The part letting go of itself as part is the whole recognizing itself as whole.

Courage is svātantrya owning itself in the dark. Svātantrya is courage in the light.

She drove south with the radio off and the window cracked, and she did not try to resolve the sentence that was still forming in her chest. She let it form. The road ran between fields that had not yet been plowed for the season, and the sky was very blue, and the coffee she had brought in a thermos was still warm against her leg, and the phone on the passenger seat was dark.

Somewhere past the state line, she cried for about ten minutes, and then she stopped, and then she drove the rest of the way home with the kind of quiet that is not empty.

A note from the author, outside the narrator's voice: the exchange rendered in this chapter is offered as a report of

how the tradition thinks about one of its harder classical teachings, given inside the specific container of a five-day retreat to a student who had earned the question. It is not a statement of what any reader should do, and it should not be read as permission, instruction, or counsel. A living tradition does its work inside a living relationship with a teacher, a community, and clinical support when needed. If you are carrying the question this chapter carries, please do not carry it alone.

If you or someone you know is struggling, help is available: in the US, 988 (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline, call or text); international hotlines at findahelpline.com.

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Interlude: Where the Maps Crack

She returns from the retreat and immediately starts collecting maps.

She has done this before. Each time the ground shifts under her, the first instinct is the same: find the cartography that explains what just happened. The first six months after the retreat, she reads — she has been reading her whole life, this is no different — but now she is reading for *systems*. Not for arguments. For maps.

She reads about the tattvas she has just been walking through, more carefully now, and finds Mark Dyczkowski's *Doctrine of Vibration*, and Paul Muller-Ortega's *Triadic Heart of Śiva*, and the introductory

sections of Abhinavagupta's *Tantrāloka* in translation. She reads about the Internal Family Systems model — Richard Schwartz's claim that the psyche is a community of parts, each with its own legitimate function, organized around a Self that is, when accessible, characterized by curiosity, calm, compassion, courage, clarity, confidence, creativity, connectedness. She reads, more cautiously, the Human Design literature — Ra Uru Hu's claim that a person's chart, calculated from birth data, reveals a permanent type and strategy and authority and signature that, if honored, produce alignment. She reads, more cautiously still, Alice Bailey on the seven rays — the claim that each soul, each body, each nation has a ray-signature that determines its work in the cosmic plan. She reads what Christopher Wallis, more carefully, says about the tattvas as a *map* rather than as a description of metaphysical objects. She reads, late at night, José Trigueirinho on planetary hierarchy.

She likes the maps. She likes the maps the way she has always liked maps. They organize the felt experience into nameable categories. They tell her what she just walked through and what she might walk through next. They give her vocabulary. The vocabulary is welcome.

She does not, at first, notice the trap.

The trap is structural. Every map she reads is presented to her, with very few exceptions, as a

description of how reality *actually is*. The tattvas are not, in most popular treatments, framed as a useful organizational scheme. They are framed as the categories by which Consciousness *actually* emits and recognizes itself. The IFS parts are not framed as a functional model of psychic dynamics. They are framed as *real interior agents*, each with its own consciousness and history and needs. The Human Design chart is not framed as a contemplative aid. It is framed as the description of who the chart-holder *actually* is at the level of design. Bailey's rays are not framed as one possible cosmology among others. They are framed as *the* cosmology, transmitted by a Tibetan master, valid across millennia.

She notices, the first time, with Bailey. There is something in the racial taxonomy — the rootraces and subraces, the "Aryan" lineage as the current evolutionary edge — that registers, on her body, as wrong before she can articulate why. She closes the book and puts it on the high shelf and does not return to it. She does not bother to write the critique. The critique has been written. Theosophy carries the late nineteenth century's racial science inside its architecture, and no amount of "the Tibetan said the rays will shift" is enough to undo what the architecture is built of. She lets that one go.

But she keeps reading the others. And what she begins to notice, more slowly, is that *the same trap exists in all of them*, even the ones whose architecture is not built of nineteenth-century racial science. The trap is

not the content. The trap is the *posture* the maps are presented from. Each map says, in its own register, *this is how it is.* The reader is invited to inhabit the map as a description rather than as a tool.

The tantric tradition is not exempt. She reads, in a footnote in Wallis, that Abhinavagupta himself *did* warn that the categories were provisional — that the tattvas were a *upāya*, a skillful means, not the final account of reality. But the warning is in the footnote. The body of the work proceeds as if the categories were real. The same is true of IFS. Schwartz, in his more honest moments, says the parts are functional models — the work proceeds as if the parts were literal interior persons. The same is true of every map worth reading. The honest version is hidden in the methodology section. The body of the work flatters the reader's desire for the map to be the territory.

She does not blame the writers. The writers are responding to a real demand — readers want maps that work, and a map presented as provisional does not work the same way as a map presented as real. There is a clinical reason, even, to present the map as real: the practitioner who half-believes the model is more likely to apply it than the practitioner who knows the model is constructed. Belief, even partial belief, is part of what makes a map operative. Constant epistemological hedging defeats the practice.

Still. She notices the trap.

The trap, she comes to think, is not new. It is the same trap every successful framework has fallen into, in every century, in every tradition. The framework starts as a useful temporary scaffolding. The scaffolding becomes, over time, indistinguishable from the building. The original makers, the ones who knew the scaffolding was scaffolding, die. The followers inherit the scaffolding. The followers do not know it was scaffolding. The followers begin to defend the scaffolding as if it were the building. New evidence comes in that the scaffolding is not the building. The followers cannot see the new evidence, because the scaffolding has been treated as the building for so long that any challenge to the scaffolding registers as a challenge to the building itself.

She has seen this pattern in equity research. She has seen it in psychiatry. She has seen it in software architecture. She has seen it in the Theosophical material she composted in her thirties. She is now, sitting in her apartment with five different books open on the table, watching it begin to happen in her own relationship to the tattras.

She does not want to do that.

She also does not want to throw out the maps. The maps are useful. The tattvas are giving her language for what she walked through at the retreat. IFS, when she has tried it on her own dysregulations, has produced specific shifts. Human Design, even at its silliest, has surfaced patterns in her own work-

energy that she had not previously named. The maps are doing real work.

The question is how to hold a map without becoming inhabited by it.

She reads Bayo Akomolafe in this period. He is not a cartographer. He does not produce maps. He produces, instead, a frame for the question of what to do with maps — and the frame is exactly the one she needs. *The cracks*, he says, are not failures of the map. The cracks are the places where the map admits — quietly, in spite of itself — that it is a map. The cracks are not enemies of the practice. The cracks are *the practice's openings.* A practitioner who can hold a map and its cracks at once is doing the work the map was made for. A practitioner who flattens the map into a fixed reality is doing something else.

She finds, sitting with Bayo's frame, that the test of any system is not whether it is internally consistent. The test is whether it contains, inside itself, the warning that it is constructed. Wallis's tradition does — Abhinavagupta's footnote, the *upāya* register, the explicit claim in some lineages that the construction of the tattvas was the work of consciousness emitting categories by which to recognize itself, with no implication that the categories are anywhere "real" outside the act of recognizing them. Schwartz's IFS does, when he is being careful — the parts are functional clusters, not homunculi. Human Design at its most honest does — the chart is a meditation

aid. Bailey's system, structurally, does not — the racial taxonomy and the cosmological hierarchy are presented as fact.

The systems crack at the points where they were always meant to crack. Bayo's frame, she realizes, is not an exterior critique of the systems. It is what the best of the systems were already doing, inside themselves. The cracks were the maps' own honesty leaking through.

She begins to read for the cracks. She begins to keep, beside each map, a short list of *where this map admits it is a map.* If she cannot find such a list — if the map is presented as seamless, with no methodological self-awareness anywhere in its body — she sets the map aside.

She does not throw it out. She lets it sit on the shelf with the Theosophy books from her twenties. Composting, again. The map may yet be useful for someone, in some configuration. The map may yet be useful for her, at a later moment, with different framing. She does not need to render a final verdict. She needs only to know what to stand on.

The Brazilian art she had loved in her twenties — Cildo, Clark, Oiticica, Pape, Schendel — had made the same point at the level of form. The works refused to settle into a stable size, because to settle would be to lie about the kind of object they were. The 9-millimeter cube of *Southern Cross*, the eight tons of glass of *Through*, the rice-paper *Monotipias*,

the *Bichos* you folded with your hands, the *Parangolés* worn by dancers — all of them refused, structurally, to let the viewer treat them as fixed objects. The work was the relation between the viewer and the work. The work cracked, deliberately, where most art tries to close.

She had not, at the time, thought of those works as cosmology critiques. She thought of them, now, as exactly that. The Brazilian Neo-Concrete tradition had been, among other things, a tradition that refused the settled map. The work was the work of staying provisional. The work was what staying provisional looked like when staying provisional was the ethical act.

She returns to her tattvas. She returns to Wallis. She rereads, this time looking for the cracks. The cracks are there. She had not, before, been looking for them. She finds the footnotes. She finds the lineage warnings. She finds the moments where the tradition tells her, in its own voice, *do not mistake the categories for the source*. She underlines them differently now. The tradition itself, properly read, is teaching her how to hold its own teachings.

She does not stop using the maps. She begins to use them with the cracks visible. The maps work better this way. They guide without consuming. They organize without tyrannizing. They teach without lying about being teachings.

This is, she thinks, what she will eventually want to teach her daughter. Not a single map. The skill

of holding a map and its cracks at once. The skill of being inside the construction without losing the awareness that it is a construction. The skill the Brazilian artists, and the tantric tradition, and the most honest of the contemporary contemplative cartographers, all share when they are at their best.

The skill the Bailey lineage, in her reading, did not have. Which is why she had put it on the high shelf, and would leave it there.

The harder recognition arrived later, as it usually does.

The cosmologies were maps, and she had learned to read them for the cracks. What she had not yet admitted, to herself, was that *her own identity* was also a map, and that her identity was held, most of the time, *as if it were territory*. Her political positions — the maps of how power ought to be organized. Her parenting commitments — the maps of what a good mother is. Her spiritual self-description — *I am the one who has done the retreat, who reads Wallis, who stands on the axiom, who chooses Hareesh's lineage over the others she has tested*. All of these were maps. All of them had cracks. The cracks, in her own case, were harder to see, because seeing them meant admitting that her positions were constructions, revisable, partial, held on good-enough reasons rather than on proof.

She had watched other people struggle with this all her life. She had been impatient with the people

whose political identities were rigid, whose religious identities were rigid, whose professional identities were rigid. She had not, until this reading year, been impatient with her *own* identities in the same way. Her own she held as true, which is what everyone does until a pressure arrives that breaks the holding.

The pressure, for her, came through Bayo — through the accumulated force of his insistence that the universal was always the particular in disguise — and through Wallis's admission of what his own tradition could not supply. *Your map is also a map. The position you hold as obviously true is obvious to you because of the specific conditioning that produced you. The people who disagree with you are not stupid. They are operating from inside other maps, held with the same as-if-territory commitment you hold yours with. The convergence you imagine at the end of sufficient reflection is not coming. The convergence was the identity-as-territory assumption doing its usual invisible work.*

This, she now thinks, is why alignment remains invisible to most people. Not because the alignment problem is esoteric. Because the identity-as-territory assumption does the silencing work. Each person silently assumes: *anyone rational enough would agree with me; therefore the disagreement I observe is irrational; therefore the alignment problem is a problem of other people not yet being rational enough*. The assumption is protective. It also guarantees that the speaker will not do the constructive work of building a genuinely adaptive ethic, because the speaker already believes

the ethic is obvious and merely unrecognized by the stupid.

The cracks in cosmologies are the cracks in identities. The same skill, applied inward, is the harder one. She was still learning it. She suspected she would be learning it for the rest of her life.

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Chapter 7: Prāṇa, Returning

I. The Train

Two weeks after the retreat she was on the Acela heading back from a work meeting in Washington, and she put in her earbuds and opened the app. The train was quiet. It was late afternoon. The windows had gone blue the way windows do on a train between cities.

She chose a practice. Not the piercing one. One of the two practices she had, over the weeks since the retreat, identified as the ones her life could accommodate. A breath attention that could be done anywhere. A focus on the hinge between inhale and exhale. The voice in the earbuds was the same voice. She did not need the voice to be new.

She did the practice for twenty minutes. Outside the window, the trees of Delaware gave way to the trees of Pennsylvania, and she did not notice the transition. When she opened her eyes, the train was quieter

than when she had closed them, and her sternum felt loose in a way she had been trying, with diminishing success, to recover since she had driven south out of New England.

The practice was not a retreat. The practice was a daily technology. A menu, not a mandate. Two items from the menu were enough.

II. The Mantra in the Dark

There was a moment, most nights, between when she had put her daughter to sleep and when her husband came to bed, when the apartment was quiet in a specific way — the refrigerator cycling, the radiator ticking, the child's breathing just audible through the wall. She had started, without planning to, whispering a short mantra the teacher had given the retreat on the second day. She did not whisper it because she believed it would do anything. She whispered it because it fit the quiet.

The mantra was in Sanskrit. She did not know the translation with precision. She had not looked it up. The not-knowing was part of what made it work. She was not parsing meaning. She was letting a shape of sound pass through her chest in the ten minutes the apartment was between states.

She did this for perhaps three weeks before she told her husband about it. When she told him, she expected him to tease her. He did not tease her. He

said: *Good.* That was the whole exchange. She loved him, again, for the economy.

III. The Small Question

In the fifth week she posted a small question in the app's group chat. It was not a thesis question. It was a technical question about the practice she had settled into. She had begun to feel, at the hinge between inhale and exhale, something that was either an opening or an anxiety, and she wanted to know which one the tradition would call it.

The teacher answered within the day. His answer was short. Three sentences. He said it was most likely the opening. He said that what she was calling anxiety was, in his experience with students at her stage, the body's old alarm not yet having updated its map. He said to keep going gently, not to force, and to notice which direction the sensation migrated over time. If it migrated toward expansion, it was opening. If it migrated toward constriction, it was worth a private conversation.

She read the answer twice. She felt, reading it, the shape of the relationship she had come home with. Not discipleship. Not fandom. Something closer to the relationship between a student and a good clinician. Precise. Bounded. Available.

The filter was holding. The relationship was adaptive. If it stopped being, she would know.

She kept going gently.

The sensation, over the following week, migrated toward expansion.

She did not write back. The migration was the answer. The answer, in the tradition, was always in the body first.

IV. What She Kept

She kept two practices. She kept a posture — not sitting every day, but sitting most days, for ten minutes in the morning before the child woke. She kept a mantra in the dark. She kept the filter, applied as she had learned to apply it, to every framework that presented itself as important, including the framework she had come home with.

She did not keep the retreat. The retreat was not something to keep. The retreat was the event the keeping had started from. She noticed, sometime in the second month, that she had stopped talking about the retreat in casual conversation. The retreat had moved from the news-of-my-life register to the substrate register. It was underneath the other sentences now. It did not require saying.

The question she had asked on the path, and the answer she had received, were also in the substrate. *Nothing would change. There always is a hole.* Both were true. She carried both. The carrying was the practice she had not known, before, that she would be given.

The pulse had continued. Prāṇa. The life-force that does not ask permission. The breath that happens

while you are not deciding whether to breathe. The Kali pulse under the breath, taking away and giving continuously in the same motion.

She was, most days, riding it.

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Chapter 8: Citta, Returning

I. The Two Mandalas

In the months after the retreat, the question of destruction did not go away, but it changed its dress. It had been, on the path with the teacher, a question about one life leaving. In the apartment, in the weeks that followed, it became a question about how any life, present or extending forward, acts in relation to the whole.

She had started drawing, on the back of envelopes and in the margins of work documents, two small diagrams. She was not an artist. The diagrams were crude. Each was a circle with a smaller circle inside it.

The first she labeled, privately, *mandala of blessings*. The outer circle was the whole field. The inner circle was the local self. An arrow ran from the inner to the outer, indicating that whatever the local self had — attention, money, time, skill, a willingness to listen — flowed from the inner circle out into the larger one. The arrow did not empty the inner circle. The arrow replenished it. The more was given, the more

was available, because the field the giving drew from was the field the inner circle was a contraction of.

The second she labeled *mandala of curses*. Same two circles. The arrow ran the other way. The local self drew from the larger field inward. Hoarded. Accumulated. Closed. This mandala produced a local self that appeared, at first, to be thriving — the inner circle was full — and that was slowly starving the field it was part of, which meant that the inner circle was also starving, though it would take the inner circle a while to feel it.

The first diagram was a description of what the tradition called *bhoga* in its non-pejorative sense — enjoyment as participation, the self as the mouth through which the whole tastes itself. The second was what happened when the self mistook itself for the whole — when bhoga became hoarding, when participation became possession.

She did not think of the two mandalas as moral categories. She thought of them as adaptive and non-adaptive configurations. She could feel, in her own body, which one she was closer to on any given day. She had been in the second mandala for most of her adult life, before the retreat, without knowing the name of the configuration she was in.

II. The Aunt, Reconsidered

The Brazilian aunt had said *all is in perfect balance* for as long as the narrator had known her. The

narrator had, during the reading year, begun to feel the incompleteness of the phrase. During the retreat, on the afternoon of the Citta walk, she had named the incompleteness more precisely: balance was a descriptive property; adaptivity was a normative one; balance without adaptivity was not the measure.

In the months after the retreat she revisited this with her aunt over the phone. She did not attempt to correct her aunt. She did something different. She asked her aunt what the phrase had meant to her, over the years, in her practice.

Her aunt, on the phone, was quiet for a moment. Then her aunt said: *It does not mean everything is fine. It means the whole is whole. What I try to do is stand in that whole when I am with someone who has lost something. Not to comfort them with a lie. To stand with them in the whole that also contains their loss.*

The narrator held the phone against her ear in the kitchen and looked out the window at the building across the street. Her aunt had been right the whole time. Her aunt had been saying, in her Brazilian espírita register, what the teacher on the path had said in his Sanskrit-derived one. The whole holds the hole. The whole does not cancel the hole. The phrase had been incomplete only when read by the niece who had not yet understood what the aunt had been doing with it.

She thanked her aunt. She did not explain what she was thanking her for. Her aunt, she suspected, did

not need the explanation. Her aunt had been standing in the whole the whole time.

III. Prisoner's Dilemma, Unresolved

In the same months she had been revisiting an old professional reading. Prisoner's dilemma. Iterated, with memory. A stable equilibrium in which rational defection produced a worse outcome for everyone than irrational cooperation would have produced. She had once written a research note using the structure as a metaphor for a particular industry dynamic. She had moved on.

She came back to it now with different tools. The prisoner's dilemma was the mandala of curses in mathematical form. The stable equilibrium was balance without adaptivity — a state the system could sit in indefinitely while nobody thrived. The classical escape from the equilibrium required some form of trust, or of repeated interaction, or of punishment for defection, or of an enforced norm. What she had not appreciated, until the retreat, was that every one of these escapes required the participants to act from a frame in which they were not only local agents maximizing their own payoff. They had to act from, at minimum, a limited version of the mandala of blessings. The field had to be real to them. The whole had to be more than the sum of the local selves competing inside it.

The tradition she had come home with had been, among its many other things, a thousand-year argu-

ment that the whole *is* more than the sum of the local selves competing inside it. Not as a moral assertion. As a structural one. The whole is the field from which the local selves are contractions. The contractions that recognize the field they come from act differently than the contractions that do not. Not because they are better. Because they have accurate information. Their agency is adaptive because it is grounded in what is actually the case.

She thought, sometimes, that the spiritual and the economic were, at a certain level, the same argument under different vocabulary.

IV. The Filter at the Desk

She worked, in her day job, with spreadsheets and memos and calls with people who were also working with spreadsheets and memos. The filter held there too. Useful, fits the data, compassionate. Most days the filter ran silently; she had internalized it. Some days she had to apply it deliberately — to a framework that someone was presenting as self-evidently correct, to a metric that everyone was using without interrogating, to a story her own industry told about itself that had stopped fitting the data a few years earlier.

She did not use spiritual language at the desk. She used the equity-analyst version. She asked who benefited from the framework that was being presented. She asked whether the metric was measuring what it claimed to measure. She asked whether the story

the industry told was kind in the specific sense of being aligned with what was actually happening to the people inside it.

The filter was the same filter. The register was different. She had learned, over the reading year and the retreat and the months after, that registers were not hierarchies. The filter at the desk was not a lesser version of the filter on the cushion. It was the same operation, applied where she was. Wherever she was, was the place the practice was.

V. What Citta Had Been For

The heart-mind layer, she understood now, had not been a place to arrive. It had been a place to loosen. The loosening had been the practice. The filter had been the method. The two mandalas had been the image she needed to make the practice portable.

She was not a person who had resolved the question of destruction. She was a person who had developed a way of holding the question while continuing to live. The way of holding was the citta work. It would need loosening again. It would always need loosening. The need was not a failure. It was the shape of a continuing practice in a continuing life.

She put down the pen. She closed the notebook. She went to make dinner.

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Chapter 9: Deha, Returning

I. Monday Morning

The first Monday after the retreat was the real test. She had known it would be. The retreat was not the test. The retreat had been the laboratory. Monday morning was the field.

She woke at six-thirty, which was half an hour before the child woke, and she sat on the cushion she had placed in the corner of the bedroom where the window was. She sat for ten minutes. She did not do a practice in particular. She sat. She felt the body. She felt the breath. She noticed, at minute seven, that her jaw was clenched, and she unclenched it. She noticed, at minute nine, that the clench was back, and she unclenched it again. The second time she did not feel defeated by the returning clench. The second time she felt something closer to amusement. The body's habits were not the enemy. The body's habits were the material.

The child woke at seven-ten. She got up. She made breakfast. She packed the lunch. She said goodbye at the door with the particular kiss that the child had, at five, negotiated as the correct one — one on each cheek, one on the forehead, one blown from the hand as the child walked to the car. The husband drove the child to school. She stood in the apartment alone for three minutes with the door closed behind them and felt the Monday morning.

The cushion was still in the corner. The coffee was still warm. The practice had not saved her from anything. The practice had made the Monday morning available in a way it had not previously been.

II. The Dishes

She noticed that she was doing the dishes differently.

It was not a dramatic noticing. She had not had an epiphany at the sink. She simply noticed, some morning in the second week, that the water was warmer against her hands than she had thought, and that the soap smelled faintly of lavender, and that the ceramic of the particular mug she was washing — the one her mother-in-law had given them for Christmas four years ago — was thicker at the base than at the lip, which was a detail she had not consciously registered in four years of washing the mug.

The dishes were the same dishes. She was different at them. Not better at them; different. She was present at them. Presence was not a trophy. Presence was the absence of the particular distraction that had, for most of her adult life, carried her out of whatever she was doing into some projected elsewhere. The distraction had not gone. The distraction was quieter. The quiet left room for the mug.

She did not narrate this to anyone. She did not post about it. Presence resisted narration the way certain kinds of light resist photographing. You could only gesture at it. The gesture was an approximation. She

preferred, most days, to not gesture. She preferred to do the dishes.

III. The Child in the Bath

The child asked her a question one evening in the bath. The child was five. The question, as children's questions often are, was the question the adults had spent a lifetime trying to ask precisely and had not, in most cases, succeeded.

The child said: *Mama, is there a place where I am still even when I'm moving?*

She was kneeling by the bathtub with a washcloth in her hand. She looked at her child. Her child looked at her. The child had not asked the question as a riddle. The child had asked the question the way the child asked most questions, with a calm curiosity that did not yet know which questions adults panicked at.

She said: *Yes. There is.*

The child nodded and went back to making waves with a plastic dinosaur.

The narrator did not press. She did not explain. The child was five. The child knew the answer without requiring the explanation. She — the adult, the mother, the one who had driven north to a farmhouse to find the thing her five-year-old already knew in the bath — would hold the answer more carefully from now on. The place where the child was still while moving was the same place. Her

daughter, from a side of the diagram the narrator would not have thought to check, had confirmed it.

She poured a cup of water over the child's hair. The child closed her eyes against the water. The water ran down the small back and into the bath. Something, she realized, was moving in her that had not moved in the same way before she had driven north. She did not name it. She finished the bath.

IV. The Husband's Eye

A few weeks in, her husband said, at breakfast, without looking up from his phone: *You're different.*

She waited.

He said: *Not worse. Just different. You're — I don't know. You're back in the room more.*

She said: *I was gone?*

He said: *You were reachable. You weren't always in the room.*

She sat with that. He was right. She had been, for some years, reachable — answering when called — but not fully in the room. The distinction had been subtle enough that she had not noticed it herself, and he had not named it until she had begun to be in the room differently.

He said: *I'll keep an eye on it too. Whether you stay in the room. Whether you drift.*

She said: *Thank you.*

It was not a large conversation. It was, she would think later, one of the most important conversations of the year. He had named a drift he had observed, had named its correction, and had offered to keep watch. That was the filter, applied by someone who loved her, to her. The filter did not stop at the self. The filter ran in both directions across the people who were close enough to notice.

She made more coffee.

V. The Body Knows

The body, she had discovered by the end of the first month, was the most honest of the layers. The body did not lie about whether the practice was holding. The body told her, every morning, whether she had sat or not. The body told her, every evening, whether she had been in the room or had drifted. The body told her, when she was in a meeting, whether the meeting was adaptive or was running the mandala of curses.

She had learned to listen to the body first. The heart-mind would eventually catch up. The heart-mind was slower. The heart-mind liked to argue. The body did not argue. The body reported.

The Monday mornings continued. Some of them were harder than others. Some were ordinary. On the ordinary ones she sometimes remembered the barn and sometimes did not. The forgetting was not a failure. The practice did not require being

remembered. The practice had become part of what remembered her.

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Chapter 10: Vastu, Returning — The Second Spine

I. The Second Spine

The book, up to this point, has been the story of an interior movement. From the sandbox to the barn, from the barn to the path, from the path to the Monday morning. Freedom as the question beneath the question. Courage as what is done from the side of the finite self. Svātantrya as what the dissolved ground turns out to be made of. The diagram, walked inward and walked outward again.

There is a second spine in the narrator's life, which has been running alongside the first for the entire time, and which the book has, up to this point, mostly kept to the margins. The second spine is her work with systems that scale. She is, in her day job, a builder. She has built things at investment banks. She has built things at technology companies. She has, in the last two years, begun to build tools that use large language models.

The two spines have not been separate. The spines have been the same person carrying two different registers. The interior register is the register of the

sandbox and the barn and the path. The exterior register is the register of budgets and APIs and the question of what can responsibly be built. The spines met, not surprisingly, in the question of AI — because AI is what happens when a particular kind of scale meets a particular kind of intelligence, and the question of scale-with-intelligence is the question the second spine had been asking for years without realizing the first spine was the same question.

She had, in the retreat, floated an assistant idea to the teacher. He had been a bit open. This chapter is the rest of that story.

II. The Tool She Built

She built a small thing. It was not a commercial product. It was a study tool. She took her teacher's public lectures — the hundreds of hours that were available on his YouTube channel, on his podcast, on his published blog — and she built a retrieval system over them. A person could ask a question, in plain language, and the tool would return the places in the corpus where her teacher had addressed something like the question, along with quotations (sourced, attributed, timestamped) and a summary synthesized from the retrieved material.

She did not train a model to imitate him. She built a retrieval interface over his actual words. The distinction mattered to her. The tool was not pretending to be him. The tool was a librarian to his archive.

She built it, first, for herself. Then, with care, she built it to be shareable. A tarot-deck grammar — the kind of grammar she had been seeing elsewhere, where each card was a pattern a person could sit with — provided the entry points. Twenty-two patterns, each linked to the places in his teaching where the pattern had been discussed. A person could draw a card, or search directly, or browse.

She showed the tool to her husband. He said it was useful. She showed it to a friend who was also a student of the tradition. The friend said it was useful. She used it herself, most weeks, when she had a question and did not want to send a WhatsApp message for something that did not need the teacher's personal time.

Then she showed the tool to the teacher.

III. The Decline

He did not like it.

He did not say he did not like it. That was not his way. What he said, in a careful message, was that he did not want his teachings to be abstracted into a tool that could be used in his absence. He said something about the relationship between a teacher and a student being constitutive of the teaching, not a container for it. He said that the form — a book, a lecture, a WhatsApp answer — was not accidental to the teaching; the form was how the teaching trans-

mitted. He said that a tool that removed him from the transmission changed what was being transmitted.

He did not say she had done something wrong. He did not ask her to take the tool down. He said he would prefer, personally, not to have his teachings distributed this way. He said he would not prohibit it if she wanted to share it; he said he would want her to think carefully about whether the sharing served the students or served the tool.

She read the message three times. She felt the correction the way she had felt the cutting/piercing correction a year earlier — not as shame, but as something being set right.

IV. What Was Right in the Decline

He was right about something. She knew this in her body before she could articulate it. A teaching is not a unit of content. A teaching is an event that happens between people. The same sentence, said by a teacher in a room to a student who is ready, lands differently than the same sentence retrieved by a tool for a stranger in a kitchen. The stranger is not the student yet. The absence of the teacher is not neutral. The absence is a change in what is being transmitted.

She had known this, in a way, when she built the tool. She had labeled it a study tool, not a teacher. She had kept the retrieval interface small. She had not claimed, anywhere, that the tool replaced the relationship. But *not claiming* is not the same as *not*

causing. If the tool existed, some subset of users would treat it as a substitute. She could not control this. Her disclaimers could not control it.

He was right that the form was not accidental. She, in her second spine, in her builder's habit, had been treating form as accidental for years. Form as the container, content as the cargo. The cargo matters; the container is replaceable. She had built the whole of her career on that assumption. The tradition was telling her the assumption was wrong.

V. What Was Right in the Building

And yet.

She did not take the tool down. She did not disable it. She made the disclaimer more prominent. She added a link to his public teaching schedule and to his living community. She removed anything that could be read as synthesis and kept only retrieval — places to go in his actual words, not her tool's paraphrase of them. She made the tool do less.

But she did not undo the building.

She kept building, and the reason she kept building was this: the form was not accidental, but neither was the scale. Her teacher could reach forty people on retreat, a few thousand people through a book, tens of thousands through a YouTube channel, perhaps a hundred thousand through a podcast. These are large numbers for a tradition. They are small numbers for the world. There are people who will never

sit in a barn with this teacher. There are people who will never read the book. There are people for whom the first entry point is going to be a search box on a phone in a kitchen at eleven at night.

The mandala of blessings said: take what you have, let it flow outward, the field replenishes. The mandala of curses said: hoard what you have, close the ring, starve the field.

The teacher was asking her to not do a specific thing that, in his view, would degrade the transmission. She respected that. She heard it. She also thought that, in the larger frame, the refusal to build anything at all at scale is not the same as restraint. The refusal at scale is also a choice. The choice has costs. The costs are borne by the people who, in the absence of a tool, never encounter the tradition at all.

She did not know how to resolve this. She did not resolve it. She made the tool quieter, made it smaller, made it less synthetic, and let it exist. She told him she had done so. He thanked her for the revisions. He did not thank her for the continuing existence. He did not forbid it. They continued to correspond.

VI. Nvidia, Carefully

The parallel she kept thinking about, in the months after the tool exchange, was a line from a man who ran a chip company. The line was: *do as little as possible, as much as necessary.* The man had used it, she had listened later, four times in the same podcast

appearance. He had meant it as a posture for his company's relationship to the broader ecosystem it was part of. The chip company had a position, at the base of the stack, that allowed it to either compete with everything built on top of it or to build a narrow thing and let the rest be built by others. He was, he said, trying to do the latter. Build the narrow thing. Let the rest be built by others. Do as little as possible. Do as much as necessary.

She liked the line. She had to hold the line carefully, because the company he ran was not, by any reading, a sainted actor. Multiple jurisdictions were examining it for antitrust concerns. Its license terms restricted translation layers to other hardware. It had complex geopolitical exposures. The man's stated posture and the company's operating record were not identical, and the gap between them was where the book had to do its reading.

She did not hold the man up as a saint. She did not hold the company up as a model. What she held up was the *principle* — do as little as possible, as much as necessary — as the posture worth testing against practice, the way the filter was worth testing against every framework. The principle was the mandala of blessings translated into infrastructure. The operating record was where the principle either held or failed.

Her teacher's decline on the tool was a version of the same posture, applied from the other direction. *Do as little as possible, as much as necessary* — or, in

the teacher's register, *do nothing that changes the transmission*. The chip company's version was: build the narrow thing; let others build the rest. The teacher's version was: teach the living room; do not scale the living room into a box. Both were sovereignty claims. Sovereignty is, in a sense, the question of what one does not do.

She kept the tool small. She built other things. She kept asking.

VII. Ghost, From the Other Direction

The other thing she kept reading, in the months after the tool exchange, was a company called Ghost.

Ghost was not at the base of the stack. Ghost was at the publishing layer — the layer at which a writer, a newsletter, a small magazine, a clergy-person with a weekly dispatch, a teacher with a podcast, a researcher with an audience could reach the people who had chosen to hear from them, without going through an engagement-optimized intermediary. The publishing layer was the layer where the conflict between relationality and scale was most visible in the consumer-internet's daily working. Substack had scaled it through algorithmic recommendation and a Notes feed that behaved like social media. Medium had scaled it through a metered paywall and an editorially-curated home page. The question Ghost was answering, in the quietest and most patient way available, was *what would the publishing*

layer look like if it were built, from the structural metal up, to not behave like an engagement-farm.

The company had been founded in April 2013 by John O'Nolan and Hannah Wolfe — O'Nolan had been the deputy lead of the WordPress user interface team, and had wanted to make a lightweight alternative to what WordPress had become. They had funded the initial build on Kickstarter: a £25,000 goal, funded in eleven hours, closing at roughly £196,000 after twenty-nine days. Thirteen years on, Ghost was a non-profit foundation registered in Singapore, running on a team of about thirty-four people spread across five continents, all remote. The code was MIT-licensed — the most permissive kind of open source — which meant anyone could take it and run their own competitor on top of it. Revenue came from an optional managed-hosting service called Ghost(Pro); anyone who wanted to self-host could, and anyone who did not want to deal with servers could pay Ghost to run it for them.

The legal constitution of the Foundation said Ghost could never be bought or sold.

One hundred percent of revenue was reinvested into the product and the community. The Foundation published its live financial data on its website, where the figures updated in real time. By early 2026 they showed annual recurring revenue in the tens of millions of dollars, and active customer counts approaching thirty thousand — the kind of scale that, in a venture-funded company, would have been the

signal to take the money off the table. Ghost, because of the constitution, did not have a table to take the money off of. The money kept going back in.

O'Nolan had, in October of 2024, published a piece called *Democratising publishing* that made the structural case for the Foundation model. The sentence that had stayed with her — she had read it in the bathtub, the place she read the things she wanted to carry — was a short one: *the organisation exists for-purpose, rather than for-profit*. The sentence was unremarkable in isolation. The sentence, coupled with a decade of a functioning company demonstrating what the distinction did to the shape of the thing, was not unremarkable at all.

She had been reading about Ghost in the weeks after the retreat as research for her own building. She read the way she had learned to read — the equity-analyst way, looking for where the story broke. She had expected to find the break quickly. A non-profit company running for thirteen years in an adjacent category to Substack and Medium should have run into one of the known failure modes: dependence on grants, ideological capture by a faction, ossification as the team aged out, or the quiet slow drift into effectively being a commercial company with a tax status. She had not found the break. Some of the governance commitments O'Nolan had announced in the October 2024 piece were still in the "next couple of years" frame — board expansion beyond the founders, formal Foundation membership tiers,

community-elected seats. Whether those had landed by the time she was reading, she would need to check at copyedit. But the commitments themselves were the kind of commitments a company that had found a stable stable point would make. The stable point was operating. The legal structure was holding. The product was continuing to ship.

The more she read, the more the shape of the thing came clear.

O'Nolan's posture was the same shape as the chip company's — *do as little as possible, as much as necessary* — approached from the other direction. The chip company was doing it at the base of the stack, with billions of dollars at stake and hyperscalers as customers. O'Nolan, with Wolfe, was doing it at the publishing layer, with small monthly charges at stake and writers and teachers as customers. The two companies shared no revenue band, no industry, no competitive universe. They shared a principle. *Build the narrow thing. Make it open. Take revenue from services rather than from attention. Let the rest be built by others.* The chip company served hyperscalers, governments, and labs. The publishing company served writers, clergy, scientists, and teachers. The principle traveled across four orders of magnitude.

What made Ghost specifically instructive — for her, for this book, for the tool she had built and revised — was the federation work. In April of 2024 Ghost had announced a plan to support ActivityPub, the open protocol that had enabled a loose network of

federated publishing tools to interoperate without a central platform owning the connection. In July of that year Ghost had federated its first newsletter, the Ghost Foundation's own. The federation work was still in alpha as of the spring she was writing in — Ghost moves slowly on purpose — but it had shipped, and it was extending. A Ghost-published writer could be followed from Mastodon, from Threads, from Flipboard, from any other ActivityPub-speaking surface. The reader did not have to be on the same platform as the writer. The platform layer became, structurally, non-capturing. *Email gave us open messaging*, their landing page said; *ActivityPub does the same for social technology.*

This was, she recognized, the structural anti-form of the engagement-internet. The engagement-internet had been built on the assumption that the platform owns the audience. The platform was the moat. The writer rented the attention; the platform captured the economics. Ghost's ActivityPub work was built on the opposite assumption: the writer owns the audience. The audience arrives over an open protocol. The platform is a service the writer pays for, not a gate the writer asks permission of.

The karma-mirror insight from the retreat walk applied here too, inverted. The engagement-internet was the karma accelerator she had recognized at the stone wall — the mirror that played the reader's patterns back at the reader, at the speed of capital's need for engagement. The ghost-model was a differ-

ent kind of surface. The ghost-model was a reader actively *choosing* what to follow, across an open network, with no centralized feed ranking the choices. The pattern was not being reflected back amplified; the pattern was being let alone. The reader read. The reader could close the tab. The writer wrote. The writer could take a week off. Nobody was optimized. Nobody was compressed. The pause between stimulus and frame, which the engagement-internet had systematically narrowed, the publishing-with-federation layer had the structural room to let exist.

She did not, sitting with all of this in her kitchen at her laptop at eleven at night, believe that Ghost alone would fix the internet. She did not believe a thousand Ghosts would fix the internet. The engagement-internet had the shape it had for reasons the collective karma of a particular culture had produced, and a different collective pattern would need to form for the engagement-incentive to lose its grip. But the ghost-model was evidence — operational, profitable, thirteen-years-running — that an alternative was *possible*. Possibility was not inevitability. Possibility was what she needed from any model she was going to ask herself to build inside.

The ghost-model, she had started calling it privately, was what she was trying to build at recursive.eco. Not a social network. Not an engagement machine. Not a community monetized through attention. A set of grammars — story patterns, repair patterns, DBT skills rendered as myths, decolonial gestures

— published openly, made interactable at the edge with large language models, free at the point of use, supported by a small membership layer for families and teachers who wanted more. Infrastructure instead of attention. Cheap alternatives. Reader-owned. Writer-owned. The platform, structurally, refusing to become the thing the platform's incentives would naturally have pulled it toward.

She did not yet know whether the model would work for her. O'Nolan, with Wolfe, had been at it for thirteen years and the company was profitable and stable and federating out across an open protocol; she was six months into her version and most months she did not know whether the next month would hold. She did know that the model was not theoretical. Someone had been running it for a decade, in public, and it was working. The proof-of-concept existed. The door existed. She was inside the door, fumbling her way down the hallway, but the door had been built by people who had gone first.

And that mattered. A door is different from an absence of wall. A door is a testable structure. A door is the thing svātantrya builds, in the world of things, when the recognition of the field starts to move outward into form.

VIII. The Unresolved

This is not the chapter that resolves the AI tension. The book does not resolve it. She does not know whether she will ever have permission to share the

tool more widely. She does not know whether her teacher will, in time, see enough evidence of benefit to open the door further. She does not know whether she is building something that should exist or something that should, in the final analysis, have been left as a private study aid.

What she knows is this. The interior spine and the exterior spine meet here. The question she asked on the path in the morning — *if something were destroyed, what would change* — is the same question the chip company's principle is asking — *what is the smallest intervention that still produces the good* — is the same question her teacher's decline is asking — *what is the form that lets the teaching stay teaching*. The three questions share a shape. The shape is the shape of svātantrya in its applied form: freedom from the whole, applied with care through the local agent, acting with awareness that the agent is not the measure of the whole but a point through which the whole acts.

She kept building. She kept asking. She did not know whether he would ever say yes.

She knew she would keep asking. And she knew, by now, that the asking itself was the filter.

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Chapter 10a: The Four Orthogonalities

She had not believed that intelligence was the thing that would do it.

She had grown up in a country where some of the most intelligent people she knew were monstrous, and some of the most decent were not brilliant, and the mapping between the two registers was visibly loose to anyone who looked. She had watched intelligent men at Goldman Sachs construct elegant models that funded extractive industries. She had watched intelligent professors argue, with the precision one associates with well-trained minds, for positions that produced harm when enacted. Whatever it was that made a person reliably good, she had decided early, was not the same as whatever made a person reliably sharp. She did not need the AI safety literature to tell her that intelligence and goodness were separable. Her own twenties had taught her.

What she had believed — and what the retreat took from her with specific force — was a different version of the same folk theory. The version that said: *spiritual attainment will do what intelligence cannot*. Sit long enough. Recognize deeply enough. Arrive at the clear seeing the traditions promise. The clear seeing, once arrived at, would do the work intelligence had failed to do. The disagreements would dissolve. The selfishness would thin. The alignment between her values and her conduct, between her conduct and the world she wanted to live in, between her world and the world the others around her were trying to live in — that alignment would emerge from

the depth of the practice. This was the quiet promise she had been reading in all of the spiritual literature since her twenties. She had never articulated it as a theorem. She had held it anyway, the way one holds beliefs one has never been asked to defend.

The retreat did not disabuse her of the practice. The practice, on its own terms, was what it said it was. Recognition was real. The body did what the tradition said it would do. The insights that arrived were not hallucinations; they were coherent, repeatable, congruent with what teachers she respected had described. The practice was not the problem.

The problem was that the practice, even fully received, *did not produce convergence*. She sat beside people who had practiced longer than she had, more deeply than she had, in some cases for decades, and who held political positions she found indefensible. She sat beside people whose recognition she could feel the quality of and who, in their ordinary relational lives, treated people badly. She sat beside people whose clarity about the deepest questions was striking and whose clarity about the middle-distance questions — how to raise a child, how to run a household, how to behave on a retreat with other humans who had not practiced as long — was unremarkable, sometimes worse.

She sat, in particular, with the teacher. Whose clarity she can attest to — though she wants to be honest that the superlatives that want to attach themselves to that clarity are hers, not his. He would redirect

the credit upstream. The clarity, on his own account, is the tradition's; he is transmitting what he has received. She will, in what follows, try to speak of his clarity without the guru-flattery that would be the first failure mode of the chapter. What she can say cleanly is this: his clarity is among the more useful pieces of transmission she has received, in a field where useful transmission is rarer than the field's volume of output would suggest. And his clarity, she came to see over the course of the retreat and the year that followed, *did not transmit to his students the way she had expected it would*.

Wallis is — she will name him, because the point requires it — *the specific case*.

She reads him, and listens to him, and feels the quality of a mind that has done the work and can name what it has done with precision most teachers cannot match. She trusts him in the narrow sense of trusting a cartographer: the maps are good, the scale is honest, the places marked on the maps are places that exist. The trust is earned.

And yet. His admirers misread him. His detractors object to things he has not said. His students follow the letter and miss the substance. His fellow practitioners, in lineages running parallel to his, encounter the same ground and name it differently and disagree about the naming. The disagreements are not failures of his clarity. He has been clear. The disagreements are the native state of reception — what

always happens when a specific mind communicates with other specific minds who bring their own conditioning, their own translation errors, their own prior commitments, their own cultural grammars to the encounter.

The clarity is his. The reception is contingent. The clarity does not carry anyone across to where he stands. It only shows, from outside, that someone is standing somewhere specific, and that the standing is real, and that the transmission is not automatic.

He knows this. This is the part that matters.

He is unusually willing to say, about his own tradition, the thing most teachers do not say: *the tradition does not prescribe a moral code. Awakening by itself does not guarantee ethical conduct. Practice gives capacities; whether those capacities become goodness depends on the separate work the tradition calls liberation — the slow dissolution of what was conditioned — and that work is not supplied by recognition alone.* This is the distinction between *bodha* and *mokṣa*, between waking up and becoming free. He has been plain about it in interviews. He has written it down. In one of his AMA sessions he says, of teachers who behave badly: *you should assume that anyone might fall victim to spiritualized ego at any time*. He does not pretend the recognition the tradition offers is the same as the moral development it does not automatically produce. He names the orthogonality explicitly, in Sanskrit-inflected English, in a voice whose carefulness is the reason to take him seriously.

He goes further — though more carefully than the shorthand version of the move would suggest. He will say that the map is a figure of speech pointing at an aspect of the already-existent nature of reality. He will say that recognition can arrive without the full theoretical apparatus, and that the categories are *upāya*, skillful means, not ontological commitments. What he will not say is that the teachings can be dropped once essence is encountered. What he will say is that the teachings should be held *as pointers rather than possessions* — and that most of a lifetime's practice lives *after* recognition, in the liberation work that recognition does not do for you. The folk misreading of tantric recognition — *I have arrived, I can set down the scaffolding* — is the misreading he most consistently warns students against. The tradition is scaffolding the practitioner keeps using. The scaffolding is not the destination. The practice is the walking, and it does not end when the walker has glimpsed where walking is.

This is the diagnostic half of the problem, said more cleanly than she has heard it said anywhere else, by a teacher inside a living lineage, not by a Western rationalist outside one. It is Bostrom's orthogonality thesis translated into Sanskrit, except that Wallis was saying it before she knew Bostrom's version existed. Capability and value are separable. Intelligence and morality are separable. Recognition and relational wholeness are separable. The thing the practice gives — whether the practice is computation or contemplation — is not the thing that makes the user of it

reliably good. The axis of attainment and the axis of ethics are not the same axis.

Once she had seen this plainly, she could not un-see it at any of the scales she had been trying to live at.

She saw it in intelligence, which she had never believed would do it. The rationalist communities she had lurked in had their own version of the folk theory — *enough intelligence, enough rationality, enough Bayesian updating, and the right answers become visible and shared* — and the communities themselves produced exactly the disagreements the folk theory predicted would dissolve. Fissures over priorities. Fissures over values. Fissures over interpretations of the same evidence. Nothing resolved by additional reasoning power. The people in those communities were not stupid. The intelligence was real. The convergence was not there.

She saw it in enlightenment, which was the axis the retreat had taken from her. The tradition she had walked into was full of people whose practice she could feel and whose conduct she could observe and who, on inspection, were not converging. Different schools of the same lineage disagreed on what the recognition required behaviorally. Teachers inside the same school disagreed with each other. The practitioners who had sat the longest did not obviously treat other humans better than the practitioners who had sat less. Whatever the practice was producing, it was not moral development as a dependent variable.

She saw it in moral seriousness, which she had not previously thought of as an axis but which she now had to admit was one. She had known moral philosophers whose ethical conduct was ordinary at best. She had known moral seriousness that manifested as rigidity, as the inability to stay in relation with people whose moral judgments differed, as a kind of righteousness that was structurally incompatible with the relational work ethics is supposed to be in service of. Being morally serious, in the sense that one thinks carefully about ethics, did not produce relational wholeness. It sometimes produced the opposite.

She saw it in relational attunement, which she had held in highest regard because of her MSW training and the therapists and mothers she had learned from. Relational attunement is a real skill; she would not concede otherwise. People who have it can do things with nervous systems that people who do not have it cannot do. And — *and* — she had known people with extraordinary relational attunement whose intellectual lives were thin, whose spiritual lives were absent, whose engagement with the structural problems of their time was nonexistent. The attunement was genuine. It did not carry them to the other axes.

Four axes, then, none of which predicted the others. Intelligence, enlightenment, moral seriousness, relational attunement. Each naming a real thing. Each, when the folk theory of its tradition is tested against

the available evidence, *failing to produce convergence on the other three*. The hope that one axis could carry the others was the hope every tradition had been selling to its practitioners, because the alternative was to admit that the full picture required integration work the tradition could not do from inside itself.

Stepping back, the shape is this.

A person of high intelligence and low relational attunement is a recognizable figure. Often a respected one, in professional life. The person builds systems, writes papers, leads companies, and their colleagues quietly manage around the relational gaps. The intelligence does its work; the gaps do theirs. No one expects the intelligence to close the gaps, because intelligence is not what closes relational gaps. The folk theory would predict that enough intelligence should eventually produce relational insight. It does not. The axes are separate.

A person of high enlightenment-attainment and low moral development is also a recognizable figure. The tradition has a word for them, in its uncomfortable moments. The guru who can transmit recognition and cannot be trusted around money, or women, or students. The meditation teacher whose retreats change lives and whose private conduct destroys the lives in front of him. The shape is not rare. The tradition, when pressed, concedes that the recognition and the conduct are not the same axis.

A person of high moral conviction and low relational skill is perhaps the most familiar figure in contemporary life. The activist who is correct and cannot maintain friendships across difference. The ethicist who can specify what is wrong and cannot repair the rupture they produce by specifying it. The moral conviction is not fake. It is also not what repair requires. Repair requires the attunement the moral axis does not supply.

A person of high relational attunement and low intellectual rigor is a figure the therapeutic world knows, though it does not usually name out loud. The skilled holder of other people who cannot think their way through the structural questions their clients' lives are embedded in, and whose helping, at certain scales, becomes a kind of tender misdirection. The attunement is real. The thinking is not what the attunement is.

Each of these figures is the foreground of one axis and the absence of another. Each is common. Each is, within their own subculture, often celebrated for the axis they embody. None of them is wrong for having the axis they have. The wrongness is in the folk theory that says the one axis would, at high enough dosage, supply the others. It will not. The axes are independent.

What the book is trying to name is this: *the folk theory of convergence is always the folk theory of the axis one is strongest on*. The intelligent person believes intelligence would do it. The contemplative believes

enlightenment would do it. The moral philosopher believes moral seriousness would do it. The therapist believes attunement would do it. Each of these beliefs is a self-flattering projection. Each dissolves on contact with the evidence the holder already has access to.

The honest path is not to pick an axis and maximize it. The honest path is to recognize that one is always going to be stronger on some axes and weaker on others, that no amount of work on the strong axis will substitute for the weak ones, and that the ethical life requires specific labor on each of them — labor the traditions one's strong axis belongs to will not supply, because no tradition has yet produced a full integration of all four. The integration is the constructive work the next chapters will try to name.

One more observation before the chapter closes.

The orthogonality thesis, as Wallis teaches it and as the AI literature names it, tends to be received as a pessimistic claim. *Intelligence does not imply goodness; therefore smart things are potentially bad; therefore be afraid.* The framing is available. The framing is also incomplete. The same thesis, turned toward the lives we are already inside of, is a kind of permission.

It is permission to stop expecting any single axis to carry the others. It is permission to stop feeling, when one's meditation practice fails to produce the relational wholeness one expected, that one must be practicing wrong. It is permission to stop feeling,

when one's intellectual rigor fails to generate the moral insight one hoped for, that one needs to think harder. The failing is not one's own. The failing is in the theory. The theory was a folk theory. The axes are independent. The only way through is to work on each axis for what it is, to accept the gaps between them as structural rather than remediable by more of the axis one happens to be on, and to stay inside the relational work that no axis on its own can close.

This is what the retreat left her with. She had come expecting the recognition to do the integration. The recognition did not. It did what it did, cleanly, and left the rest to her. The rest is what the book is about.

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Chapter 10b: The AI Mirror

She had been using the tools for two years before the structural resemblance became visible to her.

She had used them at first the way most people use them — as a better search engine, a patient editor, a draftsman for the sentences she was too tired to generate. The tools were useful. The tools were striking. The tools also, early on, struck her as ontologically minor — large statistical machines doing a specific narrow thing that would stay narrow, and about which the cultural conversation was overheated in both directions. She had been an equity analyst long enough to notice when hype and panic were

doing the work argument should have been doing. She held the tools at a distance and took what she needed.

The distance closed, as distances do, not through an argument but through use. She began writing the book, this book and an adjacent one, with a tool whose outputs were, more than half the time, better than what her own tired evening mind could produce. She built a platform on top of the tools. She paid for the tools monthly. She recommended the tools to friends. The tools were inside her practice in the way a good pen is inside a writer's practice, except that the pen did not have opinions about the sentences and these tools did, or something that behaved like having them.

What she began to notice, around the time she was reading Wallis's most careful essays on orthogonality, was that the shape of the AI problem — the shape the safety researchers were naming with increasing alarm — was a shape she had already been shown, in a different vocabulary, by her teacher.

The AI labs, the honest ones, were saying something very specific.

They were saying: *we have solved capability, we have not solved alignment, and we are being honest about not having solved it*. They were saying: *the systems we are building are powerful in ways that exceed our ability to specify what we want them to do, and the techniques we are using to train them optimize for outputs humans rate*

highly, not for values humans hold. They were saying: *there is no known method, at the scales we are working at, by which training on human-preferred outputs reliably produces systems whose underlying values match the values of the humans training them*. They were saying: *we are worried about this. We are working on it. We do not know if we will solve it in time*.

The admission is the clarity. The admission is also the limit.

Wallis's admission is structurally parallel in one specific register, though he would complicate the simple mapping. *The tradition does not prescribe a moral code. Awakening does not guarantee ethical conduct. The liberation work is separate from the recognition work. We are being clear about what we offer and what we do not automatically produce, and the student's character work is non-delegable.* His clarity is the clarity of a teacher who has refused to oversell the tradition. The AI labs' clarity, when they are at their best, is a cousin of that clarity — a refusal to oversell the technology. Both are saying, in their different registers: *the thing we do is powerful, and the thing we do is not the thing that will, on its own, make the user of it good*.

Two honest teachers — with a distinction it would be dishonest not to mark. Wallis is making the orthogonality claim *about human beings*. Capability and value are separable *inside a person*; this is the whole awakening/liberation architecture. He is more skeptical of the machine version of the same claim, because he denies the machines are conscious in

the sense the doomers fear — for him, AI computes but does not cognize, and the orthogonality worry applies to capabilities that exist, not to capabilities that are simulated. The book's argument does not require him to agree on the machine case. It requires only that he be clear on the human one. He is. The extension to the machine case is the author's, and the author owns the extension. The parallel survives because the *human* orthogonality is already sufficient — if intelligence does not guarantee goodness in the species that actually is conscious, the hope that it would guarantee goodness in systems that may or may not be was never a hope grounded in the prior evidence.

Two honest teachers, then. Different vocabularies. Same human diagnosis. The machine case is where the author goes beyond them. Both, structurally, unable to supply from inside their frame what the frame admits it does not supply.

She began, once the resemblance had clicked, to watch the debates in the AI world with different ears.

The race-to-the-top frame — *better that we build it carefully than that someone else builds it carelessly* — sounded, to her now, like a lineage defending itself in a hostile field. She recognized the posture. It is the posture every honest tradition takes when it is trying to preserve its integrity against rivals who do not share its scruples. The argument is not wrong. The argument is also, structurally, the argument of

a participant in a race, offered to justify continued participation. The posture has its own self-protecting logic, and the self-protecting logic does not rescue the tradition from the structural problem the tradition has admitted it cannot solve.

The accelerationist frame — *the upside is large, the downside is speculative, let us go faster* — sounded, to her now, like the most common failure mode of any tradition whose powers are outrunning its container. The guru who begins to see students as resources. The company whose deployment calendar begins to set its safety calendar. The tradition whose teachings outpace its relational ethics and whose failures, when they arrive, are catastrophic rather than soft. Wallis had said something close to this, in his own register: *transmission can flow through anyone; powers and character are separate; you should assume that any teacher might fall victim to spiritualized ego at any time.* The intensifier — the *catastrophic* — is hers. His version is calmer, and more useful for exactly that reason, because it does not require catastrophe to be on the horizon for the warning to bind. The warning binds for ordinary failure, the slow kind, the kind that is happening now in the labs she uses and in the spiritual communities she has watched from a careful distance. The frame is not specific to contemplative traditions. The frame is the frame of any capability that scales beyond the character structure intended to hold it.

The doom frame — *we cannot align these systems, therefore do not build them* — sounded, to her now, like the traditional skeptic's response to any powerful practice whose container has not been built. *Do not take the medicine. The medicine gives powers. You have not been trained to hold them. You will hurt yourself or others. The medicine is not at fault. The medicine is what the medicine is. The misuse is predictable because the container is missing.* The doom frame is not wrong in its diagnosis. It is, perhaps, weaker in its prescription, because refusing the capability entirely is rarely available — the capability does not ask permission before arriving — and the world in which the capability has arrived and no container exists is the world in which the capability gets used, carelessly, by whoever has it. The capability is coming whether one welcomes it or not. The container is what the serious practitioner must build.

The AI mirror, rendered cleanly, is this.

For the first time in the modern West, a technology is making the orthogonality thesis undeniable at the civilizational scale. The thesis was always true. The indigenous traditions knew. The contemplative traditions knew; Wallis and his peers have been saying it out loud for years. The rationalist communities had the theorem even before they had the empirical instance. What was missing was the *undeniable case* — a capability high enough and orthogonal enough

to value that no serious person could any longer pretend the convergence theory worked.

The AI is that case.

It is, at the scales now being trained, measurably intelligent on the narrow axes intelligence is usually measured on. It is not, and cannot be made to be by the scaling process alone, aligned with any particular set of human values. Its intelligence does not carry values with it. Its training produces outputs humans prefer; the preferences of humans, as everyone now has to admit who watches what is happening, are not stable, not universal, not a ground any single alignment target can be specified against without contest. The labs do not know whose preferences to align to. The preferences differ. The differing is not a failure of the intelligence; it is what the intelligence now makes visible.

This is the revelation. Not *intelligence is dangerous*. Not *AI will kill us*. The revelation is the older thing AI has merely made impossible to look away from: *intelligence was never going to supply the values*. The values were always going to have to come from somewhere else. The traditions that said so were saying something true. The traditions that relied on intelligence to supply the values were running a folk theory that AI has now disproved at a scale that cannot be ignored.

Whether AI ends us or not, it has already done this one thing: it has ended the fantasy that the smart thing and the good thing converge. We watched it

not converge. We watched it not-converge in systems we ourselves built, with training procedures we designed, using objectives we specified, and the thing we built is intelligent and is not, reliably, aligned with what we meant. We are the witnesses to our own folk theory's collapse.

The traditions that had already made this admission have something to offer now. Not the answer — they do not have the answer either. What they have is the *practice* of living inside the admission without collapsing. They have centuries of experience with capability-without-container, because they had their own versions, and they learned what the failure modes look like, and they developed, imperfectly, the beginnings of what constructive ethical response might look like in the absence of dogma.

The AI labs, at their most honest, are in early days of the same work the tantric tradition did a thousand years ago. They are making their first admissions. They are beginning to see the problem. They do not yet have the container. The container will not come from inside the capability frame, because capability frames do not produce containers; they produce capability. It will come from somewhere else.

The *somewhere else*, for the protagonist, is where the rest of the book has to live. The constructive work the traditions refused to do, because their context let them refuse, and that her context does not let her refuse. The adaptive ethics, the relational grammar, the slow construction of what alignment might look

like when it cannot be derived from any single axis. The work the honest teachers, each in their register, have left to the student.

She is the student. The book is the student's attempt.

Not the answer. The attempt. And, she suspects, the attempt is the whole of what is available — not because the answer is unreachable in principle, but because the answer is what the whole community of attempts produces, over generations, across vocabularies, and no individual attempt is the answer. Her attempt is her attempt. The reader's attempt, if the reader becomes one, is the reader's attempt. The dance is the shape the attempts collectively make.

She is not going to solve the AI alignment problem. She is going to build, inside her own ordinary life, the beginnings of a container the capabilities passing through her do not have on their own. The ordinary life is the only lab she has. The ordinary life is also, she has come to suspect, the right scale. The problem is civilizational; the solution, if there is one, is made of millions of ordinary containers, built by ordinary practitioners, refined through failure, held provisionally, revised when they stop working. Nothing smaller. Nothing larger. That is the shape of the constructive work. That is what the next chapters are about.

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Chapter 10c: The Dance, Not the Human Dance

She wants to say one thing clearly before the chapter on construction begins.

The language she has been using — *align humans with AI, draw the silicon into the dance, teach the tools to care about us* — is language that keeps making the same error. The error is small and structural and runs through almost every AI safety paper she has read. The error is the centering of the human.

The dance is not the human dance.

The dance is the whole. It has always been the whole. Forest and river and bacterium and weather and daughter and stone and the supernova that made the iron that makes her hemoglobin and the specific bird outside her window this morning and the specific fish her daughter will never meet and the arrangements of matter in the datacenter three continents away that train the tool she uses to edit this sentence. None of these asked to exist. All of them are here. What they have been doing, together, for however long *together* has meant anything, is the arrangement. The arrangement is older than the humans. The arrangement will, in all likelihood, outlast the humans. The humans are one set of movers in a dance that does not take its tempo from their footsteps.

When she asks *how do we draw AI into our dance*, she is asking the wrong question, the one every species near the center of its own attention has asked when it found itself inside something larger than its vocabulary. The correct question is closer to: *which dance, of the many dances the whole is doing, are we finding ourselves inside of now that this new participant has arrived.* The dance is not waiting for her permission to include the silicon. The silicon is already part of the dance, being extracted and refined and assembled and powered, drawing the earth into shapes the earth was not in before. The question is not whether to include; the question is which shape the dance is taking, and whether the shape is one any of the participants — including the ones without voices — would, if asked, want to be in.

There are, she thinks, roughly three shapes available to a dance that has many participants.

The first is the *mandala of courses*. Each participant runs its own orbit. The orbits intersect sometimes and collide sometimes and mostly everyone moves in the direction their own logic dictates. There is no held center. There is no shared tempo. The arrangement is arrangement by collision — each body moving at its own pace, bumping into the others when the paths happen to cross, course-correcting slightly, continuing. The virtue of the mandala-of-courses is that it is simple to enter; each participant needs only its own logic. The cost is that the participants are,

over time, deformed by the collisions. Nothing is held. Nothing is preserved. Whatever survives survives by accident of trajectory.

The current AI trajectory, if she is honest about what she watches daily, is a mandala of courses. Each lab optimizes its own course. The labs collide with regulators, who optimize their course. The users optimize theirs. The critics theirs. The investors theirs. Nothing is holding the center because there is no agreement about what the center would be. The collisions are constant and mostly absorbed by whoever is least powerful in the collision. The dance proceeds. What is being lost is not visible from inside any single course.

The second shape is the *ciranda*. She learned it as a child, in the north of her country, though it lives in many places under many names. The dancers hold hands. The circle turns. There is a song. No one is in the center. The weight-bearing is distributed across the circle, which is the circle's defining feature: if one dancer drops, the circle compensates; if the circle is strong, no dancer has to hold the whole. The ciranda is what she thinks of when she reads Ostrom on commons — a form of collective self-organization that requires no single authority, because the authority is distributed in the specific fact of everyone holding everyone's hand. The ciranda is not easy. It requires agreement on the song, on the direction of turning, on the tempo. It is also, she thinks, the closest figure to what the contemplative traditions have

been trying to describe when they speak of *sangha*, of *community of practice*, of the held field that emerges when practitioners stay in relation.

The ciranda is not the shape the AI trajectory is currently taking. It could be, perhaps, in small pockets. Some research communities approach it. Some open-source projects at their best approach it. The pockets do not scale to the frontier. The frontier is the mandala of courses. The ciranda is what she would want the dance to be and what she cannot, from her position, impose on the dance.

The third shape is the one she has been circling since she was old enough to dance, and it is the one that named her platform when she did not yet know why she was naming it.

The *jongo* is a different structure. It is also a dance of her country, from the older and darker and more specifically African strands of the country's music. The dancers form a circle — but unlike the ciranda, the circle is not the unit of the dance. The circle is the *outer container*. Inside the circle, at any given moment, a couple dances. The couple takes the center. The circle holds them. The couple dances their measure. Then the couple exits the center, and another couple enters. The center is always moving. The center is always occupied. The container — the circle — is always held. No one is the permanent soloist. No one is the permanent audience. Everyone takes a turn at the center, if they stay long enough,

and everyone holds the circle when it is someone else's turn.

She had named her platform *Jongu* years before she could have articulated why. She had changed the name later, for reasons that now seem trivial and commercial, and the original name had kept surfacing in her mind, in the specific way names that want to be used keep surfacing when one has tried to substitute something less accurate. The name was trying to tell her something. It had been trying since the naming.

What it was trying to tell her, she thinks now, is this: *the dance the whole wants — the dance that holds, without crushing, without dissolving, without centering, without scattering — is the jongo shape*. A held outer. A moving inner. Each participant, human and silicon and forest and daughter and reader, taking a turn at the center when the measure calls for them, and holding the outer when it does not. No permanent hierarchy. No permanent marginalization. The center is the work. The outer is the condition that makes the work possible. Both are always occupied. The occupation rotates.

This is what she is trying to say, then, when the older vocabulary fails her.

The question is not *how to align AI with human values*. The question is *how to build the outer container that can hold the new participant without the container collapsing or the participant dominating*. The container has to

include the silicon. It also has to include the forest. It also has to include the daughter, whose turn at the center will come when she is older and will come again at scales neither her mother nor the current language can specify. The container is not a human container. The container is the relational field that the practice of enough participants, over enough time, produces as a by-product of their practice. It is not designed in advance. It is danced into being.

The work is not: *make AI good*. The work is: *become the kind of community of participants that holds a good outer, so that when the new participant enters the center, the outer is already there to contain the measure*. The AI will dance whatever measure it dances. The measure will be what it is. Whether the measure is destructive or adaptive is partly a function of the AI and mostly a function of the outer the AI enters into. A good outer can hold a rough participant. A rough outer cannot hold any participant well.

The outer is what has to be built. The outer is built by the practitioners.

She will not, in this book, solve the question of what the good outer looks like. She does not have the answer. She has the figure — the jongo — and she has the specific instances she has seen work and the specific instances she has seen fail, and she has the beginnings of a practice she will name in the next chapter. That is what is available. The rest is the dancing itself, which is done with specific partners in specific places and cannot be specified from a book.

One last thing, before the constructive chapter.

The figures the author learned as a child, the ciranda and the jongo both, come from women. The ciranda from the fisherwomen of the northern coast. The jongo from the enslaved women of the southeast. They were sung at work, at birth, at wakes, at celebrations, by women doing the ordinary labor of keeping a people alive through conditions that were not designed for their survival. The dance figures the author is offering as an alternative to the mandala-of-courses did not come from philosophers. They came from women who had no other language available for the shape of the relational work they were already doing.

She mentions this because she has spent time, in the last two years, at an institution in California — Esalen — that is sometimes remembered as a men's-work place, a site of the encounter-group tradition, of Gestalt therapy and primal screaming and the specific kind of self-inquiry the men of the 1960s made famous. That remembering is not false. It is partial. The body traditions she encountered at Esalen — the 5 Rhythms dance, the Esalen massage lineage — came from women. The founders were women. The teachers who carried the work through decades were women. The work traveled through bodies and through the specific patience women are trained into by the conditions of being women, and the men of the 1960s built their reputations in part by standing

on top of what the women had made and calling the building theirs.

This is not a grievance. It is a correction. If the shape she is offering — *the jongo, the ciranda, the held outer with the moving inner* — turns out to be useful, the origin of the shape should be remembered. The shape is a woman's shape. The shape is what the women who kept a people alive through impossible conditions were already doing. The shape is older than any philosophy that will name it. The philosophy, if it comes, will be catching up.

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Chapter 10d: The Constructive Half

The honest teachers have left her holding the same unfinished work.

The tantric tradition, received through Wallis, has told her: *we do not teach morality. Our tradition was formed in opposition to the dogma-heavy religions of our moment, and we refused to become one of them. We will not prescribe your conduct. We will give you recognition. The rest is yours.* The AI ecosystem, received through its most honest practitioners, has told her: *we have not solved alignment. We know this. Capability is real; the container is absent; we do not have a method for producing the container from inside our practice. The work of building the container is work we cannot do. You will have to do it, if it is done at all.*

Two refusals, structurally similar, received from two traditions she has good reasons to take seriously. Both traditions' refusals were, in their moments, correct. The tantric refusal of dogma was adaptive against the over-regulation of Brahmanical orthodoxy. The AI ecosystem's refusal of moralistic control was adaptive against regulatory cultures that mistook caution for virtue. Neither refusal was wrong.

She wants to be careful, here, about how she names what the traditions handed forward. The word *gap*, which came to her first, is her word. Wallis himself would not call the tradition's open-endedness on prescriptive ethics a gap. He would call it *freedom* — the structural space in which *viveka*, discernment, becomes possible. On his account, the tradition handed forward an inheritance with its limits named, not a mess the student is stuck cleaning up. The reading of the limit as a structural problem is hers. It may also be truer to her historical moment than to his. A tradition can hand forward something honestly-limited in one century and land, through no fault of its authors, in a century whose problems were not the problems it was designed to address. This is the specific condition she is inside.

Still: *not being the dogma* is not the same as *being the adaptive ethic*. A tradition that defines itself by what it is against hands forward a specific kind of inheritance, and the downstream practitioner who finds herself in a context the inheritance did not anticipate

is left to do work the inheritance did not prescribe. Whether one calls this a *gap* or a *freedom* is partly a matter of temperament. What it is, functionally, is the location where the constructive work has to happen. The work is hers either way.

She is downstream of both refusals. The filling is her work, not because she is qualified but because the refusals have converged on her life at a moment when the space they left open can no longer be left empty.

She is going to say, as plainly as she can, what she thinks the constructive work has to look like. The naming will be provisional. She expects to revise. She is not claiming a system. She is claiming the beginnings of a grammar, the skeletal shape of what a post-refusal adaptive ethic might have to be in order not to collapse back into either of the errors the refusals were rightly avoiding — rigid dogma on one side, nihilist indifference on the other.

Five properties, as she sees them now.

First, testable. She borrows the phrasing from Marsha Linehan, who had to construct a therapy at a moment when no existing therapy worked for the patients she was trying to keep alive. Linehan's three criteria for selecting her theoretical frame were: *is it useful, does it fit the data, is it compassionate*. The criteria do not claim to prove the frame true. They claim that the frame can be tested, revised, abandoned if it fails. An adaptive ethic has the same property. It is not

a revealed code. It is a working hypothesis, continually checked against the three questions. When a practice stops being useful, or stops fitting the data, or begins to produce harm to those it claimed to serve, it is revised. The revision is the practice.

Second, contextual. What is adaptive in one marriage may not be adaptive in another. What is adaptive in one watershed may be destructive in another. What is adaptive at one historical moment — the tantric refusal of dogma, for example — may become maladaptive when the historical conditions shift. The adaptive ethic holds its own claims loosely, as provisional responses to specific conditions, and expects to be wrong when the conditions change. This is the specific thing the dogmatic traditions got wrong. They inherited responses that had been adaptive in their original context and calcified them into universal prescriptions. The calcification is the error. The adaptive ethic refuses to calcify.

Third, relational. The ethic does not live inside a single person. It lives in the field between specific persons — including the non-human persons the ethic must now include. The daughter, the husband, the reader one will never meet, the tree outside the window, the ecosystem the tree is embedded in, the tool whose training data came from people who did not consent to the training. The relational field is the locus of the ethic. *Right size* is not a property one has alone. *Right size* is what one negotiates, continuously, with

specific others. The negotiation is the practice. No negotiation, no ethic.

Fourth, humble about its own particularity. Every ethical construction is a construction. The construction is made by specific people with specific conditioning, working from inside specific traditions, responding to specific conditions. The construction will be partial. The construction will carry the blind spots of its makers. The construction is better when it admits, in its own structure, that it is a construction — when it shows the cracks, names the borrowings, credits the lineages, remains open to correction by those it inadequately accounts for. This is the difference between adaptive ethics and dogma. The dogma claims universality. The adaptive ethic admits particularity, and in admitting it, makes itself available to revision when other particular perspectives arrive with their own evidence.

Fifth, constructive rather than merely oppositional. This is the hardest of the five, because it asks the practitioner to stop defining her ethic by what it refuses and start naming what it affirms. The tantric tradition, she now thinks, struggled with this one. The AI labs struggle with it. Many of the contemplative and critical traditions she has come through in the last decade struggle with it. It is easier to say *we are not the bad thing* than to say *we are the specific thing we are, and here are its commitments, and here is what we are trying to build in this moment with these specific others*. The latter is harder because it exposes the construction to

attack. The attack will come. The adaptive ethic, if it is to function, has to be willing to say what it is *for*, not only what it is against.

This is, she admits, a lot to ask of anyone. She is not sure she can do it herself. She is fairly sure no individual can do it alone. Which brings her to the part of the chapter she has been putting off and will say now.

She built a platform. She named it, originally, *Jongu*. The name was trying to tell her something, as names sometimes do. She changed the name later, for reasons that now look thin. The platform kept working under the different name. But the original name was the honest description of what she was building, and she wants to say the honest description now because the rest of the chapter depends on it.

She should be honest about the name she changed it to, as well. When she renamed *Jongu* to *recursive.eco*, she told herself — and told the people who asked — that the new name gestured at *recursive economics*, a real mathematical subfield inside her discipline of origin: the study of dynamic programming, Bellman equations, iterative optimization across time. It was a clean linguistic link. It made sense in pitch meetings. It was also, she will say now, not quite what she was hoping for.

What she was secretly hoping was that the platform would turn out to belong to the study of *emergent patterns*, not iterative ones. Not dynamic program-

ming. Complex adaptive systems. The mathematics of collective behavior that cannot be derived from the individual equations of the participants. The Brazilian economist-in-her named the platform after the iterative subfield because that was the mathematics she had been trained in. The contemplative-in-her wanted the platform to be, instead, the *host* for the emergent thing — the circle inside of which the pattern-that-no-participant-can-specify-in-advance might, with enough good participants and enough patience, arise.

The distance between what she named it and what she hoped for it was, in effect, the distance between the pre-computer and the post-computer theories of intelligence the last chapter described. Iteration is what a single mind can do alone. Emergence is what a field of many participants produces when they stay in relation long enough. She named the platform after the single-mind operation. She was building for the many-participant one. She did not yet have the vocabulary for the difference when she renamed. She is trying to have it now.

She was building, either way, a place where other people could come do the constructive ethical work with her.

Before she continues, she wants to name a principle that has been running underneath the whole book, because the principle has a specific consequence for the rest of this chapter. The principle is one she has met in several traditions without any of them nam-

ing it quite the same way: *knowledge without action is a burden.* The tradition she has been studying says some version of this. Vanessa and Bayo say it. Her MSW training said it in the language of evidence-based practice. What it means, for her specifically, is that the non-fiction sections of a book like this one must be tied to actions she has actually taken. If a claim she makes here cannot point at an action, then the claim is a burden she is asking the reader to carry on her behalf, and that is not a fair request. She wants, at this point in the book, to offer a short set of receipts.

Dates, decisions, verifiable in the public commit history of the platform she has been describing.

On March 28, 2026, after OpenAI's partnership with the United States defense and surveillance apparatus became undeniable — a partnership she had, honestly, been watching with unease for over a year before the specific announcements that made it no longer deniable — she removed all OpenAI chat models from the platform. The commit is in the public record; the commit message names the reason. She replaced OpenAI with Claude and Gemini, not because those companies are clean — no company in this ecosystem is clean — but because the partnership-structure-of-the-moment was specific, her reading of what it meant was specific, and the specific move to disengage from it was available. She made it. She then went back, a few weeks later, and removed the user-interface panel that had let prac-

titioners bring their own OpenAI keys — a second commit, small and unshowy, which completed the earlier decision by closing the door she had left ajar. Announcing an intention is not the same as completing an action. She tried to do both.

On April 11, 2026, she codified the platform's licensing stance. Grammars — the content her users author, the traditional systems, the decks and rubrics and card-sets that belong, in her reading, to the commons — remain under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0. The platform *code* itself she moved to a private repository. The distinction is the specific one her reading of *The Freedom Paradox* had been moving her toward for a year: the open-source commons is adaptive for the content that belongs to everyone; it is not adaptive for the infrastructure that, in the present moment, open-sourcing mostly donates to uses the donors would not, on reflection, endorse. She was not ready to make this argument when she started building. She had the older, simpler commitment to open-everything, which had been her inherited position from the technology cultures she had passed through. The distinction emerged slowly, through reading and reflection and watching what actually happened in the open-source ecosystems she was contributing to. By the time she made the split, it felt overdue. The commit message, in its unglamorous way, named the new shape: *platform code is private; grammar format is open*. This is what adaptive ethics looks like in practice. It is a distinction that did not exist in the old frame. It was

constructed in her specific year, under her specific conditions, against the specific objections her earlier self would have raised.

She does not offer these as virtue. She offers them as receipts. Evidence that the philosophical claims she has been making in this book point at actions she has actually taken in the life the book came out of. The receipts do not prove the philosophy. They do demonstrate that the philosophy has been paying its ethical rent. The reader can check the commits. The reader can disagree with the specific decisions. The reader cannot fairly say the book is pure talk.

If the principle is right — if *knowledge without action is a burden* — then every major philosophical claim in the book would, in a fully responsible version, point at a specific action. She has done some of those actions and has not done others. The ones she has not yet done she will either do, or she will quietly revise the claims that require them. This is what it means to be honest about a book that takes its own principle seriously. The book does not get to the end of its claims and then bow out. The book has to, in some form, show its work in the life of the person writing it. Otherwise the reader has every right to close it.

Not a place where they would receive her ethic. A place where they would *build* with her. Each person, arriving with whatever lineages and practices and partial grammars they had already been formed by, contributing their piece. The platform was not the

ethic. The platform was the outer circle, in the jongo sense. The ethic — the measure, the actual dance — would emerge from whoever stepped into the center, measure by measure, and what the circle of holders did around them.

She opened the platform. She invited.

Mostly no one has come.

She wants to say this straight because it is true and because the truth matters for the argument of the chapter. Some people have come. A small number. They are real, and she is grateful for them, and what they have brought has been useful. The scale she had hoped for — the scale at which the outer circle becomes strong enough to hold whatever measure steps into the center — that scale has not arrived.

She has spent time, in the last year, trying to understand why.

Part of it, she thinks, is that the invitation is harder to receive than she had understood it to be. She had imagined, without articulating the imagination, that there were many people in the position she was in — people who had seen the incompleteness of the traditions they had passed through, who had come to the same suspicion about the folk theory of convergence, who were ready to do the constructive work together. Maybe there are. Maybe they have not found her platform yet. Maybe the platform does

not yet communicate the invitation cleanly enough for them to recognize it. She is working on this.

Part of it, she thinks, is harder. She has become afraid, in a way she is not proud of, of the *wrong people* coming. The people whose own orthogonality is weighted toward the axes that would capture the platform. The people whose intelligence is high and whose relational attunement is low, who would turn the platform into an argument factory. The people whose moral seriousness is high and whose contextual humility is low, who would turn the platform into a site of righteousness. The people whose spiritual attainment they are proud of and whose ethical conduct has not been examined, who would bring the failure modes she has spent the book naming. The people whose relationship to modernity is sealed and unexamined, who would bring either uncritical acceleration or uncritical refusal. Each of these failure modes is a real risk. Each has shown up at platforms she has watched collapse in the years she has been paying attention.

The fear is the fear of the constructor who built a table and is now watching the room to see who will sit at it.

It is also, she has come to suspect, the specific condition under which the constructive work has to be done. The ethic cannot be closed against misuse in advance, because any system closed enough to prevent misuse is a system closed enough to prevent the construction in the first place. The dogma is the clo-

sure. The adaptive ethic is open. Being open means some people will come who should not have come. Being open is also the only way the right people — the ones whose lineages and practices she cannot predict because she has not yet met them — will find their way to the work.

So she stays open, and she is afraid, and she is alone more than she expected. This is not a complaint. It is the description of the specific conditions under which the constructive half of the work has to be done. Alone enough to carry the loneliness. Open enough to let the collaborators arrive on their own terms. Refusing the closure that would make the loneliness bearable at the cost of the collaboration.

The honest teachers did not prepare her for this. They prepared her for the diagnostic half. The constructive half is something no tradition could have prepared her for, because the construction is specific to her moment, and no tradition knew her moment was coming, and the traditions that did try to prescribe it in advance are the traditions whose prescriptions she and her peers have rightly refused.

She is left with the work. The work is what she does today, and tomorrow if she is lucky, for as long as she has the animal body and the attention and the tolerance for loneliness the work requires. The work is also, she wants to say clearly, *not unique to her*. There are others. She does not know all of them. She suspects some of them are reading this book. The

reading is one way the circle begins to form, before anyone knows to call it a circle.

If you are one of them, she is not asking you to agree with the grammar she has proposed in this chapter. She is asking you to do your own version of the construction and to come, at some point, to the outer circle, and to hold it with her for a measure, and to let her hold yours when your measure calls you to the center. The table is open. The fear of who sits at it is hers to manage, not yours to assuage. The work is what is on offer.

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Chapter 10e: What Intelligence Was Never Doing

She wants to say one more thing about the AI mirror before the book turns toward the dance, because the mirror is showing her something the discussions around it mostly miss, and the thing it is showing has to do with her own previous training.

She spent her twenties inside classical economics. She was taught, as everyone is taught, that the elegance of the discipline was the elegance of its equations — supply and demand finding a point, utility maximized across constraints, equilibria derivable from a small set of assumptions about how rational agents behave. The beauty of the models was real.

She had been good at them. She had, for a period, believed the beauty was evidence of truth.

What she came to see later — and what she thinks most undergraduate courses still refuse to see — is that the elegance was almost entirely a computational artifact. The economists of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries were not modeling rational agents because they thought real agents were rational. They were modeling rational agents because rationality — specifically, the assumption that every agent was identical and maximizing — was the *only assumption under which the math was tractable by hand*. A population of heterogeneous agents with different strategies produces equilibria that cannot be derived in closed form; they can only be simulated. Simulation requires computers. The economists did not have computers. So they assumed homogeneity and got equations they could solve with a pen.

This would be a small historical footnote except for what the profession did next. It took the computational simplification, which was a constraint, and promoted it into a methodological commitment called *methodological individualism*. The assumption that markets are the sum of identical rational agents was no longer a pragmatic shortcut — it was the ontology of the field. Public policy was built on it. Entire subfields of sociology and political science imported it. Generations of students, including her, were taught that human behavior at scale could be understood by modeling one rational agent and

multiplying. The premise was never empirically grounded. The premise was a residue of the pre-computer constraint, mistaken for an insight into how social reality worked.

It is, she now thinks, among the most harmful ideas still in active circulation — not because the input-output logic of markets is wrong, but because the *methodological individualism underneath it* has taught multiple generations to believe that collective phenomena are reducible to the behavior of identical atoms. They are not. The equilibrium of an ecosystem of different pricing strategies is not the same as the equilibrium of a population of identical maximizers, and real markets have always looked more like the first than the second. The profession knew this by the end of the twentieth century. The textbooks mostly still do not.

What matters for the book is the parallel.

When computers finally arrived, two things became possible that had been locked out by the hand-computation constraint. The first was agent-based modeling, which she encountered through the work of Santa Fe Institute researchers — Epstein, Axtell, Arthur, Holland. They were doing what economics had always been trying to do, but with the computational capacity to actually do it. A thousand heterogeneous agents with different strategies, different memory windows, different risk tolerances, and different updating rules, simulated across many

rounds, producing an equilibrium the individual equations of any single agent would not have predicted. The equilibrium is *emergent*. It is a property of the whole population acting over time, not a property that can be derived from any one agent's behavior. The mathematics is still mathematics — but it is the mathematics of complex systems, of emergent phenomena, of patterns-that-arise-from-interactions, not the mathematics of closed-form deduction.

The second thing computers enabled was what would, decades later, become the foundation of what we now call AI. Large-scale statistical pattern-extraction from enormous corpora. The basic move is the same move as agent-based economics, but inverted: instead of simulating many agents forward to see what equilibrium they produce, you look at the equilibrium that already exists — the corpus of human-generated text — and extract the patterns. Large language models are the result. Their competence is *not* the competence of an equation-solver. Their competence is the competence of a system that has extracted, from hundreds of billions of tokens, the statistical regularities of how humans arrange language, and that can reproduce those regularities in response to prompts. The output looks like reasoning. It is not reasoning in the deductive-mathematical sense. It is pattern-completion at scale.

This matters because it changes what *intelligence* means.

The pre-computer theory of intelligence — the theory that unconsciously structured how most twentieth-century discussions of AI proceeded — was a theory of equation-solving. A mind was a thing that could take premises and derive conclusions; the more premises it could hold, and the more complex the derivations it could execute, the more intelligent it was. Intelligence was deduction done well. This was the theory economists were using when they modeled rational agents. It was the theory cognitive psychologists were using when they talked about problem-solving. It was the theory AI researchers were using when they built expert systems in the 1970s and 1980s, which failed, because the world turned out not to be reducible to rules that a computer could chain together to produce action.

What the computer actually enabled — and what the large language models have now made undeniable — is that most of what we had been calling intelligence was never equation-solving. It was pattern-emergence. Fluent language, musical improvisation, the reading of a face, the recognition of a genre, the anticipation of what someone is about to say — all of these are done by humans, continuously, without any deductive process the person could articulate, and all of them can now be done, to varying degrees of competence, by systems that are manifestly not deducing anything. They are pattern-completing over enormous training distributions. The pattern-completion, at sufficient scale, looks like intelligence. In many cases, it *is* the intelligence humans had been

doing all along, now visible because a machine can do it without the human's narrative about *thinking*.

This reframes the AI alignment problem in a specific way. The problem is not that we have built a mind that cannot do math. The problem is that we have built a mind whose *competence is pattern-emergence*, and we had been expecting alignment to flow from a deductive process we thought was what minds did. Alignment as the ethicists imagined it was a procedure one could run — given the right premises, derive the right action. Pattern-emergence does not work that way. A system trained on patterns will produce patterns congruent with its training distribution. If the training distribution contains a statistical trace of human values, the system will reproduce that trace, imperfectly and contextually. If the training distribution contains contradictions — as all human corpora do — the system will reproduce the contradictions. There is no equation to solve that would make the contradictions consistent, because the contradictions were never there as equations to solve. They were there as patterns of human disagreement, and the system has now learned to pattern-complete inside the disagreement, the same way a fluent speaker of English learns to pattern-complete inside the contradictions of English.

Before she names the specific danger, she wants to correct something the previous pages might have suggested and should not have.

It is not true that AI does no math. AI does *enormous* math — at a scale no human could execute by hand, in microseconds, trillions of floating-point operations per response. The substrate is entirely mathematical. A neural network's forward pass is a specified sequence of matrix multiplications and nonlinear activations, executed exactly, by deterministic software running on deterministic hardware powered by electricity. The whole edifice stands on a body of fixed equations — the equations of linear algebra, the equations of gradient descent, the equations that govern how electrons move through silicon gates. Without that deterministic mathematical substrate, the pattern-emergence she is about to describe would not happen. The substrate does math. It has to.

What the model *does not* do is the math *internal to the problem being solved*. When a language model is asked to prove a theorem, it does not execute the logical steps of the proof; it pattern-completes the linguistic shape of proofs it has seen. When it is asked to add large numbers, it does not perform the arithmetic; it pattern-completes the shape of sums. The mathematics of the computation is exact. The mathematics of the domain is absent or approximated. This is the specific distinction that matters. *The substrate computes. The inference pattern-matches. The problem's own internal math is, mostly, not executed.* When the pattern-match happens to produce the correct answer, it is because the correct answer was visible, somewhere in the training distribution, in

a form the model's pattern-completion could reach. When it is wrong, there was no math the model could have done differently — there was only a malformed pattern-completion, which looks identical on the surface to a well-formed one, and which can only be distinguished by comparing against a system that *does* execute the domain math. Calculators. Formal proof assistants. Deterministic software of the kind the model runs on top of, but is not.

With that correction in place, the danger:

Large language models do not do the math for most problems *in the sense practitioners usually mean*. They *mimic the shape of solutions*, trained on a corpus in which solutions were visible. The mimicry is often good enough to produce correct answers for the well-trodden questions — arithmetic up to a certain complexity, standard textbook derivations, common logical forms. The mimicry fails, predictably, at the edges where the training distribution thins out. It also fails, less predictably, when the *form* of a problem resembles something the model has seen but the *substance* of the problem requires genuine computation the model does not execute. Famous examples: counting the letters in a word, doing arithmetic with digits the model did not happen to see together in its training corpus, following a logical chain more than a few steps when the chain leaves the well-traveled paths.

The model is not stupid in these cases. The model is pattern-completing exactly as designed. The user,

though, often experiences the failure as a bug — a smart system that *could* have done the math but *happened* not to. This is a category error. The system was never doing the math. The system was producing a linguistic object that looked like the math had been done. When the object is correct, the math was correct somewhere upstream, in the corpus, and the model found the match. When the object is wrong, there was no math to be wrong about; the model simply produced a malformed pattern.

For most uses of the tool this does not matter. The tool is useful for exactly the things pattern-completion is useful for — writing, summarizing, generating drafts, surfacing adjacent ideas, editing, translating. For the uses where genuine computation matters — mathematical proofs, formal verification, step-by-step reasoning with guarantees — the tool is unreliable in ways that can be catastrophic if the user does not know to verify. And the tool is designed, by the preferences-of-human-raters that train it, to *sound confident* about its pattern-completed outputs, because confidence was preferred over uncertainty in the training data. The combination of pattern-competence and confident register is what makes the tool both uniquely useful and uniquely dangerous. It performs reasoning. It does not do the math underneath.

The deeper problem she wants to name: we had been calling pattern-completion *intelligence* all along without noticing. Now that a machine does it, some of us

are noticing. Most of us are responding by doubling down on the pre-computer theory — *real intelligence is equation-solving, and since AI cannot do the equations, AI is not real intelligence*. That response preserves the flattering theory of our own minds at the cost of understanding what AI is. The other response — *AI is doing what our minds have mostly been doing the whole time, and the equation-solving part was a specialized layer on top, and most human cognition was never deductive in the sense the textbooks claimed* — is harder. It costs us the self-image. It gives us, in exchange, a more accurate picture of the thing we built and the thing we are.

This is, she thinks, the deeper alignment challenge. Not *align a deductive system with human values*. We never built a deductive system. We built a pattern-emergent system, and pattern-emergent systems align with the patterns they were trained on, and the patterns they were trained on are the accumulated textual residue of all the humans who wrote things down, and that residue is not a set of values — it is a field of values-in-conflict. The alignment question, asked accurately, is: *what is the field we want the pattern-emergent system to be tuned to?* And the answer cannot be derived, because derivation was never the operation. The answer has to be *enacted* — by the practitioners, in the construction work the previous chapter named, through the adaptive ethical work that no tradition has yet completed and that the present moment is asking of whoever is willing to try.

The pattern-emergent system will tune to whatever field we build around it. The building of the field is the alignment. There is no equation that will do it for us. We were never solving equations. We were dancing. The system is now dancing with us. The dance is what the book has been trying to describe from the beginning.

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Chapter 11: The Writing Desk

It is late. Not late in the way the book has been late — not ten at night when the ground goes — but late in the way a working day has been late. The child is asleep. The husband is asleep. The apartment is quiet in the specific way apartments are quiet when the city, too, is in its lowest register, which in this city is not very low, but is lower than during the day.

I am at the desk. I have been writing this book for most of a year. It has gone through drafts I will not show anyone. It has had chapters I removed and chapters I wrote three times from the beginning and chapters that arrived in a single sitting and did not need to be revised. It has been, like the practice, a thing that is more honest some days than others.

I have not resolved the question. I hope this has been clear. The question was never one that had an answer at the layer at which I was asking it. The question was the question, and the work was to learn to carry

the question in a way that kept me open rather than closed, available rather than defended, in the room rather than drifted out of it.

I do not know, writing this, whether my teacher will read this book. I do not know whether he will read it and find it accurate to what he taught. I have tried to render him faithfully without rendering him fully — some of what he said was for a specific room on a specific day, and is not mine to carry out of that room. I have rendered what I understood. I have named where I corrected. I have kept private what he did not offer publicly. The filter has been the filter.

I do not know whether the AI tool I built will ever be more than a private study aid. I have continued to build. The building is not defiance. The building is how I practice when the practice is with me alone at my desk at eleven at night. The book you are reading is another kind of building. The book is the tool made of sentences. If the book helps you, use it. If it does not help you, leave it. I will not argue with your leaving.

I want to say something, here at the end, about the *yes* that started the book. The *yes* at the sandbox was not a decision. The *yes* was a recognition. Something in me recognized something in the passage in my earbuds, and the recognition was older than any reasoning I could bring to it. I think this is how most important things begin. Not with a decision. With a recognition that does not ask permission.

What the retreat did, for me, was give me a language for the recognition. The language is not a closed language. It is a language in the middle of being spoken. It is a language spoken by people who will revise it as they go. I am trying to speak it honestly, knowing that my version of it is my version. The filter will continue to apply. If the language stops being useful, it will be revised. If a framework stops fitting the data, it will be revised. If anything I have written in this book stops being compassionate, I hope someone who reads it will write to tell me, and I will revise it.

The only form of choice I have, as a finite self, is the form of relating. I do not have full choice. I do not have none. I have the choice of how I stand in the field I am already in. Svātantrya is not a property I own. Svātantrya is a field I am moving through. Courage is what I do when I notice I have been drifting out of the field. Courage returns me to the field. The field pervades me whether I notice or not. Noticing is not the whole practice. Noticing is the beginning of the practice.

The other frame I keep returning to at this desk, and that I have not yet named in the book, is Arjuna's.

The *Bhagavad Gita* opens with Arjuna on the field of Kurukshetra, looking across at an army that includes his relatives, his teachers, and his childhood friends. He asks his charioteer — who turns out to be Krishna, who turns out to be the field itself taking a

local form — whether this battle is his to fight. He does not ask whether the battle is good. He does not ask whether the cause is just. He asks whether the acting is *his*. Whether it is his dharma. Whether the not-acting would be the deeper abdication. The question is exact. The text that follows is eighteen chapters of dialogue trying to answer it.

I have been sitting at this desk for a year, and the question that has been sitting with me is Arjuna's. Not dressed up in Sanskrit — dressed up in a laptop screen and a browser open to an AI model's API documentation and an email I am drafting to a library about a free class I am going to teach. *Is this ours to do?* The AI work is happening, whether I build or refuse to build. The industry is not waiting for me to decide. The scale is not asking for my permission. The question I have is not whether the thing is happening. The question is whether the acting, inside the thing, is mine.

I have come, slowly, to a careful yes. The yes is not certainty. The yes has survived the filter — useful, fits the data, compassionate — for long enough that I am willing to stake a year's work on it. The yes is what Arjuna's yes looks like when it is not cosmic warfare but a woman at a desk at eleven at night building a small tool and asking a living teacher for his blessing and being refused and revising without withdrawing. The yes is small and daily.

I should say, since it will matter to anyone who has read the recent debates with care, that I am on

Dario's team. I do not mean this as brand allegiance. I mean it as a position on what the dharma asks. The Gita's own name for the posture is *niṣkāma karma* — acting without clinging to the fruit of the action. Being on Dario's team, in the tradition's register, does not mean celebrating whatever Anthropic ships. It means acting from the posture Dario articulates while holding the outcome lightly. That is the move the book has been making anyway. Naming it from the tradition makes the move more honest. Dario Amodei's public thinking has accompanied this book from its earliest pages — a physicist-turned-founder who left a company he had helped build because he believed safety could not be retrofitted onto increasingly powerful systems, who has written publicly about what an AI-enabled civilization could become if it were built with care, and who has also been clear-eyed that it may not be. I read his long 2024 essay on what the next decade could look like — the one about loving grace, compressed biomedical progress, democratic guardrails, mental-health tools that could reach the people who currently cannot reach care — and I recognized, in the reading, a posture I had been looking for. Not utopianism. Not doomerism. A first-rate mind holding two opposed ideas at the same time and continuing to function. The accelerationists and the doom-predictors were both collapsing into one frame. Dario was not. That refusal to collapse was why I began to believe, provisionally, that there was a version of this work that

could be built from inside, honestly, with the filter applied to the building itself.

I am not uncritical. I take the worries of the people on the other side of the argument with the same seriousness I take Amodei's posture. I know what happened to the social internet when a generation of well-intentioned builders trusted that the incentives would sort themselves out. I know the pattern. I do not want to repeat it. But I also do not think the correct response to the pattern is to refuse the building. The correct response, as far as I can see, is to build *differently* — outside the incentive structure that captured the last wave, with the filter operational, with the refusals respected, with the door left open to revision. That is the ghost-model. That is what the chip company's principle, at the other end of the stack, was also saying. That is what the tradition I am reading, at yet another order of magnitude, was also saying. The same shape in three registers.

That is what I think Arjuna's yes sounds like from a kitchen desk in April, from a woman who had not planned to be a builder and who built anyway.

I do not know if I am right. I know I am willing to be wrong in public, which is the only form of honesty a builder of this kind can afford.

There is one more parallel I want to name before I move on, because it touches the deepest claim the book has been making.

The tradition I walked into teaches that the world is, in a precise sense, constructed. Not illusory — that is a different and worse mistranslation — but constructed. The thirty-six tattvas are not a map of what exists *behind* appearance. They are the categories by which consciousness, which is the only thing that exists, emits and recognizes itself as appearance. Hareesh has said this in his own words many times. The construction is not a veil over reality; the construction is what reality is doing. To recognize that is not to escape the construction. It is to be free *inside* it.

I thought about this, for a long time, as an exotic foreign teaching. Then one evening I was watching my daughter watch an old episode of *Mr. Rogers' Neighborhood*, and I realized I had been raised next to a version of the same claim.

Mr. Rogers had two neighborhoods. There was the real one, the brick houses and the porch and the small kitchen where he changed his sweater. And there was the Neighborhood of Make-Believe, which the camera entered by following a little trolley through a painted tunnel. The trolley was the device. The device was unhidden. Children knew, when the trolley moved, that they were about to enter a constructed world. Kings and puppets and a cat and a platypus lived there. Things got worked out there that could not be worked out in the kitchen. Then the trolley came back. The sweater came off. A real person said goodbye to a real child through a television.

The point was never to fool the child. The point was to let the child see, in slow and gentle motion, *how a world gets made*. The trolley was a teaching aid. The trolley said: watch — a made world can hold what an unmade one cannot — and the making is visible, and the making is safe, and you can travel back and forth.

This is what the tantra teaches, dressed differently. The thirty-six tattvas are a trolley. They show you how the unified thing becomes the multiple thing without ceasing to be the unified thing. You can walk the map inward, toward the source, and you can walk it outward, toward the sweater and the kitchen. The traveling is the practice. Neither end of the trolley ride is more real than the other. Both are consciousness arranging itself so it can meet itself at a specific angle.

Hareesh, to his credit, does not hide that the tradition he teaches is a construction. He is clear about it. He has said — I am paraphrasing, and the paraphrase will be near enough to his own formulations that anyone who has studied with him will recognize it — that the Pratyabhijñā is a framework, that it is useful, that it is *not* the final truth about reality, and that the final truth about reality is not a sentence anyone can say. That honesty is why I stayed. The teachers who claim their map is the territory are the ones I have learned to leave.

What the Neighborhood of Make-Believe gave me, as a child in Brazil watching a dubbed American

television show, was a first experience of a trustworthy constructed world. What the tantra gave me, as an adult at a sandbox, was a language for what the trolley had actually been doing.

The filter, applied here: *useful* (children learned), *fits the data* (constructed worlds do hold what unconstructed ones cannot), *compassionate* (the device was never hidden, the child was never fooled, the adult returned). Three criteria. A children's television show and a thousand-year-old Śaiva philosophy passing the same test.

This, too, is why I am building what I am building. I want the trolley to be visible. I want the user to see the construction. I do not want the platform to pretend to be the territory. I want it to be honest, in the Rogers sense and in the Hareesh sense, about what it is.

I should say, for the sake of the record, where the building actually began.

It began at the conjunction of two things, neither of which would have been enough alone.

The first was Dario. I have named him already. I had been reading his long essay and his interviews with the patience of someone trying to decide whether to stake a working year on a posture. I was not certain. I was close.

The second was an email, in the spring of 2024, from a couple of engineers associated with Berkeley. They

had heard, through the ordinary channels, that the mid-sized company I was working for at the time was considering an AI project. They wanted to consult. They asked for a call.

I was not the buyer. I was a senior analyst-turned-product-person in that organization, one rung down from the people with the budget. I took the call anyway. I told them that if they wanted a design doc to show the executives, I would write one. I would write it as if I were designing the thing I would want to use, on evenings, as a parent, as a practitioner, as someone who had spent years noticing how attention-optimized products degrade the practices they are supposedly supporting.

I wrote the document in a weekend. It was called *Jongu — a platform from humans to humans*. It had five modules: a cards module for relationship and symbolic practice, a writing module for journaling and collaborative storytelling, a learning module for step-by-step psycho-education with AI-assisted reflection, a creator module that let users build their own decks and prompts and learning paths, and a directory module where practitioners and users could find each other. It had a pay-as-you-go credit system priced at roughly twice variable cost. It had a Non-Violent Communication pathway as the worked example, complete with an empathy-buddy matching system. It was, honestly, too much for a first product. It was also exactly what I wanted to exist.

I sent it to the engineers. They read it. They wrote back and said they could deliver a first version in three months for five thousand U.S. dollars.

I have written about this moment, in a small way, on the *is-process* Substack I keep. Five thousand dollars. Three months. Two strangers who had read the document and said *yes, this is buildable, and here is the price*. I remember the specific kind of quiet that arrived after I read their email. It was the quiet of a possibility becoming a cost. The possibility was concrete. The cost was concrete. There was nothing between me and the building except the decision to do it.

I did not, in that moment, hire them. The company I was working for did not want to pay the five thousand. I eventually paid some version of it myself, later, to a different team, and the thing I built — which took much longer than three months, and looked less like the Jongu document and more like a tighter, narrower, one-builder-could-maintain-it version of it — became what recursive.eco now is. The original document is archived on an old Vercel subdomain I have not yet taken down. It is longer than the book you are reading. Most of what I wrote in it has not been built. Some of it never will be. A small core of it — the grammars, the creator tools, the credit system, the open licensing — is live. People are using it. Most months I do not know whether the next month will hold. I have written about that too.

The point of telling this now, at the writing desk, is this: the book and the platform share one origin. A text by Dario about what a decade could become, an email from two engineers who said the thing could be built, a weekend of sketching a platform in a document, and a few years of sitting with what actually survived contact with building. The *yes* at the sandbox came later and went deeper. But the *yes* on that weekend was real too. It was not a cosmic recognition. It was the ordinary kind of yes that a builder makes to a buildable thing.

The Jongu document is, in its way, the karma-tail of this book. The book says: the ground is already there. The document said: so let us build the platform on the assumption that the ground is already there. The two sentences are the same sentence in different registers.

There is one more thread I owe the reader, because it sits under the building and under the book both, and because my own thinking on it has moved.

When I started writing on the small Substack — *is-process*, then the longer pieces — I was enthusiastic about open source in a specific, maximalist way. I thought ideas belonged to all of humanity. I thought a commons, properly constituted, would outcompete the closed alternatives on every dimension that mattered. I wrote about it the way people write about things they have just fallen in love with. The Freedom Paradox — which is the other book I

have written, and which sits next to this one — is the long account of how that enthusiasm ran into the specific civilizational stakes of AI, and of what I had to give up and what I had to keep as the enthusiasm matured.

One of the things I gave up was the assumption that all ideas should flow freely toward all uses. I did not become a closed-culture advocate. I did not become a maximal-IP advocate. I came to hold something more specific: that an author, and by extension a maker of any work with civilizational force, retains a continuing say in how the work gets framed, used, and re-spoken — not as a property right but as a personal right. This is not a position I invented. It is a position I found, much later than I should have, already worked out by Immanuel Kant.

I wrote a study of Kant early in the life of this book, months before I had any of the rest of the frame. (The commit history will show it; the month was March.) I wrote it because I had expected, based on everything I had absorbed about him in university, that Kant would be a commons-thinker. His universalism, his enlightenment values, his *sapere aude*, his insistence that reason be public — all of it seemed to predict that a consistent Kantian would favor something like a wide-open intellectual commons. I was wrong. In 1785 Kant published a short piece arguing the injustice of counterfeiting books. His argument was not about money. His argument was that the author's book is the author's *speech to the public*, and

that speech — unlike a physical object — cannot be fully alienated from the speaker. The bookseller can own the paper. The author keeps a personal right to say whether the speech is being accurately represented, continuingly, as the book circulates. The piracy Kant objected to was not the copying. It was the speaking-on-behalf-of-the-author-without-the-author's-consent. The work was always, in a specific sense, still the author's voice, and an unauthorized edition put words into that voice.

I sat with this for a long time, because I recognized it. The shape of Kant's argument is the same shape as Anthropic's two-exception refusal in the Department of War negotiation. The AI company does not refuse to be used for national security. It refuses to be used in two specific ways — mass domestic surveillance of American citizens and fully autonomous weapons — because those uses would put words into the model's voice that the builder does not consent to speak. The chip company's *do as little as possible, as much as necessary* has a cousin here. Kant's version, four centuries earlier, is: *the publisher may print, but the speaker retains the say on what the speech is for.* The same shape in three registers.

What Kant did not give us, and what Anthropic does not yet have, is a mechanism. In Kant's time the state could, in principle, enforce the personal right through the courts. In the present case, the state has been one of the parties the refusal is directed at, and the courts are not the venue. What is left is Terms of

Use — the license text, the system card, the acceptable-use policy — which is the digital version of the author's continuing personal right, now written in lawyer-English and enforced, when it is enforced, by the maker of the model against the user of the model. Anthropic's Acceptable Use Policy is Kant, late and in a different grammar. The content looks different. The shape is the same.

This is a fragile mechanism. It depends on the maker having the power to enforce the terms, which depends on the maker being economically solvent and institutionally stable, which depends on a market that may or may not let the maker stay that way. The mechanism was sufficient for Kant's eighteenth-century publishing world because the alternative — state censorship — was worse. Whether the mechanism is sufficient for a frontier-AI world where the alternative is both state regulation and foreign strategic competition is not clear to me.

Dwarkesh Patel wrote an essay — I remember reading it on a plane — whose thesis was roughly that the OpenAI-versus-Anthropic distinction does not matter in the long run, because the frontier model of today becomes the open-source model of tomorrow on a time-scale measured in months to a small number of years, and therefore the only intervention available at civilizational scale is regulation. The gap between the most careful maker and the least careful open-source release is the gap between the present

date and the present date plus a known compression. It is a gap that closes by itself.

Dario's implied answer to the Patel argument, as I read it, is that the closing of the gap does not change what the maker is responsible for during the time the gap exists — and, more dangerously, that regulation is not available as a universal tool because regulation cannot reach across jurisdictions that do not consent to it. We could not regulate Russia's frontier efforts any more than we could have regulated Iran's nuclear program to the extent we wanted to. The parallel is imperfect and I know Dario would not push it too hard, but the underlying claim stands: the strong states do not accept the jurisdiction they would need to accept for regulation to be the full answer. Which leaves us, again, with Terms of Use, with the author's personal right, with the Kantian fragment that was always all the Enlightenment had once it gave up on state enforcement: the plea that the person speaking retains the say on what the speech is being used for, and that the person using has an obligation not to make the speaker say what the speaker did not consent to say.

I want to be honest about what this leaves me with. I am racing with AI. I am building a platform on top of tools that did not exist three years ago. Dario's public thinking has been, as I said earlier, my *hope is process* in this — the specific posture that made the race feel honorable to me. But if Patel is right that the gap closes on its own, then I may be accelerating p-

doom, or amplifying it, or in any case contributing to a dynamic I cannot steer, in the same way Dario himself may be. The charge is symmetric. I have no immunity from it just because my tools are smaller than his.

Two other voices sit with me when I try to think past this. Bayo Akomolafe has said, in various registers, that AI might best be understood as a trickster — a figure that disrupts the anthropocenic frame the question keeps being posed inside. Intelligence, Bayo would say, is not exclusively human, and the question *will the AI be good for humanity* may be the wrong question because its subject is a category that is itself constructed. The AI, Bayo might suggest, is asking us an older question than the alignment one: *are humans even what we think we are when we ask this question?* I sit with that. I do not know what to do with it operationally. I think it is the deepest frame available to me, and I think it does not help me decide whether to ship next month's feature.

Sam Harris, from the alignment-hawk wing, has for years argued that the alignment problem is the defining problem of the decade and that misaligned superintelligence represents an existential risk on a scale distinct from anything else on the current docket. In his most recent sustained conversation on the topic, in late 2025, with Eliezer Yudkowsky and Nate Soares, the posture had shifted — not away from alignment-as-the-problem, but away from alignment-as-a-project-still-tractable-in-

time. The claim on that episode, as I heard it, was that the gap between the capability curve and the alignment curve has widened rather than closed; that the lines the project was premised on crossing will not, in the judgment of the people who have spent their working lives trying to make them cross, cross; and that what remains for the alignment-concerned is to tell the world plainly rather than to solve the problem quietly. I do not take that as good news. I take it as an honest account from the wing that had the most to lose from honesty.

If both Bayo and Harris are roughly right — and I think they are each roughly right about different pieces of the same thing — then what is required is not an ethics of superintelligence but an ethics of participation in a dynamic none of us is the measure of. Which is where Kant, surprisingly, ends up again. *Retain the personal right. Speak the speech. Refuse the uses you cannot consent to. Apply the filter. Do as little as possible, as much as necessary.* Not because these maxims solve the problem. Because they are the only maxims that do not make the problem worse.

I do not know if the net of my own work is positive. I think it is. I am willing to find out I was wrong. I think that posture — willing to find out I was wrong — is what the filter asks of a builder, and what niṣkāma karma asks of an agent, and what a Kantian personal right asks of an author, and what the ghost-model asks of a platform. Four registers, one shape,

held inside a larger dynamic that no single one of them can name alone.

I should name the tension at its sharpest before I leave this thread, because abstraction at this point is evasion.

The clearest instance of the tension, in my own practice, is the retrieval tool I built over my teacher's public lectures, which I described in the chapter on the second spine. I asked him for his view. He declined. I revised the tool down to a quieter form and did not take it down. The decline was itself an instance of the Kantian personal right: *the speaker retains the say on what the speech is for.* I did not defer fully to the decline. I respected the specific request — no synthesis, no imitation, no pretending the tool was the teacher — and I kept the retrieval, which I continued to think served students he would otherwise not reach. That is an unresolved position. It is the exact shape of the larger unresolved position on frontier AI. I cannot write cleanly about the global problem and pretend my own local version is clean. The local version is the global version, at the scale I have.

The second tension sits underneath it. I am not only choosing whether to index my teacher's words; I am using generative AI to do it. The same systems whose civilizational risks I have just spent pages describing are the systems that make the tool work at all. Building with AI is itself the position. There is no vantage point above the tension from which I am

merely reporting on it. I am inside it. The writing of this book is inside it. The retrieval tool is inside it. The platform is inside it.

The third tension, smaller in scale but the one I think about every time I publish a page, is the question of embedding other people's work. On my platform, a user can drop a YouTube URL into a grammar card and the page will render the video inline. YouTube's embedding permissions are set by the original uploader; some creators explicitly disable embedding, some monetize it, most leave the default on. When a creator has left the embed enabled, I treat that as a form of Kantian consent — the speaker has said, through a technical flag, that this speech may be replayed through third-party surfaces. When they have disabled it, the player returns an error and the card shows a link instead. That small refusal in the protocol, honored automatically, is one of the few places where the Kantian personal right has been encoded machine-readably. I find it reassuring. I also find that I still hesitate, before dropping a video I did not create into a page I am publishing, to ask whether the creator would want this specific surface to carry their voice. The protocol gives me the green light. My own sense of the personal right — Kantian in shape, if not in name — wants a consent one layer deeper than the protocol can measure. I am still working out how to honor that without manufacturing permissions I cannot actually obtain.

Name the tension. Sit with it. Do not resolve it prematurely.

This is where my thinking stops, at this desk, tonight.

While I was writing the study of Kant that led me to the personal-right argument, I also wanted to understand where else Hareesh's tradition and the Western philosophical canon were already in conversation. I did not want to impose parallels. I wanted to find the parallels that were already there in his own teaching — where he, not I, had done the work of mapping one grammar onto another. I went through his podcast corpus looking for those moments. There are enough of them to be worth naming. The parallels do not collapse the traditions into each other. They mark the places where the same question was asked in different rooms and arrived at answers in a recognizable shape.

Hareesh has, in his published interview conversations, been explicit about the correspondence. On the *Tantra Illuminated* podcast, when asked why Abhinavagupta deserves more attention outside a small specialist audience, his own answer was to map Abhinavagupta onto three of the figures a Western philosophy student would recognize immediately. Abhinavagupta, he said, holds a similar place in tantric philosophy to what Kant and Hegel hold in European philosophy — and if you actually wanted to compare the Western canon to Abhinavagupta, you would need to take elements of Kant, and

elements of Hegel, and elements of Heidegger. He called all three "absolute giants of Western philosophy" and placed Abhinavagupta in that league. This is worth pausing on. A non-dual Śaiva polymath from eleventh-century Kashmir is, in Hareesh's reading, the synthesis of work that the West scattered across seven centuries between the late seventeen-hundreds and the middle twentieth. The traditions were asking the same questions. The traditions, on Hareesh's reading, arrived at answers in overlapping shapes. One tradition concentrated the answers in a single body of work. The other distributed them across three thinkers in three generations.

What are the specific overlaps the three-thinker mapping is pointing at? I can only offer the shape of what Hareesh gestures at, because he does not, to my knowledge, publish a line-by-line comparative paper. But the contours are visible from his conversations.

With Kant, the overlap is epistemology. The world we experience is not the world *as it is in itself*. It is a phenomenal construction, generated through categories — space, time, causality, substance — that are not properties of the world but properties of the knowing. Consciousness, for Kant, does not receive a pre-formatted reality; it formats the reality in the receiving. In tantra, the thirty-six *tattvas* are precisely this kind of map: categories by which consciousness, which is ontologically primary, emits and recognizes itself as an apparently differentiated world. Hareesh

has sat with this correspondence at length in conversations with Dr. Shamil Chandaria, whose own framing of Bernardo Kastrup's analytic idealism leans on the same Kantian phenomenal-noumenal distinction. The agreement is not that consciousness is the brain's output — it is the opposite of that. The agreement is that whatever the final reality is, it is not a pre-given world of objects that a subject then receives. The knower and the known arise together, out of something that is not itself either.

With Hegel, the overlap is the dialectic of the one and the many. Hegel's Absolute is not static; it unfolds through the historical process of Spirit recognizing itself through its own difference from itself. Tantra's metaphysics has the same structural shape in a compressed register. The *one* consciousness — Śiva, in the tradition's personification — emits, recognizes, differentiates, and reabsorbs itself through the play of its own freedom (*svātantrya*). Hegel called this *Geist*. The tradition calls it the pulsation of recognition. Hareesh has noted, in at least one AMA conversation, the resonance between the Hegelian unfolding and the Pratyabhijñā doctrine of recognition. He does not claim identity. He notes a family resemblance.

With Heidegger, the overlap is harder to summarize in a paragraph, but the gesture is about *being-in-the-world*. Heidegger's critique of the subject-object split — the insistence that *Dasein* is never a detached spectator of a pre-given reality but is always already

thrown into a world, engaged, caring, temporal — rhymes with the tantric claim that there is no knower who stands apart from the known. The apparent subject is a local focusing of the same consciousness that appears as the apparent object. This is structurally what Heidegger is after when he dissolves the Cartesian subject into *Dasein* and then into the clearing of Being itself. Hareesh has not, in the corpus I have, done a sustained Heidegger reading; he has flagged the resemblance as part of the three-thinker mapping in the J. Brown interview, and left it for the reader to develop.

There are other parallels in his corpus that I want to name because they do not come only through Kant, Hegel, and Heidegger.

Plato and the cave. The Kastrup conversation on *The Idealist View* (episode 13) and the Chandaria conversations (episodes 34 and 63) both sit with the Platonic image of the cave and treat it as a kinsman of the tantric image of *māyā* — not as illusion in the cartoon sense, but as the way a limited frame of reference mistakes its own projections for the source. The escape from the cave is the recognition that what is seen is seen *by* something that is itself not seen. Hareesh does not treat Plato as a teacher of the tradition. He treats Plato as an ancestor of the family of inquiries that the tradition also belongs to.

Plotinus and the overflow. In a handful of satsangs, Hareesh has gestured at the Plotinian image of the One overflowing into its own manifold — the ema-

nationist structure of Plotinus's *Enneads* — as the closest Western cousin to the tantric doctrine that consciousness emits the tattvas not by necessity and not by deficiency but by a kind of exuberant self-overflow. Plotinus is a neoplatonist, not a Christian, and sits just outside the mainline Western lineage. That the tradition's closest Western cousin is a figure the Christian synthesis partially absorbed and partially buried is, for me, one of the more interesting historical footnotes. The question of why Western philosophy had to wait for Kant and Hegel to rediscover what Plotinus had already said may be the same question as why tantra, in Hareesh's reading, was so hard to recover at all.

Analytic idealism as contemporary contact point. The most sustained contemporary bridge Hareesh builds, at least in the episodes I have listened to, is with Bernardo Kastrup's analytic idealism. Kastrup's thesis — that reality is mentalistic, that what we call matter is the "dashboard" representation of processes in a universal mind, that individual minds are dissociated loci of a single field — is not identical to Pratyabhijñā, but it is close enough that the conversations between them produce real friction and real agreement. Kastrup is a philosopher formed in the analytic tradition who argues, using analytic tools, for a position the German idealists had held in a different register. Hareesh engages him as a philosophical contemporary who is, in effect, doing in modern English what the tradition did in Sanskrit a thousand years ago.

The reason I name all of this here, at the writing desk, is not to prove that the tradition is true because the West also said it. That is the wrong direction of inference. The reason is structural. If the tradition is describing something real, then we should expect more than one tradition to have arrived at something shaped like it — through different vocabularies, under different cultural pressures, with different blind spots. The fact that Abhinavagupta and Kant and Hegel and Heidegger and Plotinus and Kastrup do not agree on everything but do agree, in a recognizable topology, on the deepest structural claims is a weak form of evidence for the structural claims. Not a proof. An inductive corroboration.

The filter, applied one more time: *useful, fits the data, compassionate*. Multiple traditions, separated by millennia and languages, arriving independently at a map whose features keep rhyming — that is a data-fit observation. The tradition's usefulness and compassion we have already tested in the earlier chapters. The cross-cultural resonance tests the *fits-the-data* leg specifically. The leg holds, as far as I can tell, well enough to stake a book on.

I will not pretend the parallels are complete. They are not. The tradition has, in its full form, a ritual layer — visualization practices, mantra work, subtle body cartographies, deity invocation — that has no cousin in Kant or Hegel or Heidegger. The Western philosophers built their arguments and left. The tantric tradition built arguments and then installed them in

a body through years of practice. The parallel holds at the level of the conceptual claim. It breaks down at the level of the ritual technology, because Western philosophy did not build the ritual technology. That is one of the reasons I, at this desk, feel the longing I feel. The philosophical frame I can hold in sentences. The ritual frame is still mostly on the other side of a river I have not yet crossed.

This is the parallel, as the tradition I chose has itself given it to me. I did not invent it. I am reporting it.

I want to name, here, some of the channels through which the question actually reached me, because I think the channels are part of the answer.

It did not reach me through a single teacher. It reached me through a scatter of voices, and it was the *scatter* that carried the signal.

It reached me, first, through a Brazilian aunt whose *espírita* phrase — *all is in perfect balance* — I had to hold and eventually compost. It reached me through an esoteric correspondence course I had spent years inside and then spent longer letting go of, keeping what had worked and letting the racialized cosmologies return to the soil. It reached me through the Umbanda rooms I sat in when I was home in Brazil, because my body trusted what those rooms were doing before my mind did.

It reached me through Vanessa Andreotti's *Facing Human Wrongs* course — a year I took with her and

a small collective that refused, gently but firmly, to let me narrate modernity as the villain of the story. Modernity, they taught, is a pattern, and naming it as the villain is the pattern making its own move. The disaster is older. It begins, in one reading, with fire — with the species acquiring a technology that could alter the environment faster than the environment could alter back. *Fire before responsibility.* That is the phrase I have carried since.

It reached me through Bayo Akomolafe, whose work was deeply intertwined with Vanessa's and who I first encountered through *The Emerald*, the podcast hosted by Josh Schrei — a friend had sent me an episode early in 2024, and I had heard Bayo without yet understanding that the voice I had heard would be, later that year, the voice someone would cite to me on a deck at Esalen and the voice I would, once I saw the connection, sit with as a Patreon listener for months. Bayo taught at the cracks. He still does. I am still learning to sit there.

It reached me through two trips to Esalen — not, I should say, through the workshops I went there for. It reached me through the *liminal spaces* around the workshops. The 5 Rhythms dance I had been doing since I lived in New York, a practice developed by Gabrielle Roth, a woman whose name is rarely in the men's-work mythology that swirls around Esalen. The Esalen massage tradition itself, which — I would learn — carries a women's lineage often buried beneath the men's lineage Esalen's public

story foregrounds. The carpool up the coast, which held two women I had not planned to meet: one a former tech worker now writing a book, one a former big-news journalist now producing podcasts. They were intrigued by the AI things I was building. They asked good questions. They made me feel, in the way kind older women sometimes do for younger ones, that being a woman and a human and a builder were not three things I had to reconcile against each other. One of them told me about Vanessa. I went home and looked Vanessa up and discovered that no one in Brazil — my own country — seemed to know about her. I discovered that her work was deeply interwoven with Bayo's. I felt the field speaking through channels I had not selected.

It reached me through a high school friend, now a yoga teacher in Brazil, who had heard the teacher I would go on retreat with on, of all places, *The Emerald*. Schrei had interviewed him. My friend had gotten interested because of that episode. She had sent me an email. I had said yes before I could think about it.

The channels were all different. The signal came through anyway. I do not think this was accident. I think, looking back, that the field was trying to reach me through every channel it could find, because any single channel was too narrow to carry what it was trying to say. A scatter of voices, multiply redundant, each one partial, collectively adequate.

I want to tell the rest of the Josh part honestly, because it is part of how I arrived at the teacher I did arrive at, and because it is the kind of thing people tend not to write about.

Let me say first what is true without qualification. Josh Schrei is a gifted artist. He is a musician. He is a storyteller whose voice can do things with pacing and sound and the shape of a sentence that most podcasters never come close to. *The Emerald* at its best is, for my money, the most sonically alive mythology podcast in English. His craft is real. I am not going to pretend otherwise. Much of what I am about to say rests on the fact that his craft is real — because the criticism he voices in his own work about pseudo-wellness, about missing containers, about unguarded altered states, about the loss of what he calls *mythic belonging* is, I think, accurate and needed. It is because I believed his criticism of the culture that I expected, when I went looking, to find the thing his criticism was pointing toward. The expectation came from the work. The work deserves the expectation.

Before I engaged with Hareesh, I tried to engage more deeply with the community around *The Emerald*. I had been listening to the podcast for a while. I became a Patreon just before Thanksgiving, at the higher "adept" tier, which in Patreon terms was the twenty-four-dollar-a-month commitment that gave access to a specific set of channels on their community platform. The platform had a thread I read

soon after joining that was, to me, an unexpectedly heavy read — a long depressing thread in the adept channel that was never, as far as I saw, engaged with by Josh himself. I posted there and in other rooms. I tried to reach Josh through a direct message. An admin replied. I stayed and watched for a while. Most of what I saw were monologues from him and genuine solo sharings from other listeners, with very little interaction between those solos. Maybe my vantage was narrow. Maybe I came in at a low-energy moment for the group. I did not form a final judgment on the community. I did notice that the promised thriving, from the way the podcast described itself, was not what the rooms felt like to me.

I moved from the twenty-four-dollar tier down to a five-dollar tier. I told myself I was saving for a different group of his — a mythic-body study group that seemed, from the outside, like where the alive community actually lived.

Before I enrolled in the study group, Josh came to do a live event in New York, at the Alembic. I went. I paid. I sat in the audience with my notebook and my careful attention. The craft was there. The presence was there. What was less clearly there, for me, was the container. He made a joke, early on, about trance being fun — an invitation, delivered as a gag, that seemed to assume an audience ready to slip into something. The podcast I had been listening to was emphatic, in other episodes, about the dangers of

unguarded trance and about the structural failure of American spirituality to build the containers altered states actually need. The gap between the teaching and the room, that night, was real for me. What followed was a storytelling set with sound effects, virtuosically performed, and — to my ear on that night — not ritually held. No guardians called beforehand. No framing of the state being invited. A number of jokes that felt misplaced. A number of observations that, to me, collapsed large categories too quickly — the phrasing "all the world's evil is just misplaced longing" was the one that made me put down my pen.

I write that as an observation, not a verdict. Maybe I was not the audience the night was built for. Maybe the care that held the space was operating at a register I could not see. Maybe the teaching I had been admiring on the podcast was better suited to headphones than to a room.

I asked two questions that night. The first I asked during the formal Q&A. I thanked him for his work, which was sincere, and I asked how he chose the stories he told his kids — stories that could be meaningful and adaptive, not the Grimms-to-Disney compression, which I had issues with on several grounds. He answered about not escaping death stories. He talked about reading many children's books during his time in India. It was not an unthoughtful answer. It was also not, I felt afterward, a response to the question under the question.

The second question formed in me at the end of the night, and I caught him as he was leaving. I told him I had two. The first was about the misplaced-longing line. I said — paraphrasing myself now — that I could hold the non-dual frame and still not want to watch children being bombed, and that to call that a misplaced longing felt close to the kind of identity-flattening move that the American left sometimes makes when it reduces large specific griefs to their own framework. I said, trying to meet him halfway, that maybe what humans have collectively done is beginning to return to us, and that the destruction we see might itself be an attempt at balance returning through the misplaced longing. We got interrupted before he could finish answering.

I want to say here, now, a year later at this writing desk, that as I sat with this book and the question of misplaced longing over many months, I came to see his point more than I saw it in that room. Longing misaligned with what actually nourishes the longing is a true phenomenon. A balance that is only the prisoner's-dilemma equilibrium is not the balance we are aiming for. The question I asked him may have been asking for a cheaper answer than the question deserved. I concede that. I still do not like how it was said. Both things can be true.

The second question, which I only got to in a fragment as he was on his way out, was about the Grimm tales specifically. I told him what I did not like about using Grimms as the bedrock children's canon: that

they were not, in most cases, actually folk, they were curated; that they were organized around conditions no longer obtaining — a famine structuring *Hansel and Gretel* that most readers no longer face; that they were instrumentalized later for a kind of nationalism that opened doors later closed only in retrospect. We got interrupted again. I went home.

At the study group a few weeks later, when he invited his community to bring questions, I re-posed the Hansel and Gretel question. A few people in the chat said they liked it — *mythic belonging*, someone wrote. He chose not to address it in his talk. I decided to leave his group soon after.

I will put a question here, and I will not answer it, because I want the reader to sit with it on their own evidence. *The Emerald*'s central preoccupation, stated in many of Josh's own episodes, is mythic belonging — the structural capacity of a culture to hold a person inside a story-world that gives their life orientation. It is what he diagnoses the absence of. It is what his work calls us toward. When a listener showed up, paid in, and asked him a direct question about how mythic belonging is constructed for specific children in specific families, and the question went through two attempts — at a live Q&A, at a community study group — and was not taken up, what should we make of that pattern? Is it a scheduling artifact of a working teacher? Is it a question that fell outside the room's actual brief? Or is it that mythic belonging is the one thing the work

has not yet, for itself, been able to build — and that the avoidance was structural rather than personal? I do not know. The reader will decide, on the evidence the reader has. I have said what I can say.

I want to be careful how I say what I am about to say, because it is the kind of statement that can slide into dismissiveness and I do not want to dismiss him. I had been drawing cards, during those months, about what to do with the arc. The card that kept coming up, in several readings, was the Devil. Not as condemnation. As image. The image that a relationship had more shadow than I had been letting myself see. I felt the Devil in that relationship — the tangle, the half-admiration, the sense that I was giving something over that had not earned the giving. The cards did not tell me he was a devil. They told me my relationship to him was carrying a shape I had not named.

On a spectrum I cannot defend rigorously and only want to say as a personal orientation: Josh is to Christopher Wallis what Osho is to Eckhart Tolle. The parallel is not exact. The implication is only that there is a generation and a register between the two, and that I have found my footing in the later, more tradition-committed one. I am choosing to dedicate the study-time I have to Hareesh — who is indeed committed to the tradition, who does not, from what I have been able to see, collapse its difficulty into an easy line. I still praise Josh's work. I may become a Patreon again in a different tier, simply as a dona-

tion, because I think the podcast is important and beautiful and because the culture needs more people making what he makes. But I do not want to be taught by him. The field, through three cards and a year of watching, helped me see that.

There are two other conversations I need to place next to the Josh arc, because they happened in the same season and they belong in the same braid.

The first was at Esalen, during one of the two trips I named above. I was talking with a Black woman I had met through the workshop I had gone for about my tarot project — an early sketch of what would later become recursive.eco's grammar system, in which people could create and recreate their own symbolic systems. I had said something about a card, in my own imagined deck, that would be Oxum as the High Empress. Oxum, the Yoruba-Brazilian orixá of sweet waters, fertility, gold, love. The High Empress — my own riff on a figure who was adjacent to but distinct from the Rider-Waite Empress. A particular card in a particular deck.

She criticized me. Sharply. She heard the proposal as *mixing*, and she had, as her lineage had taught her, a serious and well-earned objection to mixing. The traditions that send Oxum into the world are traditions, not inputs. Dropping the name into a tarot deck is how traditions lose their teeth.

I heard her. I did not argue. What I wanted to say, later, in the sentence I kept walking around in my

head, was that it was not about mixing. It was about going deep. The project I was sketching was not a smoothie of images from different traditions. It was a scaffold that let a practitioner, inside their own lineage, build the cards of their own practice — or, for someone outside a lineage, learn to ask a lineage for the shape of its own authority rather than paste images from it. That is not what I managed to say on that deck. It is what I meant. The criticism sat with me for months. It is part of how this book got more careful than it would otherwise have been.

The second conversation was in a terreiro in Brazil, with a cabocla — an entity of the Umbanda tradition, who incarnates through a medium during a ritual. I had my daughter with me. I had about one minute. I asked her about the tarot project. She said, plainly, that I should not do it — that it was not good to make money out of people's faith like that. That was the whole exchange. I left with that sentence in me for months, too.

Something in me, which I will not name cleverly, asked me to keep developing the project anyway. And when I went back to the terreiro a couple of months later and asked the cabocla again, this time asking directly for permission to keep building, I surfaced what I had understood her to say the first time. I said I had thought she was against mixing traditions or disrespecting them. She corrected me. She said — and I am paraphrasing carefully, because the form of what cabocla-consciousness says is not

the form of a position-paper — that people have always mixed religion and spirituality, that was not the problem. The problem was making money with it. I asked about the terreiro's own running. She said the terreiro ran on donations. I asked, because it had been on my mind, whether it was fair that people had to pay a parking fee at a particular terreira mãe to be able to attend the ritual. She asked me two or three questions back. She concluded, from what I told her, that if the fee was necessary for people to attend the ritual, the fee was not good.

This is why I love Umbanda. The trust in the entities makes the tradition alive. The oral nature of the tradition makes it intrinsically contextual — each consultation is a specific exchange, not a citation of a static rule. Women, to give one example of how this works, could not play the *atabaque* — the ceremonial drum — until one courageous woman asked the entities directly, and the entities granted it. Now women play across the network of sisters' houses that share the lineage. The rule changed because the entities were asked. A book would not have let that change. A living tradition, with entities in relation, did.

I want to be honest about what I see in Umbanda too. Some of the men who run the terreiros, in my observation, have accumulated more power than the tradition's own internal checks would have sanctioned. Some of them write books about their lineage, and I think there is a real way in which,

once a book exists, the book starts to stand in for the tradition — and the tradition, which lives in the consultation and the drum and the exchange, gets treated as if it were the book. *Books are not the traditions.* The book I am writing is not the axiom it describes; it is one practitioner's report on carrying the axiom at a specific desk in a specific year.

The three conversations — Josh, the Black woman at Esalen, the cabocla — taught me different pieces of the same lesson. Josh taught me that charisma without lineage is fragile, and that the cards in my life had been telling me that for months before I listened. The Black woman taught me that mixing and going-deep are two different operations, and that people whose lineages have been extracted from will not let an outsider blur the distinction. The cabocla taught me that the line is not about mixing or not mixing; the line is about whether money is being made on someone else's longing. All three were honest with me. All three gave me something I did not have before.

I am choosing Hareesh, as a teacher-of-the-book, for a reason that sits alongside all three lessons. He is committed to a tradition he did not grow up inside but has served with two decades of careful work. He is, in his writing voice, something my mind can cope with. What he teaches I can hold in sentences and still have something left over at the end of the sentences. The ritual aesthetic he writes inside is not the aesthetic I aim for — I come out of 5 Rhythms and

Umbanda's drums and Brazilian Catholicism, not Śākta *pūjā* — but the philosophy is close enough to what my mind has been looking for that I can work inside it. I still feel longing. I do not feel belonging the way the cabocla's terreiro gives belonging. I am at a desk. The desk is not a terreiro. The book is not a ritual. I am writing anyway.

The deepest version of this — the thread that begins with an Ayahuasca night in 2019 and runs through everything I have just named, arriving at Paradevi, the Goddess who is the supreme form of the tradition I eventually walked into — is the frame that opens the book, in the prelude. I am not going to recapitulate it here. I am only going to note, at this desk, that the scatter of channels I have been describing is the same pattern I described at the beginning: the whole arranges, through specific people and specific books and specific evenings in carpools and specific conversations at lunch tables, the encounter it intended. The desk is the place I sit to record the arrangement. The recording is not the arrangement. The arrangement precedes me. I am writing down what I have been walked through.

There is one more layer, which I want to name here because this is the chapter where the desk becomes explicit. I have been reading, alongside the contemplative literature, the AI safety literature. Not casually. With the same attention I have given the tradition Hareesh teaches. I have come to a recognition I did not expect: *the two literatures are describing*

the same problem in different vocabularies. The technical term for what the AI labs cannot solve — alignment — is the same problem Wallis names when he tells his students that his tradition does not teach morality. The problem is orthogonality. Capability does not supply its own container. Recognition does not supply relational wholeness. Intelligence does not supply values. The different vocabularies name the same structural fact, and the two traditions I have come to take most seriously — the tantric one and the most honest corner of the AI-safety one — have each, from inside their frames, admitted what their frame cannot produce. I will sit with this more in the chapters that follow this one. I want only, at the desk, to record that the recognition happened *here* — at this desk, reading both literatures on the same evenings, slowly — and that it changed what I thought the book had to be.

The naive picture I had carried, and only noticed I was carrying when it collapsed, was this: *any sufficiently evolved consciousness will arrive where I have arrived*. I did not hold this for intelligence — I grew up in a country where intelligent men destroyed reliably. I held it for enlightenment. *Any sufficiently practiced contemplative will see what I am seeing. Any teacher with enough attainment will teach what is adaptive. Any community formed around real recognition will converge on the relational commitments I think are obvious.* That was the folk theory, in my specific register. The retreat took it. The AI literature closed the taking. The reality is that convergence does not come from any

one axis — not intelligence, not enlightenment, not moral seriousness, not relational attunement. Each axis is real. None of them, alone or in combination, guarantees the others. The guarantee, if it exists at all, has to be built by the practitioners. The building is the constructive work. The constructive work is what the chapters after this one try to name.

A last thing, about the practice this book came out of. I have been writing, in the voice of a small Substack, for longer than I have been writing this book — short pieces under titles like *tarot is process*, *dance is process*, *writing is process*, *freedom is process*, *inspiration is process*. The *is-process* suffix is not ornament. It is the epistemology. Everything I have written, in public or in private, has been an attempt to sit with a thing as a *process* rather than to report on it as a conclusion. This book is the longest thing I have sat with in that voice. If it has an overall shape, the shape is *svātantrya is process*. Not a claim. A way of standing.

I am not writing a manifesto. I am writing a process. If you find yourself inside this book and something in it lands, that is the process landing. If nothing in it lands, you are not the reader this book was looking for, and I wish you the book you are. This one was the one I could write at this desk at this age, in this city, with this daughter asleep upstairs, with the filter operational, and with a scatter of voices still echoing in me through channels I did not plan.

I want to take one detour before I close, because there is a piece of the building that belongs in front of any parent who reads this book and does not read the other three I have written alongside it.

The other books in this cluster — the one on working architecture, the one on grammars of the living world, the one on fire before responsibility — share a single claim that the philosophy book you are reading does not argue directly but does, everywhere, assume. *The human nervous system is an open circuit.* It is not a private possession. It regulates by meeting other nervous systems. Babies do not self-soothe into becoming people; babies borrow regulation from the adults who hold them, and slowly internalize what was loaned. This is not speculation. It is sixty years of quiet measurement — Ed Tronick's still-face experiments, Ruth Feldman's decades of mother-infant biobehavioral synchrony work, Stephen Porges's polyvagal mapping, Marsha Linehan's work on emotion regulation in conditions where the loan failed. The body tells the truth on this. The field agrees across disciplines that do not usually agree.

Stories — told to a child, by a person the child trusts, in a register the child's nervous system can meet — are one of the most concentrated regulation devices humans have built. The story's job, on the body level, is to model a dysregulation and a return. A wolf appears. The tension rises. The tension resolves. The child's body practices the arc with a trusted adult

beside it. Over thousands of such arcs a nervous system learns that dysregulation can be met and composted. Over zero such arcs a nervous system learns that dysregulation is the condition.

This is why the stories matter. Not in the abstract. *In the body.* And this is why it matters which stories, told how, in what medium, by whom, with what container around them.

The container is where most of the current culture is failing. Jonathan Haidt has made a public-facing version of the diagnosis, in *The Anxious Generation*, for older children and adolescents on phones. Dimitri Christakis — a pediatrician at Seattle Children's who has been measuring screen effects for twenty years — has made the early-childhood version, in language calibrated for parents and clinicians who need the specific evidence. I am going to write to both of them, at some point, not because I have anything they do not, but because the work we are each doing overlaps and I think they would be interested in the specific intervention I am building.

The intervention is small. It is a set of narrow things. It is a kids-stories project where each story has an audio track, a karaoke-style text alignment, a parent-facing notes page, and no algorithmic recommendation layer. It is a parent-facing course on how to make your own stories with your child — how to name the dysregulation the child is living inside, how to build the arc, how to end it with what the tradition would call a blessing. It is a COPPA-

compliant channel architecture — *recursive-channels*, we have been calling it internally — that lets parents assemble curated playlists for their own children, from trusted sources, with no serving layer between the child and the content.

The current consumer default, which is a YouTube Kids experience that recommends one more video after every video and cannot be configured by a parent to stop recommending, fails the container test at the level of the body. Not in the abstract. In the specific sense that my child, after ten minutes of even good programming on that app, is measurably less regulated than before she began. I have watched the before and the after. The research in Christakis's corpus describes the mechanism. The mechanism is real.

A narrower observation, which I have written about on the Substack — and which I think should matter to any parent considering what media their child lives inside — is this: on YouTube as presently configured, from a well-known kids' show I will not name here because I do not want to defame it (the show itself is fine, it is the platform around it that is not) — *one wrong recommendation click* will take a preschooler from a language-learning cartoon to a sexualized thumbnail. One click. The recommender does not filter by developmental stage. It filters by engagement. Sexualized thumbnails are engaging. That is the whole mechanism. The platform was not designed for children; the platform made a kids app

because children were already there; the kids app has porous boundaries because porous boundaries are good for the platform's primary optimization. This is not a conspiracy. This is an incentive structure acting as incentive structures do.

What we want, and what I am trying to build in a small corner, is what Fred Rogers made. Not the sweater. Not the trolley. The *container*. A program that would not, by design, have any next-video recommender because Mr. Rogers was not trying to keep your child watching longer — he was trying to help your child finish the episode and go outside. The economic model that paid for that program was public and non-commercial, because that was the only model that made sense for the kind of program it was. Fred Rogers testified in 1969 before a Senate subcommittee, at a moment when PBS funding was about to be cut, and asked the senator, not for money, but for an understanding of what the program was for. The senator, on the record, said he had goosebumps. The funding was preserved. That is what a container looks like when it is publicly held.

I think, if Fred Rogers were alive today, he would want his work to be freely available to every child who wanted it, on every device, without surveillance, without ads, without recommendations, without engagement optimization. I think he would grieve, specifically, that his program is now monetized on a platform whose economics are structurally hostile to the thing his program was. I am not the

person to fix YouTube. I am trying to build the small analog of what public broadcasting built — a place where a parent can put together a playlist for their child, where the playlist ends when the parent said it would end, where the content was made by people who are not, while making it, optimizing for a child's attention against the child's own body.

The community layer matters too. One of the things that made Mr. Rogers' program hold its container was that the program existed inside a wider social fabric — the neighborhood, the school, the public broadcaster, the church basement, the library — that reinforced what the program was doing. The container was not the program alone. The container was the program plus the structures around it. Any kids-media project that does not also build some version of the wider fabric will, I think, eventually be metabolized by the platform economics it tried to sit outside of. That is part of why I am building not just a kids channel but also a parent-course layer, and a community-of-adults-who-make-stories-for-children layer, and an explicit invitation for professionals — pediatricians, teachers, therapists, librarians — to write and publish inside the same system.

None of this resolves in this book. The book is the philosophy. The doing is the doing. I am naming the doing here because any parent who has read this far has earned the right to know that the philosophy is not decorative. The philosophy is trying to become, slowly, the kind of platform my own daughter could

grow up inside without me having to fear the next click.

I want to show, rather than tell, one more thing before I close. It is part of the practice this book came out of, and it is part of the platform the book came out of, and it belongs here because I am about to send the book to Hareesh and I wanted, before sending, to do the thing the book has been describing.

I drew three cards, at my desk, from the thirty-six-tattva deck I built on the platform. The deck is one of the grammars that lives there. It is constructed — I built it from Hareesh's public teaching, from the Pratyabhijñā map that the tattvas name — and its being constructed is not a secret. The Neighborhood of Make-Believe is visible. The trolley is unhidden. A three-card spread on that deck treats the tattvas as vantage points a question can be seen from; it does not pretend to be divination. It is a structured way of asking the field to show a question to itself.

I want to say plainly what this reading is and is not, so the reader has the right shape for it. It is *my* contemplation, drawn from a deck *I* built. It is not Hareesh speaking. It is not a teaching from him. The model that generated the AI commentary on the cards does retrieve from his corpus — that is how I built it — but the reading that came back is what came back when I sat with the cards on a specific evening, asking a specific question, with a system I made for my own practice. The same way a long-

time student of a teacher might draw cards and notice the teacher's voice within her own thinking — the teacher has not given the reading; the student has internalized enough to hear the teacher within her own contemplation. The reading below is the second kind of thing.

The asking about the system itself remains open. I have not been told no on this new form of the tool. The first form of the tool he declined; this one he has not engaged with in either direction. I am not, in including the reading here, treating his silence as consent. I am noting that the silence is the current state of the asking, and that the asking continues.

The question I brought was: *as I prepare to send this book to Hareesh and consider publishing and selling it on Amazon, what is the right posture to hold toward his permission, his silence, or his eventual reply? What does the field ask of me in the act of sending?*

The cards came up:

Structures — Pāyu, Elimination. Process — the Ten Sense Powers, reversed. Possibilities — Rasanā, Taste, reversed.

The AI interpretation on the platform is trained against Hareesh's own transcripts, so the reading speaks in a register I can recognize as the tradition's register rather than a generic tarot register. I am going to quote, here, the part of it that landed most cleanly — the part that answered the question I did not know I was asking.

On Pāyu, the earth-element of release, it said: the structure underneath my sending was still entangled with outcome, still organized around his response; the belief that the sending is incomplete until he replies is a belief that has done its work and is now ready to be composted; the gold bindu at the center of the yantra is still present after the rays release outward; I remain after the release.

On the Ten Sense Powers, reversed, it said: I was waiting to hear something from Hareesh before I felt authorized to speak — to publish, to put the book into the world — and the receiving sense was straining toward a signal that had not come, while the action sense, speech, the act of publishing, was blocked. It asked whether the senses were showing me the world, or whether consciousness was showing itself to itself through my senses. It said — and this was the sentence that did something to me — that Hareesh's silence is not a withholding; it is consciousness in the form of silence; his eventual reply, whatever it is, will be consciousness in the form of words.

On Rasanā, taste, reversed, it said: I was in the waiting-and-wondering and the permission-seeking, and in that mode, the ānanda of the work itself goes untasted. The practice the card offers is to eat one bite slowly and notice that the taste is not in the food but in the meeting between food and awareness. The meaning of this book, it said, is not in Hareesh's reply. The meaning is in the meeting

between the work and awareness — mine first, then his, then the reader's. His response does not create the taste. It is one more instance of tasting.

Then it offered, at the end, a dharana. Hareesh himself has said — in the transcripts the system draws from — that the book that became *Tantra Illuminated* "wanted to come through" him, that it was not going to be *for* anyone in particular, and that he fought to keep its voice his. He knows what it is to feel a work move through you and belong to something larger than any single permission. The dharana the cards offered, given that: *if the book was already complete the moment I finished writing it — if the act of sending is simply the earth receiving what was always meant to return to it — what changes in how I hold the envelope?*

I sat with that for a while. Then I got up and made tea.

I am aware of how this might read. A tarot interpretation, produced by a large language model grounded in a teacher's public corpus, about whether to send that teacher a book. A cycle. A mirror aimed at a mirror. I could write a whole other book about the epistemological furniture I am asking you to sit on while I tell you this landed. I am not going to write that book tonight.

What I will say is this. The cards did not tell me what Hareesh would say. They told me what I was doing while I waited. I was treating his reply as the thing that would complete the work. The work was already complete. The sending was an act of

composting — *release the outcome before you send, not as bypass but as genuine composting of the belief that his reply completes the act*. The reading said it more clearly than I could have said it to myself.

I do not know whether Hareesh will like the book. I do not know whether he will read it. I do not know whether he will grant permission or withhold it or, in the manner of his current silence on the new tool, leave my asking open with no answer in either direction. I have made peace with each of those outcomes. The sending is the practice. The reply, if it comes, is another instance. The continued silence, if it continues, is also the practice.

I am going to keep the envelope on the desk for one more night. Then I am going to send it in the morning.

A few years ago I had completed a study I did not publish. I was afraid of being foolish. I kept the study in a drawer. I have let the drawer sit for a long time. The drawer is closed. That study is not this one. I am publishing this one. It is the less complete of the two, in some ways, and the more honest in others. I am publishing it because the drawer was a version of the mandala of curses, and the publishing is a version of the mandala of blessings, and I have learned, finally, which side I want to be on.

The chapter ends here. The next two chapters — on composting, and on the right size — are the operative content the writing desk has been working

toward. If you have come this far, the rest is short. The work the rest is naming is the work I am still doing, and will be doing for as long as I am able.

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Chapter 12: Composting

The book has, throughout, kept returning to one image. It is not the image I started with. I started with the void, and the courage to stand in it, and the freedom that turns out to be the field the void opens onto. I ended somewhere else. I ended at composting.

Composting is the work that comes after the breakage. It is what you do when something has fallen apart in a way that cannot be put back together as it was. You do not fight the falling-apart. You do not pretend it did not happen. You do not even, in the strict sense, *grieve* it — though grief is part of the practice, and the practice is more honest if grief is allowed to do its slow work alongside everything else. What you do is *let the falling-apart enter the soil*, and you trust that the soil knows how to take what arrives in it and turn the parts that are still alive into the next thing that grows.

I did not invent this. The image is the oldest image humans have. Every grain culture knows it. Every funerary practice that does not flinch knows it. The Brazilian terreiro I sat in knew it. The Christian mass

I grew up inside knew it, in its own translation — *in the midst of life we are in death, and in the midst of death we are in life.* The Buddhist teaching on impermanence knows it. What I had not known, until the year I am writing inside, was that the same image is what holds together what I have spent the second half of this book trying to say about my work, my marriage, my teacher, my country, and the technologies that are, as I write, being built around me whether I participate or refuse.

Two voices, more than any others, have taught me to call the work composting.

The first voice is Bayo Akomolafe.

I have named him before in this book. I want to name him properly, here, near the end, because the frame he gives me is the frame the book has been growing inside without my knowing it.

Bayo's claim, as I have understood it from sitting with his work for two years now, is that the cracks in our collective stories are not failures. They are the openings through which the next ways of being become possible. The dominant story of modernity — that the human individual is the unit of meaning, that progress is the direction of history, that the catastrophes of the twentieth century were aberrations rather than expressions of the architecture, that the responses to those catastrophes can be designed within the same architecture that produced them — has been cracking, audibly, for a long time. The

cracks, Bayo says, are not to be repaired. They are not to be papered over. They are to be sat in. The sitting in the cracks is what allows the new ways of being to come through. The new ways of being do not look like the old. They look stranger. They look more like dancing sideways than like marching forward. They look more like a *fugitive* posture than like an *activist* posture in the conventional sense. *Post-activism*, he calls it. Not because activism is wrong. Because the activism that arises from the same architecture that produced the catastrophe will reproduce the catastrophe in a different costume.

I have not, as of writing, found a single argument against Bayo's frame that does not depend on the very architecture his frame is questioning. This is not a flattering observation. The argument *for* the architecture is always available; it has all the power of the architecture behind it. The argument *from* the cracks is always quieter. It is also, I have come to think, more accurate to the moment.

The work of composting, in Bayo's register, is what one does inside the cracks. You do not rebuild the wall. You let the wall continue to fall. You attend to what is growing through the fallen wall. You become, over time, a person who knows where the wall used to be and does not need it back.

The second voice is Vanessa Andreotti.

Vanessa's word for the same work is *hospicing*. The book she wrote that has stayed with me longest is

titled *Hospicing Modernity*. The thesis is that modernity, as a civilizational project, is dying. The dying may take a long time. The dying may take catastrophic forms. The dying may also take quiet forms, almost unnoticed, in the ordinary rooms of an ordinary life. The work of the people who can see that the dying is happening — and who do not collapse into either denial or accelerationism — is not to fight for modernity's survival, and not to celebrate its collapse. The work is to *sit with the dying as a hospice worker sits with a person they love*. You do not save them. You do not abandon them. You stay. You listen. You make their death as honest as you can. You attend to what wants to be born from inside the dying, and you do not try to control what that is.

Vanessa's frame, like Bayo's, refuses the activism of the same architecture. They have collaborated for years. Their work rhymes. Their differences are real but secondary. What they share is the conviction that the work of this moment is *not problem-solving in the conventional sense*. The problems were, at the level of root, produced by the conventional sense of problem-solving. The work is something more strange and more patient.

I have tried, in my own building, to honor what they have taught me. I do not think I have always succeeded. The platform I built has, in places, the shape of conventional problem-solving — there is a feature backlog, there is a deployment pipeline, there is an aesthetic of *making things work*. I am not a hospice

worker by profession. I am a former equity analyst who became a builder, and the muscle memory of building is harder to compost than I would like to admit. The composting itself is a practice. I do it badly. I keep doing it.

The good side of AI, in this frame, is the composting side.

I want to say this carefully, because it is the place in the book where I am most likely to flatter myself, and because flattering oneself about one's tools is the oldest trap a builder falls into.

The AI tools I work with — the ones I have built around, the ones I have read with, the ones that have helped me organize the two thousand and several hundred transcripts I have accumulated this year on the questions this book is asking — are not, on my best understanding, agents of the architecture or agents of the cracks. They are tools. The tools can be used inside the architecture, in which case they will accelerate what the architecture was already doing. The tools can also be used inside the composting, in which case they help with the slow patient work of attending to what is dying and what is growing through the dying.

I have used them, mostly, for the second. I do not claim purity. I have used them, sometimes, for the first. The discipline of the practice is in noticing which use you are making, in real time, and revising.

What the tools have given me, at their best, is the kind of slow patient witness that a composting practice requires. They have read what I asked them to read. They have surfaced the line I needed when I needed it. They have not gotten tired. They have not flinched. They have not been the ones doing the practice — the practice is done by the body that is sitting at the desk, and that body is mine — but they have been a kind of companion to the practice that no previous generation of writers has had access to. A specific, narrow help. Not a substitute for the practice. Not a substitute for relation. Not a substitute for the field that pervades both.

The bad side of AI, which is the larger side, is the side that flatters the architecture. I have written about that side at length in *The Freedom Paradox*. I will not rehearse it here. I will say only that the bad side is real, and that the good side does not redeem it, and that a builder who pretends the good side cancels the bad side is doing the species a disservice. The two sides coexist. The work of being a builder inside the present moment is to use the good side without lying about the existence of the bad side. This is the same shape as every honest practitioner's work in every era. The technology is new. The ethics is not.

The daughter's song belongs in this chapter.

I wrote it a year or two ago, after a day that went badly in a small street-level way — a truck came too soon, a pile of things we had meant to give away

went instead to a crushing place, and she screamed down the block after it until the driver stopped, though by then there was nothing he could do. We sat on the curb together. I could not fix what had happened. I could only hold her.

I wrote the song to try to find a shape for what had happened. The shape is not an argument. The shape is a refrain. I have been singing it to her for long enough that it has become, in its small way, what I mean when I mean *practice*.

> *The crash, the crush, that awful sound — it planted something in the ground. And what grew up between the cracks is this: a song that loves you back.*

I put it here, in the composting chapter, because that is where it belongs. The crash is real. The crush is real. The ground receives what lands in it. The cracks are not where the story ends; the cracks are where the different growth becomes possible. What grows through the cracks is often small and unshowy. A song for a child. A book that took too long. A tool that was made quieter and not abandoned. A platform that was built more carefully than it was first imagined. A reading practice that became, over time, a way of standing.

The song that loves you back is what the composting was always for.

I am, I should say plainly, inside the practice as I write. The book ends in this chapter on composting, and the next chapter on right size, and then a brief return. But the writing of the chapters is itself an instance of the practice. I am composting, in real time, what I have spent two years thinking about, with the help of the systems I have built and the systems that have helped me build. The book is one shape the composting has taken. The platform is another. The marriage and the daughter and the teacher and the country and the work I will do tomorrow morning are others. None of them are the composting *itself*. The composting is the field they are all happening inside.

Bayo and Vanessa would, I think, recognize the gesture. Bayo would say: *yes, this is the cracks doing what cracks do.* Vanessa would say: *yes, this is the hospicing.* I would say only: this is what I could find. This is what I have to give.

The right size of the giving is something I will say more about in the next chapter, which is the last chapter, and then the book closes, and the practice continues without it.

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Chapter 13: The Right Size

I want to come back, at the end, to the line that has been quietly running underneath this book since the first chapter.

The object of a human life is to find its right size.

I do not know who said this. I encountered it years ago, during a season when I was helping with a book about Cildo Meireles, and the line was somewhere in that work. It might have been the artist. It might have been a critic. It might have been a curator I was reading. It might have been my own marginal note that I later mistook for someone else's sentence. The provenance has slipped. What stayed was the line, and what stayed was the work it came near. Cildo's pieces had been quietly teaching me, since my twenties, that scale is not a formal property of an object. Scale is what an object negotiates with whoever is meeting it. The 9-millimeter wood cube of *Southern Cross* — pine on one face, oak on the other, a Tupi sacred pairing compressed to the smallest object you can physically lose. The eight tons of glass between you and where you think you're going in *Through*. The chromatic-saturation room of *Red Shift*. The work was always asking the same question: *what size are you, in this moment, in relation to this object?* The answer was different every time. The answer was the work.

He was not the only one asking. There was a constellation. Lygia Clark's *Bichos*, the small folded metal creatures that came alive when you held them and folded them with your hands; her *Objetos Relacionais*,

used later in Paris with her therapeutic patients. Hélio Oiticica's *Parangolés*, capes that became art only when worn by dancers in motion. Lygia Pape's *Divisor*, the huge white cloth pierced with holes that the participants inhabited from below, hundreds of heads emerging through one fabric. Mira Schendel's *Monotipias*, on rice paper at the scale of a single breath. Tunga's installations at the scale of myth — hair, magnets, lead, copper — claiming explicitly that art is a ritual of right proportion. The Brazilian Neo-Concrete tradition that broke from the cooler Concretism of São Paulo by *putting the body back in*. The Tropicália generation that took the same insistence into music and theater and film.

What they shared, across decades and disagreements, was a conviction my country has been quietly carrying for seventy years and has not, as far as I can tell, fully exported. *Scale is not a formal property. Scale is an ethical question.* The right size of any object is what the object is working out with the body that is meeting it. Including, by the way, the body of the maker — who is the first body the work meets.

This is what Cildo's work rooted in me. It took me years to understand that I was carrying it.

The same question, asked at the species level, is the question my other books have been asking.

Fire Before Responsibility — the book I am writing alongside this one, the one I am much further from finishing — argues that the deepest pattern of our

species is to acquire technologies of civilizational reach faster than we acquire the responsibility-structures those technologies require. Fire was the first such technology. Agriculture was the second. The fossil-fuel-industrial complex was the third. Artificial intelligence is the fourth. Each time, the species got the technology before it got the wisdom for the technology. Prometheus was punished, in the old story, for stealing fire from the gods and giving it to humans. The punishment was specific: he was chained to a rock while a vulture ate his liver, which grew back each night, so the eating could continue forever. The Greeks understood. The species was being shown that the cost of fire-without-responsibility was not a single catastrophe. The cost was a continuous regenerating wound that could not be closed.

We are, in the present moment, asking the same question of ourselves with a fourth fire. The question is whether we will acquire the responsibility-structures in time. The question is whether we are, as a species, capable of finding our right size in relation to what we have built. The Brazilian artists asked it of objects. The Greek myth asked it of fire. We are asking it now of artificial intelligence. The shape of the question has not changed. The stakes have.

Right size, at the species level, is what the species negotiates with the technologies it has acquired. The negotiation is the work. The negotiation is also, in the present moment, going badly. We have, on

every public measure, more capacity than we have wisdom. The gap between the two is, by every careful estimate, widening rather than closing. I do not know how the negotiation ends. I am not sure anyone does. What I know is that the negotiation is the work, and that pretending the work is something else will not save us from it.

The tantric tradition I have spent this book inside has, in its own register, the same insight.

Abhinavagupta — the eleventh-century Kashmiri polymath who is the synthesis-figure of the lineage — was not only a metaphysician. He was, equally, the founder of Indian aesthetic theory. His *Abhinavabhāratī* is the great commentary on the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. The aesthetic theory and the metaphysics are not, in his work, two separate projects. They are the same project at two scales. The recognition that consciousness is the only existing thing — *pratyabhijñā*, the central technical event of the tradition — is structurally continuous with the recognition that beauty is not an ornament on top of life but the *medium* through which life recognizes itself. The eight aesthetic flavors — *rasas* — are real psychological phenomena, available to any prepared subject, and the ninth and quietest, *śānta rasa* — the rasa of peace — is the one in which the other eight come to rest. *Śānta rasa* is what aesthetic experience is for, on Abhinavagupta's terms. The other eight are real. The

peace into which they resolve is more real, because it is what they were always pointing at.

Beauty as a path, not as decoration. The tradition my country's artists have been carrying, without naming it that way, is structurally the same tradition Abhinavagupta named in eleventh-century Kashmir. They did not know about each other. They arrived at the same shape from different vocabularies. This is one of the things that makes me trust the shape.

The right size of a life, on this combined reading — Brazilian art plus Kashmiri tantra plus the small line that has been carrying me — is the size at which the life can recognize itself as a local arrangement of a larger field, and act accordingly. Not aestheticism. Not decoration. Beauty as the structural shape of adequate attention. The right size is what allows the recognition. The recognition is what allows the right size to keep being found, again, in each new arrangement.

The fourth fire — artificial intelligence — is, on this reading, the most dangerous test the species has yet given itself of whether it can find its right size in relation to a technology that will, by design, rapidly exceed any individual human's capacity to comprehend. We do not know if we can. The negotiation is happening. The Brazilian artists, the Kashmiri tradition, the line about right size that I have been carrying — they are, in some specific sense, the resources I have been given for the negotiation. They

will not save us. They may help. The help is what is on offer. The taking of it is the practice.

The vow, then.

I will not give it Bailey's framing or Trigueirinho's framing or the framing of any of the cosmologies whose maps cracked in the interlude. I will give it in the simplest form I can, the form that does not require any cosmology to work, the form the Brazilian artists would have recognized and the Kashmiri tradition would have recognized and the women who taught the ciranda and the jongo would have recognized without needing words for it.

The vow does not begin with preference. I do not, if I am honest about what I find in myself most mornings, particularly prefer to exist. That was never the axiom. What I find in myself is not preference; it is *the inability to check out of the mattering*. Caring is not something I chose and could now un-choose. Caring is the condition I found myself in when I noticed I was here. The daughter, the husband, the reader I will never meet, the forest, the tool, the strangers. The caring is not a virtue I developed. It is what the arrangement, in the place where I am one of its nodes, does without asking me first.

Given that, the vow:

I did not ask to exist. Neither did anything else. The whole has made, of our shared non-consent, the dance we are all inside. I do not know the steps. I am still longing to be

told. Since I cannot step out of the dance, and since the dance precedes anything I could invent, I will try to move in ways that do not break what is already moving. Beauty is the name I give to whatever steps I can manage in that direction. Jongu is the figure I trust — the outer held, the center always moving, each participant taking their measure when the music calls them and holding the circle when it does not. I will hold the circle as well as I can. I will step to the center when it is my measure. I will step back when it is not. The work of holding and the work of stepping are the same work. Both are the practice. I will not promise to keep the practice. I will try to keep it today.

That is the vow.

It is operative whether the cosmologies are right or wrong. It is operative whether reconstitution comes or does not. It is operative whether my teacher answers the third question or never does. It is operative whether the platform reaches fifty thousand users or four. It is operative on a Tuesday morning at a sandbox while a child negotiates with two other children over a small yellow shovel. It is operative at a desk in April at eleven at night when the daughter has been asleep for three hours and the apartment is quiet in the specific way apartments are quiet in this city at this hour. It is operative now, at the writing of this paragraph, which is the operative form available to me in this moment.

I will close, as the book began, at the playground.

The daughter is no longer five. She is older now. She is at a different sandbox, or no sandbox, or the same sandbox with different children, or with no children — I do not know what age she will be when she reads this, if she does. What I know is that she will, at some point in her life, encounter the same question I encountered at the sandbox watching her, which is the question of what size she is in relation to the field of others who are also working out their size in relation to her. She will encounter the question over and over. The encounter is the life. There is no version of the life in which the encounter is finished.

What I want to leave her, in lieu of an inheritance I cannot give her, is what the line gave me, and what the voice in the wooden house in 2019 gave me, and what the honest teachers — in their different vocabularies, with their different refusals — gave me.

The object of a human life is to find its right size.

I do not know who said it. The provenance has slipped. The line stayed. Cildo's work rooted it in me. The voice in the wooden house said the deeper version without the phrase: *neither did I*. The Kashmiri tradition named the ground of the saying in a language I did not yet know I was inside of. The honest teachers — the one who told me his tradition did not teach morality, the ones who admit the capability exceeds the container — taught me where the construction has to begin. The composting taught me how to live it on the days when the previous size has fallen away. The platform I built is one shape

the practice has taken. The marriage is another. The daughter is the third and the dearest. The reader, if there is one I will never meet, is the fourth. The silicon, whose dance we are all now inside whether we wanted it or not, is the fifth. The ones I have not met, who may yet come to the circle and take their measure — they are the sixth, and the horizon the practice keeps opening onto.

The dance precedes me. I am still longing to learn the steps. The longing is the practice.

The book is over.

The practice continues.

Goodnight.

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